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Ruth

Ruth 1:1

Section 1:1–5: Elimelech and his family went to Moab, where he and his two sons died

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This section contains the first main event of the story. An Israelite named Elimelech moved to the neighboring country of Moab with his wife, Naomi, and their two sons because there was famine in Israel. Elimelech died in Moab. His two sons later married women from Moab, Ruth and Orpah. Both of the sons then also died.

This section has two paragraphs:

Paragraph 1:1–2 gives an introduction. Verse 1 gives the setting of the story and introduces the main characters in this event.

Paragraph 1:3–5 describes the event in detail. Verse 1:5b summarizes the section that refers to Naomi but does not use her name.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi Loses Her Husband and Sons (NIV)

Naomi Widowed (ESV)

Elimelech and His Family Move to Moab (GNT)

The Move to Moab and Tragedy (GW)

It is important to translate this book in a way that indicates the story is true. Follow a natural way that storytellers in your language use to tell true events.

Paragraph 1:1–2

Verse 1:1 introduces the characters/participants in a general way that does not give their names. Verse 1:2 gives the name of each character. However, if this is not a natural way to introduce characters in your language, another option is to combine 1:1–2 and introduce the characters by name. For example:

¹⁻²Long ago, in the days before Israel had a king, there was a famine in the land. So a man named Elimelech, who belonged to the clan of Ephrath

and who lived in Bethlehem in Judah, went with his wife Naomi and their two sons Mahlon and Chilion to live for a while in the country of Moab. While they were living there... (GNT)

See 1:1–2 (combined/reordered) in the Display for another example.

1:1a

In the days when the judges ruled,

- ¶ In the days of the judges,
- ¶ Long ago, when leaders/chiefs governed Israel,

In the days when the judges ruled: The phrase that the BSB translates as days when the judges ruled is literally “in the days of the judging of the judges.” It refers to a time period of about three hundred years when judges ruled the country of Israel. After that time period, kings ruled the country.

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

- Make explicit the role/function of the judges.

In the days when the Judges were governing (NJB)

- Leave implicit the role/function of the judges. For example:

During the time of the judges (NET)

- Make explicit the location where the judges ruled. For example:

Long ago when the judges ruled Israel (NCV)

the judges: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the judges refers to the leaders or chiefs who ruled in Israel at that time.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

In the days when the chieftains ruled (NJPS)

During the time that leaders ruled/governed

the: The definite article the implies that the audience of this story already knew who the judges were. If this is new information to your readers, it may be better to translate “judges” without the definite article. For example:

During the time when judges ruled

ruled: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as ruled is literally “judged.” They judged by deciding what was right and what was wrong when problems were brought to them, and then they gave their decisions to the people involved. However, their activities were more varied than the activities of a judge in most cultures today. They also led the people to fight against any oppressors.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

governed (NASB)

led the people

1:1b

there was a famine in the land.

- there was a shortage/lack of food in the land of Israel.
- there was a time when people there did not have enough food to eat.

there was a famine: This clause means that there was not enough food for people to eat. In Hebrew, the word famine is also the word “hunger.” The verse does not give a cause of the famine. However, lack of rain was a common cause and is probably implied here. Lack of rain as the cause of the famine is suggested by ZIBBC (pages 244–245), ZECOT (page 64), and UBS (page 6). If your language requires you to give a reason for the famine, you can make explicit that this famine was the result of a lack of rain.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

there was a shortage of food (NCV)

many people were hungry

Be careful to translate famine in a way that does not imply that the famine lasted the entire time that the judges ruled. The famine lasted for a period of years, but the judges ruled for hundreds of years.

in the land: This phrase refers to the land of Israel. The famine was probably widespread throughout the country.

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

- Make the referent of the phrase explicit. For example:

there was a famine in the land of Israel

- Leave the referent of the phrase implied. For example:

there was a famine in the land (ESV)

- Substitute a different word or phrase. For example:

a famine occurred in the country (NJB)

many people were hungry there This example is an option if you have made explicit the phrase “in Israel” in 1:1a.

1:1c–d

And a certain man from Bethlehem in Judah, with his wife and two sons, went to reside in the land of Moab: Here are some ways to indicate the connection of this clause to the previous clause. Any of these options is acceptable:

- Indicate that this clause is the result of the famine that is described in the previous clause. For example:

So a man from Bethlehem in Judah went to live as a resident foreigner in the region of Moab, along with his wife and two sons. (NET)

- Indicate that this clause is the next action in the story. For example:

and a man of Bethlehem in Judah, with his wife and two sons, went to reside in the country of Moab. (NJPS)

- Leave the connection to the previous clause implied. For example:

A man from Bethlehem in Judah went with his wife and two sons to live for a while in the country of Moab. (GW)

1:1c

And a certain man from Bethlehem in Judah,

- A man from Bethlehem in Judah
- So a man whose home was Bethlehem, in the land of the tribe of Judah,

a certain man from Bethlehem in Judah: In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally “he went a man from Bethlehem Judah.” There are two main interpretations of this phrase: WBC (pages 62–63) says that “It is syn-

tactically impossible to tell whether “from Bethlehem in Judah” modifies the verb “went” (i.e., “went from Bethlehem in Judah”) or the noun “man” (i.e., “a man from Bethlehem in Judah”).

1. The home of the man was Bethlehem in Judah. For example:

a man from Bethlehem in Judah (NET) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NABRE, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The man departed from Bethlehem in Judah. For example:

So a man named Elimelech left the town of Bethlehem in Judah (NCV) (NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

a certain man: This phrase introduces the first character in the story. In this verse, the author does not say the name of the man.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

a man (NIV)

In some languages, it may be more natural to introduce the character by name instead of using the phrase a certain man. See the 1:1–2 paragraph description for an example.

Bethlehem in Judah: This phrase refers to the town of Bethlehem in the region of Judah.

Judah: Judah was the name of the region where the descendants of Judah, son of Jacob, lived. It was in the southern part of the land of Israel. See the map of Judah in the section description.

1:1d

with his wife and two sons, went to reside in the land of Moab.

- went with his wife and his two sons to live temporarily in the country of Moab.
- moved to the region of Moab to live there for a while. His wife and their two sons went with him.

with his wife and two sons: In Hebrew, this phrase is more literally “he his wife and his two sons.” This phrase introduces additional characters in the story. They are the family members of “a certain man from Bethlehem.”

In the Hebrew phrase, the man is the subject. The family members are described in relation to him, as “his wife” and “his two sons.”

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

- Translate more literally. For example:

he and his wife and his two sons (ESV)

- Translate in a way that refers to both parents. For example:

with his wife...and their two sons (GNT)

- Leave the pronoun “his” implied in the second part of the phrase. For example:

with his wife and two sons (REB)

Translate this introduction of the family members in a way that is natural in your language.

went to reside: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as to reside means “dwell as a stranger.” NIDOTTE (page 836): dwell as a stranger, become a refugee, BDB (page 157): 1. sojourn, dwell for a (definite or indef.) time, dwell as a new-comer without original rights. In this verse, the Hebrew word referred to a temporary stay. According to WBC (page 63), “The verb in and of itself does not necessarily connote a temporary stay... for many “resident aliens” lived in a community more or less permanently. A move because of famine, however, would normally suggest that it was not intended to be permanent.”

in the land of Moab: Moab is a region that is located to the east of Judah. To get to Moab, Elimelech and his family probably traveled about eighty kilometers (fifty miles). They would have traveled east from Bethlehem around the north end of the Dead Sea, and then south into Moab. Moab is south and east from Israel, on the east side of the Dead Sea. See the map in the section description.

In this phrase, the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as land means “field,” “country” or “land.” TWOT #2236b. The majority of versions translate this word as “country.” However, in this verse, the word could have any of these meanings. ZECOT (page 68) says that this Hebrew word “usually refers to land as a field that has been brought under human occupation and cultivation.” See also NICOT (pages 86–87).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

on the plateau NICOT (page 86) suggests that the Hebrew word may refer to a “fertile plateau about twenty-five miles wide along (and several thousand feet above) the Dead sea’s eastern shore.” of Moab (NAB)

in the country of Moab (NIV)

In the region of Moab (NET)

Ruth 1:2

Section 1:1–5: Elimelech and his family went to Moab, where he and his two sons died

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See 1:1–2 (combined/reordered) in the Display for another example.

1:2 (combined/reordered)

- Before Israel was ruled by kings, Elimelech from the tribe of Ephrath lived in the town of Bethlehem. His wife was named Naomi, and their two sons were Mahlon and Chilion. But when their crops failed, they moved to the country of Moab. And while they were there... (CEV)

This verse gives more details about the characters that were introduced in 1:1.

1:2a–b

The man’s name was Elimelech, his wife’s name was Naomi,

- The man was called Elimelech, his wife was called Naomi,

1:2a

The man’s name was Elimelech: The name Elimelech means either “God is king” or “my God is king.” However, the meaning of the name is probably not important to the story.

It is recommended that you follow the majority of versions that transliterate the name Elimelech. You can add a footnote to explain the meaning of the name if you think it will be helpful to your readers.

Here is a footnote example:

The name “Elimelech” literally means “My God [is] king.” (Modified from the NET)

1:2b

his wife’s name was Naomi: The name Naomi means “pleasant” or “lovely.” In 1:20a, Naomi used a wordplay in which she contrasted the meaning of her name with the Hebrew word mara, which means “bitter.”

It is recommended that you follow the majority of versions that transliterate the name Naomi. Also consider adding a footnote to explain the meaning of the name. The footnote may help your readers recognize the play on words in 1:20a.

Here is a footnote example:

The name Naomi means “pleasant” or “lovely.” Her name is used as a wordplay in 1:20–21. She laments that she is no longer “pleasant” but “bitter” because of the loss of her husband and two sons. (Modified from the NET)

1:2c

and the names of his two sons were Mahlon and Chilion.

- and the names of their two sons were Mahlon and Chilion.
- and their two sons were called Mahlon and Chilion.

and the names of his two sons were Mahlon and Chilion: Scholars do not agree about the meaning of the names Mahlon and Chilion. They also do not know which son was older. It is recommended that you follow the majority of versions that transliterate these names.

In some languages, it may be necessary to indicate which son was older. It is reasonable to assume that Mahlon was the older of the two sons, since his name is mentioned first.

1:2d

They were Ephrathites from Bethlehem in Judah,

- They were from the Ephrathite clan and they lived in Bethlehem in Judah.
- Their clan name was Ephrath, from the town of Bethlehem in the land of Judah.

They were Ephrathites from Bethlehem in Judah:

This verse part gives more details about the family of Elimelech. They were members of a clan that lived in Bethlehem. In some verses the name Ephrath/Ephrathah refers to the town of Bethlehem, and the word “Ephrathite” refers to residents of the town Bethlehem. However, this verse has the words “Ephrathites from Bethlehem Judah.” Here it is redundant to refer to Elimelech’s family members as “residents of Bethlehem from Bethlehem.” It is preferable to understand the referent as “members of the clan of Ephrathites from Bethlehem.” See WBC (page 64), UBS (page 7), and ES (page 33). Some versions make this information explicit. For example:

They were of the clan of Ephrath from Bethlehem in Judah. (NET)

who belonged to the clan of Ephrath and who lived in Bethlehem in Judah (GNT)

1:2e

and they entered the land of Moab and settled there.

- They went to the land of Moab and settled there.
- They traveled to the country of Moab and stayed there.

and they entered the land of Moab and settled there: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as settled means “remained” or “stayed.”

This clause repeats the information from 1:1d. It does not indicate that they went to Moab a second time. In some languages, the repetition may create confusion or be unnatural. If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate this clause:

- Reduce the repetition by using different words in 1:1d and 1:2e. For example:

^{1d}...went with his wife and two sons to live in Moabite territory

^{2e}...came to Moab and settled there (REB)

- Leave 1:2e implied. For example:

^{1d}...his wife and two sons, left to live for a while in the country of Moab

^{2d-e}They were from the Ephrathite clan of Bethlehem in Judah.

Ruth 1:3

Section 1:1–5: Elimelech and his family went to Moab, where he and his two sons died

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from Moab, Ruth and Orpah. Both of the sons then also died.

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Paragraph 1:3–5

This paragraph gives the details of Naomi's situation. After Elimelech and his family went to Moab, Naomi's husband and her two sons died. She became a widow with no male family members to provide for her and protect her. This crisis is the main problem of the story. The rest of the story tells how this crisis is resolved.

1:3a

Then Naomi's husband Elimelech died,

- ¶ But Naomi's husband, Elimelech, died,
- ¶ Some time later Elimelech died.

Then Naomi's husband Elimelech died: Here are some ways to indicate the connection of this clause to the previous clause. Any of these options is acceptable:

- Indicate that this clause is the next event in the story. The BSB and some other versions translate this function with a word like Then or "And." Here this word introduces the next event. For example:

Now Naomi's husband Elimelech died. (GW)

And Elimelech Naomi's husband died; and she was left, and her two sons. (KJV)

- Indicate that this clause talks about an event that occurred at an unspecified time after their arrival in Moab. For example:

Sometime later Naomi's husband Elimelech died, so she and her two sons were left alone. (NET)

While they were living there, Elimelech died, and Naomi was left alone with her two sons (GNT)

- Indicate that this clause talks about an event that was not expected. For example:

But Elimelech, the husband of Naomi, died, and she was left with her two sons. (ESV)

- Leave the connection to the previous clause implied. For example:

Elimelech, Naomi's husband, died; and she was left with her two sons. (NJPS)

This clause refers to Elimelech as Naomi's husband. In Hebrew, it is unusual to refer to a man in relation to a woman. However, by referring to Elimelech as Naomi's husband, the author is giving attention to Naomi as the main character of this part of the story.

It is recommended that you translate this clause in a natural way in your language to indicate that Naomi is now the main character in the story. Here are two examples:

- Translate literally. Keep the reference to Elimelech as Naomi's husband. For example:

But Elimelech, the husband of Naomi, died (ESV)

- Translate that Elimelech died. In 1:3b remind the readers that his wife's (widow's) name was Naomi by making her name explicit. For example:

Elimelech died, ^{3b}leaving Naomi with only her two sons (CEV)

1:3b

and she was left with her two sons,

- and Naomi was left alone with her two sons.
- So Naomi no longer had a husband. She only had her two sons.

and she was left with her two sons: Here are some ways to indicate the connection of this clause to the previous clause. Either of these options is acceptable:

- Indicate that this clause talks about the result of the death of Elimelech. For example:

So she and her two sons were left alone. (NET)

- Indicate that this clause talks about the next situation in the story. For example:

and Naomi was left with her two sons (NJPS)

The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as *was left* means “left behind.” TWOT #2307. In this clause, the word refers to Naomi losing her husband. She needed to care for her two sons alone, as a single mother.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Naomi was left a widow with her two sons. (REB)

Naomi no longer had a husband, only her two sons. Suggested by UBS (page 8).

Ruth 1:4

Section 1:1–5: Elimelech and his family went to Moab, where he and his two sons died

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This paragraph gives the details of Naomi’s situation. After Elimelech and his family went to Moab, Naomi’s husband and her two sons died. She became a widow with no male family members to provide for her and protect her. This crisis is the main problem of the story. The rest of the story tells how this crisis is resolved.

1:4a

who took Moabite women as their wives,

- They married women of Moab.
- Each son took a woman from Moab to be a wife.

who took Moabite women as their wives: This verse part introduces two Moabite women (women from the country of Moab) as additional characters in the story. Some versions make it clear that the referent is the two sons. For example:

The two sons married Moabite women. (NLT)

Each son married a woman from Moab. (GW)

1:4b

one named Orpah and the other named Ruth.

- Their wives’ names were Orpah and Ruth.
- The name of Mahlon’s wife was Ruth, and the name of Chilion’s wife was Orpah.

one named Orpah and the other named Ruth: This verse part gives the names of the Moabite women. Scholars do not agree about the meaning of the names Orpah and Ruth. KD (page 344) says that the names Orpah and Ruth cannot be satisfactorily explained from the Hebrew. The meanings of the names are probably not important to the story.

It is recommended that you follow the majority of versions that transliterate the names as Orpah and Ruth. In some languages, it may be necessary to indicate which wife married which son. If that is true in your language, then you may indicate that Ruth was the wife of Mahlon and Orpah was the wife of Chilion. See Ruth 4:10.

1:4c**And after they had lived in Moab about ten years,**

- They lived there about ten years.
- And they remained there in Moab about ten more years.

And after they had lived in Moab about ten years:

There are two interpretation issues about 1:4c. The first issue is about the referent of this verse part:

1. This verse part refers to the two sons (or the two sons, their wives, and Naomi). The ten year period refers to the time that the sons (or the two sons, their wives, and Naomi) lived in Moab after they married Orpah and Ruth. For example:

And they continued to live there about ten years.
(NET) (CEV, NET, NLT)

1. This verse part refers to the family of Elimelech. The ten year period refers to the entire time that the family had lived in Moab. For example:

Naomi and her sons had lived in Moab about ten years (NCV) (NCV)

Many versions are ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with more versions and commentaries. This interpretation follows the standard sequential function of the Hebrew form of the verb (wayyiqtol). According to ES (page 38) most interpreters follow this interpretation. These include CBC (page 513), NICOT (page 95), EBC (page 1311), and UBS (page 8).

A second issue is about the syntax of this verse part:

1. This verse part is an independent clause. 1:5 starts a new clause. For example:

and they lived there about ten years. ^{1:5}Then those two—Mahlon and Chilion—also died (NJPS) (GW, KJV, NASB, NET, NJB, NJPS)

1. This verse part begins a clause that continues in 1:5. For example:

About ten years later, ^{1:5}Mahlon and Chilion also died (CEV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, NABRE, NCV, NIV, NLT, NRSV, REB)

The Display will follow interpretation (1). However, you may also follow interpretation (2). There is no difference in meaning caused by the choice of syntax.

Indicate the connection of this verse part to the surrounding clauses in a natural way in your language.

Ruth 1:5**Section 1:1–5: Elimelech and his family went to Moab, where he and his two sons died**

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1:5a**both Mahlon and Chilion also died,**

- Then both Mahlon and Chilion died also.

both Mahlon and Chilion also died: This clause tells what happened after the ten years that are described in the previous clause. Both of Naomi's sons died. The word also refers back to the death of Elimelech. It may give attention to the fact that all of Naomi's male family members were gone. She not only lost her husband, but also her sons.

Here is another way to translate this verse part:

Then Naomi's two sons, Mahlon and Chilion, also died.

1:5b

and Naomi was left without her two sons and without her husband.

- So the woman was left without her boys and without her husband.
- So Naomi was now alone, with no husband or sons.

and Naomi: The phrase that the BSB translates as and Naomi is literally "and the woman." The Hebrew phrase does not make explicit Naomi's name. It is the same pattern as the summary introduction in 1:1, in which Elimelech and his family members are not named. For that reason, 1:5b may be a summary closing to this section. Some versions translate this phrase literally. For example:

so the woman (NET)

Translate this phrase in a natural way in your language.

Here are some ways to indicate the connection of 1:5b to the previous clause. Either of these options is acceptable:

- Indicate that this clause talks about the result of the death of her sons. For example:

so that the woman was left without her two sons and her husband (ESV)

- Indicate that this clause talks about the next situation in the story. For example:

and Naomi was left all alone, without husband or sons (GNT)

was left without: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as left without is literally "and she was left the woman from." The verb translated as left is the same as in 1:3b. See how you translated it there.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

Then Naomi, bereaved of her two sons as well as of her husband. (REB)

and the woman was left with neither (NABRE)

Now Naomi had no husband or sons. (CEV)

her two sons and without her husband: The sons are mentioned first in this phrase. A reason may be to give attention to Naomi's loss. NICOT (page 96), and AYB (pages 84–85). However, in some languages, it may be more natural to translate this phrase in a different order, since her husband died first, then her sons. For example:

and Naomi was left all alone, without husband or sons. (GNT)

The phrase that the BSB translates as her two sons is literally "both her children." The Hebrew word "children" normally refers to young children, not grown sons.

Here are two possible explanations why the Hebrew word for "children" is used here:

- It expresses the deep pain that Naomi felt. WBC (page 66).
- It forms a pair with Ruth 4:16, which has the same word. NICOT (page 96) and WBC (page 66) both identify this as an "inclusio." An inclusio is a bracketing structure something like a bookend. Here it occurs in the first and last chapter of Ruth.

Consider translating this phrase as "both her children" if in your language it is a natural way to refer to grown sons that expresses Naomi's extreme grief.

Ruth 1:6

Section 1:6–22: Naomi returned to Bethlehem with Ruth

This section talks about the next main event of the story, which is Naomi's return to Bethlehem, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, Ruth.

Many scholars agree that verses 1:7–21 describe this event in detail, and that verse 1:22 is the closing verse of this section, which summarizes the event.

However, scholars do not agree about the function of verse 1:6. Some scholars believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. It says that Naomi arose

(she and her daughters-in-law) and returned from the region of Moab. Thus, this section begins and ends with a summary description of the main event. NICOT (pages 99–100): The common Hebrew idiom *qûm* plus a verb of motion (*šûb*) also signals the start of the story's main action: Then she...returned. Structurally, the idiom is a summary-introduction to the following events (vv. 7–21) and forms an inclusio with the chapter's summary-conclusion (cf. *wattāšāb*, v. 22). Further, it sounds the chapter's main theme, namely, the return of Naomi.

Some other scholars do not believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. Rather 1:6 describes the first part of the action. It says that she arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and prepared to return from the region of Moab.

The majority of versions follow the second suggestion. However, the first suggestion follows a pattern that is also in some other Hebrew narratives. An event is introduced by a summary statement, and the verses after it describe that event in detail. For example: Genesis 1:1 introduces the creation account of 1:2–31. Genesis 6:7 introduces the flood account of Genesis 6–9. Ruth 1:1–2 introduces the first section in Ruth 1:3–5. See the Note on 1:6b for more information.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi and Ruth Return to Bethlehem (NIV)

Naomi and Ruth Return (NLT)

Departure from Moab (GW)

1:6

1:6a

When Naomi heard in Moab that the LORD had attended to His people by providing them with food,

- ¶ Some time later in Moab, Naomi heard news that Yahweh was assisting his people by giving them food.
- ¶ While Naomi was still living in Moab, she heard news from Israel. Yahweh had helped his people by causing their food crops to grow well.

When Naomi heard in Moab that the LORD had attended to His people by providing them with food:

This verse part gives the reason why Naomi returned to Bethlehem. She heard that the LORD had provided food for his people. The famine had ended, so she no longer needed to remain in Moab.

When Naomi heard: The verse does not indicate when Naomi heard the news from Israel. However, it was some time after her sons died.

Here are some other ways to indicate when Naomi heard the news:

Then Naomi heard (NLT)

While Naomi was in Moab, she heard (NCV)

Some time later Naomi heard (GNT)

The verse leaves implicit that the news came from Israel. If this information is not clear to your readers, it may be helpful to make it explicit. For example:

When Naomi in Moab heard news from Israel

that the LORD had attended to His people: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as attended to is literally “visited.” The word means “pay attention to” or “observe with care.” KEL (page 600), and ES (page 45).

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

that the LORD had shown his care for his people (REB)

that the LORD had shown concern for his people (NET)

that the LORD had blessed his people (NLT)

by providing them with food: This line explains the way that the LORD came to the aid of his people. The verse does not say how he provided food. However, this statement implies that the LORD had sent rain to Israel, so that grain and other crops were able to grow again. It may be helpful to your readers to make some of this information explicit. Your translation should not give the impression that the LORD gave them food directly and miraculously.

Here are some ways to make more explicit how the LORD provided food for his people:

reversing the famine by providing abundant crops (NET)

by giving them good crops again (NLT)

1:6a–b (combined/reordered)

- ¶ Naomi prepared to return from Moab with her daughters-in-law, because she had heard in Moab that Yahweh had helped his people by giving them food.

1:6b she and her daughters-in-law prepared to leave the land of Moab.

- Because of that news, Naomi decided to return from the land of Moab, with the wives of her two sons.
- So Naomi, accompanied by her daughters-in-law, got ready to leave Moab and go back home to Israel.

she and her daughters-in-law prepared to leave the land of Moab: This verse part is more literally “and she arose she and her daughters-in-law and she returned from the region of Moab.” The Hebrew phrase “she arose...and she returned” is a Hebrew idiom that introduces the event of Naomi’s return that follows in 1:7–21. In Hebrew the verbs “arose” and “returned” are singular, with Naomi as the subject. WBC (page 66) notes that Naomi is the singular subject of the verbs in 1:6 and the start of 1:7. She arose, she returned, she heard, and she set forth. This syntax is unusual. Plural verbs are expected here, with Naomi and the daughters-in-law as a compound subject. WBC suggests that the effect of the singular forms is that the true subject of all the clauses is Naomi alone. This effect can be reflected with a translation such as “she set out with her daughters-in-law” rather than “she and her daughters-in-law set out.” This unusual syntax is also noted by AYB (page 85), KD (page 344), and NICOT (pages 99–100).

There are two possible functions of this idiom:

- The function of the idiom is to introduce the first part of Naomi’s return to Bethlehem from Moab. This function of the idiom is supported by UBS (page 9). It refers to her decision or preparation to return. For example:

So she decided to return home from the region of Moab, accompanied by her daughters-in-law (NET)

So Naomi and her daughters-in-law got ready to leave Moab to return to her homeland. (NLT)

- The function of the idiom is to introduce a summary of Naomi’s return to Bethlehem from Moab. It refers to the entire event. For example:

Then she arose with her daughters-in-law and she returned from the region of Moab.

The Display will follow the first option, since it is followed by a majority of versions. However, both options have merit. You will need to decide which option to follow for your translation. For more information, see the comments for section 1:6–22.

General Comment on 1:6a–b

The BSB and some other versions have reordered the verse parts. In some languages, it may be more natural to follow the Hebrew order, which first gives Naomi’s action, and then the reason for her action. For example:

Naomi prepared to return from Moab with her daughters-in-law, because she had heard in Moab that the LORD had helped his people by giving them food.

Ruth 1:7

Section 1:6–22: Naomi returned to Bethlehem with Ruth

This section talks about the next main event of the story, which is Naomi’s return to Bethlehem, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, Ruth.

Many scholars agree that verses 1:7–21 describe this event in detail, and that verse 1:22 is the closing verse of this section, which summarizes the event.

However, scholars do not agree about the function of verse 1:6. Some scholars believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. It says that Naomi arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and returned from the region of Moab. Thus, this section begins and ends with a summary description of the main event. NICOT (pages 99–100): The common Hebrew idiom *qûm* plus a verb of motion (*šûb*) also signals the start of the story’s main action: Then she...returned. Structurally, the idiom is a summary-introduction to the following events (vv. 7–21) and forms an *inclusio* with the chapter’s summary-conclusion (cf. *wattāšāb*, v. 22). Further, it sounds the chapter’s main theme, namely, the return of Naomi.

Some other scholars do not believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. Rather 1:6 describes the first part of the action. It says that she arose (she and

her daughters-in-law) and prepared to return from the region of Moab.

The majority of versions follow the second suggestion. However, the first suggestion follows a pattern that is also in some other Hebrew narratives. An event is introduced by a summary statement, and the verses after it describe that event in detail. For example: Genesis 1:1 introduces the creation account of 1:2–31. Genesis 6:7 introduces the flood account of Genesis 6–9. Ruth 1:1–2 introduces the first section in Ruth 1:3–5. See the Note on 1:6b for more information.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi and Ruth Return to Bethlehem (NIV)

Naomi and Ruth Return (NLT)

Departure from Moab (GW)

1:7a

Accompanied by her two daughters-in-law, she left the place where she had been living

- Naomi left the place where she had been living, and took her two daughters-in-law with her.
- So she and her two daughters-in-law left their home,
- This is how it happened. She departed from her home in Moab, accompanied by her two daughters-in-law.

Accompanied by her two daughters-in-law, she left the place where she had been living: This clause is more literally “and she went out from the place where she had been there and her two daughters-in-law [were] with her.”

The BSB and some other versions have reordered the clause parts. The Hebrew order first indicates Naomi’s action, and then indicates that her daughters-in-law were with her. In some languages, it may be more natural to follow the Hebrew order. For example:

So she departed from the place where she was, and her two daughters-in-law with her (NASB)

Here are some ways to indicate the connection of this clause to the previous clause. Any of these options is acceptable:

- Indicate that this clause talks about the result/consequence of the news that the LORD had come to the aid of his people. For example:

So she set out from the place where she had been living, she and her two daughters-in-law (NRSV)

- Indicate that this clause begins to give the details of Naomi’s return home. This kind of connection regards 1:6 to be an introduction to the event, and 1:7–21 to give a detailed description of it. For example:

This is how it happened. She departed from the place where she had been living, accompanied by her two daughters-in-law

- Leave implied the connection of this clause to the previous clause. For example:

Accompanied by her two daughters-in-law, she left the place where she had been living (NJPS)

The Hebrew verbs that the BSB translates as left and had been living are singular, with Naomi as the subject. However, in some languages it may be more natural to translate these verbs as plural, since the two daughters-in-law were accompanying Naomi. For example:

They started out together to go back (GNT)

Translate these verbs in a natural way in your language when one person is in focus, but more than one person is doing the same action.

the place where she had been living: This phrase refers to Naomi’s home in Moab.

1:7b

and set out on the road leading back to the land of Judah.

- They started traveling on the road that led back to the land of Judah.
- taking the path that would bring them to the land of Judah.
- They traveled on the road that led back to Naomi’s home in the land of Judah.

and set out on the road leading back to the land of Judah: This clause is more literally “and they went on the way to return to the land of Judah.” There are two ways to interpret the referent of the Hebrew word “to return” that the BSB translates as leading back:

1. It refers to the noun “way.” It was the way/road that would return them to the land of Judah. For example:

and they set out on the road back to the land of Judah (NJPS) (BSB, GW, NABRE, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB)

1. It refers to the verb “went.” The reason they went was to return to the land of Judah. For example:

began to leave the place where she had been living to return to the land of Judah (NET) (GNT, NET)

Some versions are ambiguous as to the interpretation that they follow. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with the majority of versions.

In this verse part, the Hebrew word “to return” may cause confusion if translated literally. All three women were traveling together. However, only Naomi would actually “return” to Judah, since Orpah and Ruth had not been there before.

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this verse part differently. For example:

- Use a phrase other than leading back or “return.” For example:

they went on the road that led to Judah

- Translate in a way that the phrase leading back or “return” refers only to Naomi. For example:

They traveled on the road that led back to Naomi’s home in the land of Judah.

Ruth 1:8

Section 1:6–22: Naomi returned to Bethlehem with Ruth

This section talks about the next main event of the story, which is Naomi’s return to Bethlehem, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, Ruth.

Many scholars agree that verses 1:7–21 describe this event in detail, and that verse 1:22 is the closing verse of this section, which summarizes the event.

However, scholars do not agree about the function of verse 1:6. Some scholars believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. It says that Naomi arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and returned from the region of Moab. Thus, this section begins and ends with a summary description of the main event. NICOT (pages 99–100): The common Hebrew idiom *qûm* plus a verb of motion (*šûb*) also signals the start of the story’s main action: Then she...returned. Struc-

turally, the idiom is a summary-introduction to the following events (vv. 7–21) and forms an inclusio with the chapter’s summary-conclusion (cf. *wattāšāb*, v. 22). Further, it sounds the chapter’s main theme, namely, the return of Naomi.

Some other scholars do not believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. Rather 1:6 describes the first part of the action. It says that she arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and prepared to return from the region of Moab.

The majority of versions follow the second suggestion. However, the first suggestion follows a pattern that is also in some other Hebrew narratives. An event is introduced by a summary statement, and the verses after it describe that event in detail. For example: Genesis 1:1 introduces the creation account of 1:2–31. Genesis 6:7 introduces the flood account of Genesis 6–9. Ruth 1:1–2 introduces the first section in Ruth 1:3–5. See the Note on 1:6b for more information.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi and Ruth Return to Bethlehem (NIV)

Naomi and Ruth Return (NLT)

Departure from Moab (GW)

1:8a

Then Naomi said to her two daughters-in-law, “Go back, each of you to your mother’s home.”

- ¶ But Naomi said to her two daughters-in-law, “Return to the home of your^(plur) mothers.
- ¶ After a while Naomi said to Orpah and Ruth, “Each of you^(sing) should go back to the house of your mother.

Then Naomi said to her two daughters-in-law, “Go back, each of you to your mother’s home: In this clause, Naomi attempted to send her daughters-in-law back to their former homes in Moab.

Here are some ways to indicate the connection of this clause to the previous clause. Any of these options is acceptable:

- Indicate that this clause contrasts the return to Moab in 1:8 with the return to Israel in 1:7. For example:

But on the way, Naomi said to her two daughters-in-law, “Go back to your mother’s homes (NLT)

- Indicate that this clause talks about the next action in the story. For example:

And Naomi said to her two daughters-in-law, “Go, return each of you to her mother’s house. (NASB)

Then Naomi said to her two daughters-in-law, “Go back! Each of you should go back to your mother’s home. (GW)

- Leave implied the connection of this clause to the previous clause. For example:

Naomi said to her two daughters-in-law, ‘Go back, each of you to your mother’s house. (NJB)

Go back: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “Go return.” It is an idiom that gives emphasis to the command to return. Lamdin, Biblical Hebrew (pages 239–240). Here Naomi strongly urged Ruth and Orpah to return to their homes.

The blessing that Naomi gives in 1:8b indicates that she thought well of them and wanted each of them to have a good life. So translate this idiom in a way that indicates emphasis but not anger or scolding.

Here are some other ways to translate this idiom:

Turn back (NJPS)

Listen to me! Each of you should return (GW)

each of you to your mother’s home: Naomi urged her daughters-in-law to return to the homes they each came from before they married.

each of you: This phrase indicated that Ruth and Orpah had different mothers who lived in different homes.

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

- Translate the phrase as each of you or something similar. For example:

Go back, each of you to your mother’s house. (NABRE)

Go back, both of you, home to your own mothers. (REB)

- Leave this phrase implied. For example:

Go back to your mothers’ homes. (NLT)

your mother’s home: In Hebrew, this description is unusual. Elsewhere in the Old Testament a widow would return to her father’s house. WBC (page 75) includes as references, Genesis 38:11 and Leviticus 22:13. However, references to a mother’s house sometimes do occur, such as in Song of Songs 3:4; 8:2. WBC suggests that here the reference to the “mother’s house” may give emphasis to the contrast Naomi wishes to make, that a widow should return to her mother and not stay with her mother-in-law. The reference to their mother’s homes may be unnatural in some other languages also. If that is true in your language, consider providing a brief explanation in a footnote.

Here is a footnote example:

Naomi’s words may imply that it is more appropriate for the two widows to go home to their mothers, rather than stay with their mother-in-law. (modified from the NET)

1:8b

May the LORD show you loving devotion, as you have shown to your dead and to me.

- May Yahweh show his loyalty to you^(plur) in the same way that you showed loyalty to your husbands who have died, and to me.
- You were kind to those now dead, and to me. I pray that Yahweh will be kind to you in the same way.

May the LORD show you loving devotion, as you have shown to your dead and to me: This clause is a blessing. In this blessing, Naomi indicated her desire that the LORD would be kind to Orpah and Ruth.

loving devotion: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as loving devotion has several aspects of meaning. In this verse it refers particularly to faithfulness, love, and loyalty. This term also occurs in 2:20b and 3:10b.

See Loyalty, kindness, or loyal love in the “Introduction to Ruth” for a further discussion of this key Hebrew word.

as you have shown to your dead and to me: In this part of the blessing, Naomi used a comparison to describe the kindness that she wanted the LORD to show Orpah and Ruth. She compared it to the kindness that Ruth and Orpah had shown to her and to their husbands.

Here are some other ways to translate this comparison:

May the Lord be as kind to you as you were to me and to our loved ones who have died. (GW)

May the Lord show you the same kind of devotion that you have shown to your deceased husbands and to me! (NET)

your dead: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally “the dead.” There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. This phrase refers to Mahlon and Kilion. Both of them were dead. For example:

May the Lord be as kind to you as you have been to me and my sons who are now dead. (NCV) (BSB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT)

1. This phrase refers to Elimelech, Mahlon and Kilion. All three of them were dead. For example:

You were kind to my husband and sons, and you have always been kind to me. I pray that the Lord will be just as kind to you (CEV) (CEV)

Many versions are ambiguous as to the interpretation that they follow. For example:

May Yahweh show you faithful love, as you have done to those who have died and to me. (NJB)

It is recommended that you translate this phrase in a way that allows either interpretation to be understood. However, if you need to choose one interpretation to follow, then it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a majority of versions. The Hebrew text does not indicate that Orpah and Ruth ever had an opportunity to show kindness to Elimelech. He may have died before Orpah and Ruth met Mahlon and Kilion.

This phrase probably refers to acts of kindness that Ruth and Orpah had shown to their husbands while they were still alive. NICOT (pages 104–105) suggests that their kindness “in some unspecified way benefited the dead.” However, WBC (page 76) counters that here Naomi “refers to the faithfulness of Ruth and Orpah both to her and to these dear departed during the ten years (v4) of their married life together.”

In some languages, it may be more natural to arrange the clause parts in chronological order. For example:

You were kind to your husbands who have died, and to me. I pray that Yahweh will be kind to you in the same way.

Ruth 1:9

Section 1:6–22: Naomi returned to Bethlehem with Ruth

This section talks about the next main event of the story, which is Naomi’s return to Bethlehem, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, Ruth.

Many scholars agree that verses 1:7–21 describe this event in detail, and that verse 1:22 is the closing verse of this section, which summarizes the event.

However, scholars do not agree about the function of verse 1:6. Some scholars believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. It says that Naomi arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and returned from the region of Moab. Thus, this section begins and ends with a summary description of the main event. NICOT (pages 99–100): The common Hebrew idiom *qûm* plus a verb of motion (*šûb*) also signals the start of the story’s main action: Then she...returned. Structurally, the idiom is a summary-introduction to the following events (vv. 7–21) and forms an *inclusio* with the chapter’s summary-conclusion (cf. *wattāšāb*, v. 22). Further, it sounds the chapter’s main theme, namely, the return of Naomi.

Some other scholars do not believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. Rather 1:6 describes the first part of the action. It says that she arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and prepared to return from the region of Moab.

The majority of versions follow the second suggestion. However, the first suggestion follows a pattern that is also in some other Hebrew narratives. An event is introduced by a summary statement, and the verses after it describe that event in detail. For example: Genesis 1:1 introduces the creation account of 1:2–31. Genesis 6:7 introduces the flood account of Genesis 6–9. Ruth 1:1–2 introduces the first section in Ruth 1:3–5. See the Note on 1:6b for more information.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi and Ruth Return to Bethlehem (NIV)

Naomi and Ruth Return (NLT)

Departure from Moab (GW)

1:9a

May the LORD enable each of you to find rest in the home of your new husband.”

- I pray that Yahweh will give both of you^(dual) security, each of you^(sing) in the home of your^(sing) husband.”
- May Yahweh enable each of you^(sing) to remarry and to have a happy home with your husband.”
- May Yahweh bless you^(plural) with new husbands. And may you have peace in your new homes.”

May the LORD enable each of you to find rest: This clause is a continuation of the blessing from 1:8b. The clause is more literally “May Yahweh give to you and find rest [each] woman.” The syntax is unusual. In Hebrew, the wish/prayer “May Yahweh give to you” has no object. Also, the verb find is a command form. There are two main interpretations of this clause:

1. The phrase “and find rest” is not a command. Rather, it is the object of the prayer “May Yahweh give to you.” For example:

May the Lord grant that each of you find security.
(NJPS) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, KJV, NABRE, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. The phrase “and find rest” is the consequence of the prayer “May Yahweh give to you.” For example:

May the Lord repay each of you so that you may find security. (GW) (GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

May the LORD enable: This phrase is a wish/prayer of Naomi. Here are some other ways to translate it:

May the Lord give (NCV)

May the Lord grant (NIV)

May the Lord bless you (NLT)

And may the Lord make it possible (GNT)

each of you: This phrase makes explicit that Naomi’s wish/prayer is for the benefit of both of her daughters-in-law. For example:

for each of you (GNT)

Some versions leave the phrase each of implied. For example:

May the Lord give you (NCV)

rest: In Hebrew, this word means either “rest” or “resting place.” TWOT #1323f. Here it refers to a situation that is secure and free from anxiety “after wandering, uncertainty, and pain.” NICOT (page 105).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

that you may each find happiness (NJB)

the security (NET)

in the home of your new husband: This phrase describes the kind of rest that Naomi wants for her daughters-in-law. The best way for a young widow to have security was to marry another husband.

to marry again and have a home (GNT)

with a husband! (NJB)

1:9b

And she kissed them as they wept aloud

- Then Naomi kissed them farewell. And Orpah and Ruth began to cry loudly
- And when she gave each one a parting kiss on the cheek, they wept with many tears.

And she kissed them as they wept aloud: This clause describes Naomi’s gesture of farewell to her daughters-in-law before they parted ways.

Here are some ways to indicate the connection of 1:9b to the previous clauses. Either of these options is acceptable:

- Indicate that this clause talks about the next action in the story. For example:

And she kissed them farewell. (NJPS)

Then she kissed them goodbye (NET)

- Indicate that this clause talks about the result of Naomi urging Orpah and Ruth to return to Moab and blessing them. For example:

So Naomi kissed them good-bye. (GNT)

And she kissed them: This clause describes a leave-taking custom. She probably kissed them on both cheeks. This was a proper gesture of farewell in that culture. However, in some cultures, this kind of kiss may be considered to be improper or unusual.

Here are some other ways to translate this gesture:

- Add a footnote to explain the meaning. Here is a possible footnote example:

In that culture, a proper leave-taking gesture was to give a small kiss on both cheeks.

- Make explicit the purpose of the gesture in a general way. For example:

Then Naomi expressed a fond farewell to them

- Substitute a different gesture that has the same function in your language. For example:

Then they embraced in farewell

as they wept aloud: This clause describes what happened when Naomi kissed them goodbye. The phrase wept aloud means that they wept/cried loudly.

There are two ways to interpret the referents of the pronoun they in this clause:

1. Orpah and Ruth wept aloud. For example:

but they began weeping loudly, ¹⁰and said, ‘No, we shall go back with you...’ (NJB) (BSB, CEV, GNT, NABRE, NIV, NJB, NJPS, REB)

1. All three women wept aloud. For example:

and they all broke down and wept (NLT) (NLT)

Some versions are ambiguous as to the interpretation that they follow. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with the majority of versions. Orpah and Ruth were distressed when Naomi kissed them good-bye, so they cried and told Naomi that they wanted to stay with her.

Ruth 1:10

Section 1:6–22: Naomi returned to Bethlehem with Ruth

This section talks about the next main event of the story, which is Naomi’s return to Bethlehem, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, Ruth.

Many scholars agree that verses 1:7–21 describe this event in detail, and that verse 1:22 is the closing verse of this section, which summarizes the event.

However, scholars do not agree about the function of verse 1:6. Some scholars believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. It says that Naomi arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and returned from the region of Moab. Thus, this section begins and ends with a summary description of the main event. NICOT (pages 99–100): The common Hebrew idiom *qûm* plus a verb of motion (*šûb*) also signals the start of the story’s main action: Then she...returned. Structurally, the idiom is a summary-introduction to the following events (vv. 7–21) and forms an *inclusio* with the chapter’s summary-conclusion (cf. *wattāšāb*, v. 22). Further, it sounds the chapter’s main theme, namely, the return of Naomi.

Some other scholars do not believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. Rather 1:6 describes the first part of the action. It says that she arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and prepared to return from the region of Moab.

The majority of versions follow the second suggestion. However, the first suggestion follows a pattern that is also in some other Hebrew narratives. An event is introduced by a summary statement, and the verses after it describe that event in detail. For example: Genesis 1:1 introduces the creation account of 1:2–31. Genesis 6:7 introduces the flood account of Genesis 6–9. Ruth 1:1–2 introduces the first section in Ruth 1:3–5. See the Note on 1:6b for more information.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi and Ruth Return to Bethlehem (NIV)

Naomi and Ruth Return (NLT)

Departure from Moab (GW)

1:10

and said, “Surely we will return with you to your people.”

- and said to her, “No, we will return with you to your people.”
- They said to her, “No! We want to go with you to live with your clan.”

and said, “Surely we will return with you to your people.”: In this verse, Orpah and Ruth told Naomi that they intended to accompany her as she returned to Bethlehem.

Here are some ways to indicate the connection of this clause to the previous clause. Any of these options is acceptable:

- Indicate that this clause talks about the next action in the story. For example:

and said to her, “No, we will return with you to your people.” (NJPS)

- Indicate that Orpah and Ruth’s desire to stay with Naomi contrasts with Naomi’s intention to leave them. For example:

But they said to her, “No! We will return with you to your people.” (NET)

- Leave implied the connection of this clause to the previous clause. For example:

They said to her, “No, we will return with you to your people.” (NRSV)

Surely we will return: This phrase indicates that the daughters-in-law intend to accompany Naomi on her return to her people. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Surely indicates that they objected to leaving Naomi. NICOT (page 106) calls it an emphatic *kî* adversative “On the contrary.”

Here are two ways to translate this conjunction:

- Make the meaning of the conjunction explicit. For example:

“No,” they said, “We want to go with you (NLT)

- Leave the meaning of the conjunction implied. For example:

“We are going back with you (GW)

The word return may cause confusion here. Only Naomi would actually be returning to Judah, since

Orpah and Ruth had not been there before. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this verse part differently. For example:

- Leave the word return implied. For example:

We want to go with you (CEV)

- Translate in a way that the word return refers only to Naomi. For example:

“We will accompany you on your return

to your people: In Hebrew, the word people is very general. It could refer to Naomi’s relatives or to all the people of Israel. If your language has a word or phrase that refers to relatives, including distant relatives, you may want to use it here. For example:

to your clan

to your tribe These suggestions are by UBS (page 13).

Ruth 1:11

Section 1:6–22: Naomi returned to Bethlehem with Ruth

This section talks about the next main event of the story, which is Naomi’s return to Bethlehem, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, Ruth.

Many scholars agree that verses 1:7–21 describe this event in detail, and that verse 1:22 is the closing verse of this section, which summarizes the event.

However, scholars do not agree about the function of verse 1:6. Some scholars believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. It says that Naomi arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and returned from the region of Moab. Thus, this section begins and ends with a summary description of the main event. NICOT (pages 99–100): The common Hebrew idiom *qûm* plus a verb of motion (*šûb*) also signals the start of the story’s main action: Then she...returned. Structurally, the idiom is a summary-introduction to the following events (vv. 7–21) and forms an *inclusio* with the chapter’s summary-conclusion (cf. *wattāšāb*, v. 22). Further, it sounds the chapter’s main theme, namely, the return of Naomi.

Some other scholars do not believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. Rather 1:6 describes the first part of the action. It says that she arose (she and

her daughters-in-law) and prepared to return from the region of Moab.

The majority of versions follow the second suggestion. However, the first suggestion follows a pattern that is also in some other Hebrew narratives. An event is introduced by a summary statement, and the verses after it describe that event in detail. For example: Genesis 1:1 introduces the creation account of 1:2–31. Genesis 6:7 introduces the flood account of Genesis 6–9. Ruth 1:1–2 introduces the first section in Ruth 1:3–5. See the Note on 1:6b for more information.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi and Ruth Return to Bethlehem (NIV)

Naomi and Ruth Return (NLT)

Departure from Moab (GW)

1:11a

But Naomi replied, “Return home, my daughters.

- ¶ Naomi answered, “Turn back, my daughters.
- ¶ But Naomi said to them, “Return to your own homes, my dear daughters-in-law.

But Naomi replied: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces the next event in the story. Naomi’s answer contrasted with how her daughters-in-law had replied to her. Some English versions do not translate this word.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Naomi replied (NABRE)

Naomi answered (GNT)

Then Naomi said

Return home, my daughters: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Return home is more literally “return” or “go back.” Naomi thought it would be best for Ruth and Orpah to return to their own homes in Moab rather than to travel with her to Israel.

my daughters: Naomi called her two daughters-in-law my daughters when she spoke to them. This showed her affection for them. In some languages, it may not be possible to use the term daughters for daughters-in-law.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Turn back, my daughters-in-law.

Go back to your homes, dear daughters-in-law.

1:11b

Why would you go with me?

- Why should you^(dual) go with me?
- There is no reason for you to come with me.

Why would you go with me?: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a rebuke. Naomi meant that there was no reason for the women to go with her. In fact, it would be foolish for them to return with her. Their lives would be better in their own country.

There are two ways to translate this rebuke.

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Why should you go on with me? (NLT)

What good will it do you to go with me? (CEV)

- Use a statement. For example:

There is no reason for you to return to Judah with me. (NET)

You should return to your own country. You should not choose to return to Judah with me (EASY)

1:11c

Are there still sons in my womb to become your husbands?

- Can I give birth to any more sons who would grow up to become your^(dual) husbands? No.
- I will not give birth to any more sons who could marry you when they grow up.

Are there still sons in my womb to become your husbands?: This is another rhetorical question. The implied answer is “no.” Naomi meant that she was too old to have any more children. She could not provide more sons who would become husbands for Ruth or Orpah.

There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Am I likely to bear any more sons to become husbands for you? (REB)

- Use a statement. For example:

I am no longer capable of giving birth to sons who might become your husbands! (NET)

I cannot give birth to more sons to give you new husbands (NCV)

Ruth 1:12

Section 1:6–22: Naomi returned to Bethlehem with Ruth

This section talks about the next main event of the story, which is Naomi's return to Bethlehem, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, Ruth.

Many scholars agree that verses 1:7–21 describe this event in detail, and that verse 1:22 is the closing verse of this section, which summarizes the event.

However, scholars do not agree about the function of verse 1:6. Some scholars believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. It says that Naomi arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and returned from the region of Moab. Thus, this section begins and ends with a summary description of the main event. NICOT (pages 99–100): The common Hebrew idiom *qûm* plus a verb of motion (*šûb*) also signals the start of the story's main action: Then she...returned. Structurally, the idiom is a summary-introduction to the following events (vv. 7–21) and forms an *inclusio* with the chapter's summary-conclusion (cf. *wattāšāb*, v. 22). Further, it sounds the chapter's main theme, namely, the return of Naomi.

Some other scholars do not believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. Rather 1:6 describes the first part of the action. It says that she arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and prepared to return from the region of Moab.

The majority of versions follow the second suggestion. However, the first suggestion follows a pattern that is also in some other Hebrew narratives. An event is introduced by a summary statement, and the verses after it describe that event in detail. For example: Genesis 1:1 introduces the creation account of 1:2–31. Genesis 6:7 introduces the flood account of Genesis 6–9. Ruth 1:1–2 introduces the first section in Ruth 1:3–5. See the Note on 1:6b for more information.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi and Ruth Return to Bethlehem (NIV)

Naomi and Ruth Return (NLT)

Departure from Moab (GW)

1:12a

Return home, my daughters. Go on, for I am too old to have another husband.

- Return to your^(dual) own homes, my daughters. I am too old to marry another husband.
- Return home, dear daughters-in-law, because I am now old. I will not marry again.

Return home, my daughters: Naomi repeated almost the same words that she used in verse 11. In the Hebrew text, she added another command, "go." This emphasized what she was saying.

for I am too old to have another husband: Naomi added another point to her argument. Not only was she too old to bear more children, but she was also too old to be married again.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

You must go back home, because I am too old to marry again. (CEV)

Go, because I am too old to get married again. (GW)

1:12b–c

Verse 12b–c consists of two parallel clauses. Both clauses are conditions that are not true.

1:12b

Even if I thought there was hope for me

- Suppose I thought I might still be able to bear children.
- There is no hope for me to have any more children.

Even if I thought there was hope for me: This clause states a condition that is not true. The word *hope* refers to the hope that Naomi could get married again and bear more children. It may be helpful to include that implicit information here. For example:

Even if I thought that there was still hope for me to have more sons

1:12c

to have a husband tonight

- Suppose I married a husband this very night.
- Even if I married a man tonight and became pregnant,

to have a husband tonight and to bear sons: This clause states a second condition that is not true. It was not possible that Naomi could get married that night.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Even if I got married tonight and later had more sons (CEV)

Suppose I married a man tonight. Suppose that later I gave birth to his sons (NIRV)

even if I got married today and became pregnant tonight and later gave birth to sons (T4T)

1:12d and to bear sons,

- Suppose that I gave birth to sons.
- and later gave birth to sons,

Ruth 1:13

Section 1:6–22: Naomi returned to Bethlehem with Ruth

This section talks about the next main event of the story, which is Naomi's return to Bethlehem, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, Ruth.

Many scholars agree that verses 1:7–21 describe this event in detail, and that verse 1:22 is the closing verse of this section, which summarizes the event.

However, scholars do not agree about the function of verse 1:6. Some scholars believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. It says that Naomi arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and returned from the region of Moab. Thus, this section begins and ends with a summary description of the main event. NICOT (pages 99–100): The common Hebrew idiom *qûm* plus a verb of motion (*šûb*) also signals the start of the story's main action: Then she...returned. Structurally, the idiom is a summary-introduction to the following events (vv. 7–21) and forms an *inclusio* with the chapter's summary-conclusion (cf. *wattāšāb*, v. 22). Further, it sounds the chapter's main theme, namely, the return of Naomi.

Some other scholars do not believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. Rather 1:6 describes the first part of the action. It says that she arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and prepared to return from the region of Moab.

The majority of versions follow the second suggestion. However, the first suggestion follows a pattern that is also in some other Hebrew narratives. An event is introduced by a summary statement, and the verses after it describe that event in detail. For example: Genesis 1:1 introduces the creation account of 1:2–31. Genesis 6:7 introduces the flood account of Genesis 6–9. Ruth 1:1–2 introduces the first section in Ruth 1:3–5. See the Note on 1:6b for more information.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi and Ruth Return to Bethlehem (NIV)

Naomi and Ruth Return (NLT)

Departure from Moab (GW)

1:13a would you wait for them to grow up?

- Would you^(dual) wait for them to grow up so you could marry them? No.
- you would not wait for them to grow up.

would you wait for them to grow up?: This is a rhetorical question. It is used for emphasis. Naomi's daughters-in-law would certainly not wait for any sons she might have to grow up. Her new sons would be too young to marry Ruth and Orpah.

There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Would you wait for them until they become old enough to marry? (CEV)

- Use a statement. For example:

Surely you would not want to wait until they were old enough to marry! (NET)

1:13b Would you refrain from having husbands?

- Would you^(dual) stay single/alone until you could marry them? No.
- Surely you would not refuse to marry while you waited for them to grow up.

Would you refrain from having husbands?: This is another rhetorical question. It emphasizes again that Orpah and Ruth had no reason to go with Naomi.

They would not turn down other opportunities to get married, and to wait until Naomi's sons became old enough to marry.

There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Would you...and stay single just for them? (GW)

Would you...refuse to marry someone else? (NLT)

- Use a statement. For example:

Surely you would not remain unmarried all that time! (NET)

1:13c

No, my daughters, it grieves me very much for your sakes

- No, my daughters. What has happened to me is even worse than what has happened to you^(dual),
- No, dear daughters-in-law, you know I will not have any more sons. My life has been much harder than yours,

No, my daughters: There are two ways to interpret the word No:

1. Naomi said No to the idea that Ruth and Orpah could expect her to have more sons. For example:

No, my daughters, you know that's impossible.
(GNT) (GNT, NLT, NCV)

1. Naomi said No to Ruth and Orpah's proposal to accompany her. For example:

No, my daughters, you must not return with me.
(NET) (NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is supported by some commentaries UBS, WBC, NICOT. and some English versions. Most versions, including the BSB, are ambiguous.

it grieves me very much for your sakes: There are three ways to interpret the phrase it grieves me very much:

1. It means that the situation grieves Naomi more than her daughters-in-law. For example:

My bitterness is much worse than yours (GW)
(CEV, GW, NASB, NIV, NLT, NRSV)

1. It means that the situation grieves Naomi on account of her daughters-in-law. She felt sorry for them. For example:

For your sakes I feel bitter that the Lord has inflicted such misfortune on me (REB) (BSB, ESV, GNT, KJV, NJB, REB, RSV)

1. It means that the situation grieves Naomi too much to share her grief with her daughters-in-law. For example:

For my intense suffering is too much for you to bear. (NET) (NABRE, NCV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation is followed by many English versions and fits the context well.

grieves me: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as grieves me is more literally "bitter to me." The word "bitter" refers to an irritating, pungent taste. It is used figuratively to refer to an unpleasant experience.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

My bitterness is much worse than yours (GW)

Life is harder for me than it is for you (CEV)

Your situations are bad...my situation is much worse (T4T)

1:13d

that the hand of the LORD has gone out against me."

- for Yahweh has turned against me."
- because Yahweh has opposed me."

the hand of the LORD has gone out against me: The phrase the hand of the LORD is a figure of speech. It indicates the power or ability of Yahweh to perform some action. Naomi was accusing the LORD of taking action against her, or at least using others to cause her difficulty.

Here are some ways to translate this clause:

General Comment on 1:13c-d

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

because the Lord himself has raised his fist against me (NLT)

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

The Lord has turned against me (GNT)

because the Lord has been against me (NCV)

because the Lord has sent me so much trouble (GW)

In some languages, it may be best to reverse the order of 1:13c and 1:13d. Here is one way to do this:

The LORD himself has turned against me, so what has happened to me is even worse than what has happened to you.

Ruth 1:14

Section 1:6–22: Naomi returned to Bethlehem with Ruth

This section talks about the next main event of the story, which is Naomi's return to Bethlehem, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, Ruth.

Many scholars agree that verses 1:7–21 describe this event in detail, and that verse 1:22 is the closing verse of this section, which summarizes the event.

However, scholars do not agree about the function of verse 1:6. Some scholars believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. It says that Naomi arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and returned from the region of Moab. Thus, this section begins and ends with a summary description of the main event. NICOT (pages 99–100): The common Hebrew idiom *qûm* plus a verb of motion (*šûb*) also signals the start of the story's main action: Then she...returned. Structurally, the idiom is a summary-introduction to the following events (vv. 7–21) and forms an inclusio with the chapter's summary-conclusion (cf. *wattāšāb*, v. 22). Further, it sounds the chapter's main theme, namely, the return of Naomi.

Some other scholars do not believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. Rather 1:6 describes the first part of the action. It says that she arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and prepared to return from the region of Moab.

The majority of versions follow the second suggestion. However, the first suggestion follows a pattern that

is also in some other Hebrew narratives. An event is introduced by a summary statement, and the verses after it describe that event in detail. For example: Genesis 1:1 introduces the creation account of 1:2–31. Genesis 6:7 introduces the flood account of Genesis 6–9. Ruth 1:1–2 introduces the first section in Ruth 1:3–5. See the Note on 1:6b for more information.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi and Ruth Return to Bethlehem (NIV)

Naomi and Ruth Return (NLT)

Departure from Moab (GW)

1:14a

Again they wept aloud,

- When Ruth and Orpah heard this they^(dual/plur) began crying again.
- Then Ruth and Orpah started crying again.

There is a Hebrew conjunction that introduces the next event in the story. Many English versions, including the BSB, do not translate this conjunction.

Again they wept aloud: The pronoun they refers to Ruth and Orpah. NICOT, WBC.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Again they started crying. (GNT)

Then Ruth and Orpah started crying again (T4T)

1:14b

and Orpah kissed her mother-in-law goodbye,

- Then Orpah said farewell to her mother-in-law.
- Orpah kissed Naomi goodbye and left her,

Orpah kissed her mother-in-law goodbye: There is a textual issue in this verse part:

1. The Hebrew text says “And Orpah kissed her mother-in-law.” For example:

Orpah kissed her mother-in-law (NRSV)

Then Orpah kissed her mother-in-law and took her leave (REB) (BSB, ESV, NET, NIV, NASB, NABRE, NRSV, REB)

1. The Septuagint says “And Orpah kissed her mother-in-law and returned to her people.” For example:

Orpah then kissed her mother-in-law and went back to her people. (NJB) (GNT, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions and commentaries. NICOT, WBC, ZECOT.

However, the information that Orpah returned home is clearly implied in 1:15a. You may wish to include this as implied information for clarity.

goodbye: The Hebrew text does not have the word goodbye. The BSB has added this word as implied information. Naomi’s statement in 1:15 makes it clear that Orpah is taking her leave.

Here is another way to translate this verse part:

Then Orpah kissed her mother-in-law Naomi good-bye (NCV)

Then Orpah said farewell/goodbye to her mother-in-law

1:14c

but Ruth clung to her.

- But Ruth held tightly to her.
- but Ruth stayed with her. and did not leave her.

but Ruth clung to her: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as but introduces a contrast between what Orpah decided to do and what Ruth decided to do.

Ruth clung to her: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as clung means “hold onto something tightly.” Ruth may have taken hold of Naomi’s arm or put her arms around her and held her close, indicating she wanted to stay with her.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

but Ruth held onto her tightly (NCV)

But Ruth stayed with her. (NJB)

Ruth 1:15

Section 1:6–22: Naomi returned to Bethlehem with Ruth

This section talks about the next main event of the story, which is Naomi’s return to Bethlehem, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, Ruth.

Many scholars agree that verses 1:7–21 describe this event in detail, and that verse 1:22 is the closing verse of this section, which summarizes the event.

However, scholars do not agree about the function of verse 1:6. Some scholars believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. It says that Naomi arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and returned from the region of Moab. Thus, this section begins and ends with a summary description of the main event. NICOT (pages 99–100): The common Hebrew idiom *qûm* plus a verb of motion (*šûb*) also signals the start of the story’s main action: Then she...returned. Structurally, the idiom is a summary-introduction to the following events (vv. 7–21) and forms an *inclusio* with the chapter’s summary-conclusion (cf. *wattāšāb*, v. 22). Further, it sounds the chapter’s main theme, namely, the return of Naomi.

Some other scholars do not believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. Rather 1:6 describes the first part of the action. It says that she arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and prepared to return from the region of Moab.

The majority of versions follow the second suggestion. However, the first suggestion follows a pattern that is also in some other Hebrew narratives. An event is introduced by a summary statement, and the verses after it describe that event in detail. For example: Genesis 1:1 introduces the creation account of 1:2–31. Genesis 6:7 introduces the flood account of Genesis 6–9. Ruth 1:1–2 introduces the first section in Ruth 1:3–5. See the Note on 1:6b for more information.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi and Ruth Return to Bethlehem (NIV)

Naomi and Ruth Return (NLT)

Departure from Moab (GW)

1:15a

“Look,” said Naomi, “your sister-in-law has gone back to her people and her gods;

- Naomi said, “Look, your sister-in-law, Orpah, is returning to her own people and to her gods.”
- Naomi said to Ruth, “Listen, Orpah is returning to her clan and the gods that her clan worships.”

“Look,” said Naomi: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Look attracts attention to what the speaker will say next. Use a term in your language that calls for attention.

Here is another way to translate this word:

Listen!

said Naomi: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as said Naomi is more literally “And she said.” It begins the sentence. The BSB has placed these words in the middle of the sentence. You should put these words wherever they will be natural in your language.

Here is an example of the Hebrew order:

Naomi said to Ruth, “Look... (NCV)

your sister-in-law: The term sister-in-law means “the wife of your husband’s brother.” It refers to Orpah.

has gone back to her people and her gods: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as has gone back indicates a completed action. However, Orpah had not completed her journey back home. In some languages, it will be more natural to use a verb form that indicates that Orpah was in the process of returning home. This is why some versions translate this as “is going back.” For example:

your sister-in-law is going back (NIV)

her people: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as her people could mean “her family,” “her clan,” or “her nation.” Use a word that refers to a wide kinship group. This word was used in 1:10. You should translate it the same way in both places.

her gods: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as gods:

1. It is plural. It means “gods.” For example:

back to her people and to her gods (NRSV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. It is singular. It means “god.” For example:

back to her people and to her god (NJB) (GNT, NABRE, NET, NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions and commentaries.UBS, NICOT (page 116), WBC (page 82).

The words her gods refer to the gods that Orpah’s family worshiped in Moab.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Naomi said, “Look, your sister-in-law is going back to her own people and her own gods.” (NCV)

Naomi said to Ruth, “Look! Orpah is returning to her clan and to the gods they worship.”

1:15b follow her back home.”

- Return with her.”
- Follow her and go back to your relatives.”

follow her back home: Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Go back with her (NIV)

You should do the same. (NLT)

Ruth 1:16

Section 1:6–22: Naomi returned to Bethlehem with Ruth

This section talks about the next main event of the story, which is Naomi’s return to Bethlehem, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, Ruth.

Many scholars agree that verses 1:7–21 describe this event in detail, and that verse 1:22 is the closing verse of this section, which summarizes the event.

However, scholars do not agree about the function of verse 1:6. Some scholars believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. It says that Naomi arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and returned from the region of Moab. Thus, this section begins and ends with a summary description of the main event. NICOT (pages 99–100): The common Hebrew idiom *qûm* plus a verb of motion (*šûb*) also signals the start of the story’s main action: Then she...returned. Structurally, the idiom is a summary-introduction to the following events (vv. 7–21) and forms an *inclusio* with the chapter’s summary-conclusion (cf. *wattāšāb*, v. 22).

Further, it sounds the chapter's main theme, namely, the return of Naomi.

Some other scholars do not believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. Rather 1:6 describes the first part of the action. It says that she arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and prepared to return from the region of Moab.

The majority of versions follow the second suggestion. However, the first suggestion follows a pattern that is also in some other Hebrew narratives. An event is introduced by a summary statement, and the verses after it describe that event in detail. For example: Genesis 1:1 introduces the creation account of 1:2-31. Genesis 6:7 introduces the flood account of Genesis 6-9. Ruth 1:1-2 introduces the first section in Ruth 1:3-5. See the Note on 1:6b for more information.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi and Ruth Return to Bethlehem (NIV)

Naomi and Ruth Return (NLT)

Departure from Moab (GW)

Paragraph 1:16-18

Ruth's answer in verses 16-17 is in the form of parallel lines. Poetry in Hebrew consists of parallel lines. In these verses, the same meaning is stated twice in a similar way. It is recommended that you keep the form of the lines parallel if it is possible.

1:16a

But Ruth replied: "Do not urge me to leave you or to turn from following you."

- ¶ But Ruth said, "Do not beg me to separate from you or to turn back from accompanying you."
- ¶ But Ruth answered, "Please stop asking me to leave you. Stop asking me to turn away from you and go back to my family."

But Ruth replied: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a contrast between what Naomi said and Ruth's reply.

Do not urge me to leave you: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as urge means "to request something strongly." Naomi had been asking Ruth to go home for quite some time.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Don't plead with me to abandon you (CSB)

Do not keep begging me to leave you.

or to turn from following you: The clause turn from following you indicates leaving Naomi and returning to Moab. Here is another way to translate this clause:

Don't tell me to go back to Moab.

The clause turn from following you means the same as the clause "Don't urge me to leave you." Ruth said the same thing in two different ways for emphasis.

Here are some other ways to translate these two clauses:

Don't force me to leave you. Don't make me turn back from following you. (GW)

Don't ask me to leave you! Let me go with you! (GNT)

Stop urging me to abandon you! (NET)

1:16b

For wherever you go, I will go, and wherever you live, I will live;

- Wherever you^(sing) go, I will go, and wherever you settle, I will settle.
- If you go somewhere, I will go there too. If you live somewhere, I will live there too.

For wherever you go, I will go, and wherever you live, I will live: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as For can also be translated as "because." Ruth made it clear that she intended to go anywhere that Naomi went.

Here is another way to translate this Hebrew conjunction:

For where you go I will go (ESV)

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Where you go I will go and where you stay I will stay; (NIV)

Wherever you go, I will go. Wherever you sleep, I will sleep. (ERV)

1:16c

your people will be my people, and your God will be my God.

- Your people will become my people, and your God will become my God.
- I will belong to your clan, and I will worship the God that you worship.

your people will be my people, and your God will be my God: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as people was used in verses 10 and 15. This Hebrew word could mean “her family,” “her clan,” or “her nation.” You should translate this word the same way in all three places.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Your relatives will be my relatives, and the God you worship will be the God I worship (T4T)

Your clan will be my clan. I will obey the same God that you obey.

Ruth 1:17**Section 1:6–22: Naomi returned to Bethlehem with Ruth**

This section talks about the next main event of the story, which is Naomi’s return to Bethlehem, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, Ruth.

Many scholars agree that verses 1:7–21 describe this event in detail, and that verse 1:22 is the closing verse of this section, which summarizes the event.

However, scholars do not agree about the function of verse 1:6. Some scholars believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. It says that Naomi arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and returned from the region of Moab. Thus, this section begins and ends with a summary description of the main event. NICOT (pages 99–100): The common Hebrew idiom *qûm* plus a verb of motion (*šûb*) also signals the start of the story’s main action: Then she...returned. Structurally, the idiom is a summary-introduction to the following events (vv. 7–21) and forms an *inclusio* with the chapter’s summary-conclusion (cf. *wattāšāb*, v. 22). Further, it sounds the chapter’s main theme, namely, the return of Naomi.

Some other scholars do not believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. Rather 1:6 describes the first part of the action. It says that she arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and prepared to return from the region of Moab.

The majority of versions follow the second suggestion. However, the first suggestion follows a pattern that is also in some other Hebrew narratives. An event is introduced by a summary statement, and the verses after it describe that event in detail. For example: Genesis 1:1 introduces the creation account of 1:2–31. Genesis 6:7 introduces the flood account of Genesis 6–9. Ruth 1:1–2 introduces the first section in Ruth 1:3–5. See the Note on 1:6b for more information.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi and Ruth Return to Bethlehem (NIV)

Naomi and Ruth Return (NLT)

Departure from Moab (GW)

Paragraph 1:16–18

Ruth’s answer in verses 16–17 is in the form of parallel lines. Poetry in Hebrew consists of parallel lines. In these verses, the same meaning is stated twice in a similar way. It is recommended that you keep the form of the lines parallel if it is possible.

1:17a

Where you die, I will die, and there I will be buried.

- Wherever you die, I will stay until I die, and in that place I will be buried.
- The place where you die is where I intend to die, and in that place they will bury me.

Where you die, I will die, and there I will be buried:

Ruth meant that she intended to stay in Israel with Naomi’s people all her life, even after Naomi’s own death. Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Wherever you die, I will die, and I will be buried there with you. (GW)

I will die where you die and be buried beside you. (CEV)

1:17b

May the LORD punish me, and ever so severely, if anything but death separates you and me.”

- May Yahweh punish me strongly if anything except death causes me to leave you.”
- When one of us dies, then we^(dual/incl) will be separated. But if I leave you for any other reason, may Yahweh punish me very severely.”

May the LORD punish me, and ever so severely: The Hebrew words are more literally “Thus may Yahweh do to me, and thus may he add.” This was a way of making an oath or a solemn promise. The word “thus” refers to the punishment that Yahweh would give the person who did not keep the oath. Many languages have a specific way to indicate that someone is taking an oath.

Here are some other ways to translate this oath:

May the Lord punish me, and do so severely, (CSB)

May the Lord’s worst punishment come upon me (GNT)

May the Lord punish me severely if I do not keep my promise! (NET)

if anything but death separates you and me: There are two ways to interpret this Hebrew sentence:

1. It means that they will separate from each other only when one of them dies. For example:

May the Lord punish me severely if I do not keep my promise! Only death will be able to separate me from you! (NET) (BSB, ESV, GNT, KJV, NASB, NET, NIV84, NJPS, NLT)

1. It means that they will not be separated from each other even when they die, because they will be buried in the same place. For example:

May the Lord do so to me and more also if even death parts me from you. (RSV) (CEV, NABRE, NCV, NIV, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is followed by many English versions and most commentaries. WBC, NAC, KD, UBS.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

I will stay beside you until death makes us separate. If I ever leave you, the Lord should punish me. (EASY)

May Yahweh punish me severely if I separate from you. I will be separated from you only when one of us dies. (T4T)

Ruth 1:18

Section 1:6–22: Naomi returned to Bethlehem with Ruth

This section talks about the next main event of the story, which is Naomi’s return to Bethlehem, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, Ruth.

Many scholars agree that verses 1:7–21 describe this event in detail, and that verse 1:22 is the closing verse of this section, which summarizes the event.

However, scholars do not agree about the function of verse 1:6. Some scholars believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. It says that Naomi arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and returned from the region of Moab. Thus, this section begins and ends with a summary description of the main event. NICOT (pages 99–100): The common Hebrew idiom *qûm* plus a verb of motion (*šûb*) also signals the start of the story’s main action: Then she...returned. Structurally, the idiom is a summary-introduction to the following events (vv. 7–21) and forms an *inclusio* with the chapter’s summary-conclusion (cf. *wattāšāb*, v. 22). Further, it sounds the chapter’s main theme, namely, the return of Naomi.

Some other scholars do not believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. Rather 1:6 describes the first part of the action. It says that she arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and prepared to return from the region of Moab.

The majority of versions follow the second suggestion. However, the first suggestion follows a pattern that is also in some other Hebrew narratives. An event is introduced by a summary statement, and the verses after it describe that event in detail. For example: Genesis 1:1 introduces the creation account of 1:2–31. Genesis 6:7 introduces the flood account of Genesis 6–9. Ruth 1:1–2 introduces the first section in Ruth 1:3–5. See the Note on 1:6b for more information.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi and Ruth Return to Bethlehem (NIV)

Naomi and Ruth Return (NLT)

Departure from Moab (GW)

Paragraph 1:16–18

Ruth’s answer in verses 16–17 is in the form of parallel lines. Poetry in Hebrew consists of parallel lines. In these verses, the same meaning is stated twice in a

similar way. It is recommended that you keep the form of the lines parallel if it is possible.

1:18a

When Naomi saw that Ruth was determined to go with her,

- Then Naomi saw that Ruth had definitely decided to go with her,
- Then Naomi realized that Ruth would not return to her own country,

When Naomi saw that Ruth was determined to go with her: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as *was determined* indicates that Ruth had made a firm decision to go with Naomi.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

When Naomi saw that Ruth had made up her mind to go with her (CEV)

Naomi saw that Ruth wanted very much to go with her. (ERV)

Then Naomi understood that Ruth would not agree to return to her own country. (EASY)

1:18b

she stopped trying to persuade her.

- so she stopped begging her to return home.
- so she stopped telling Ruth to leave her.

she stopped trying to persuade her: Naomi stopped telling Ruth to return home. She did this because she knew that Ruth was determined to go with her.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

she stopped urging her to go back (CEV)

So Naomi stopped arguing with her. (ERV)

So she stopped saying that Ruth should leave her. (EASY)

Ruth 1:19

Section 1:6–22: Naomi returned to Bethlehem with Ruth

This section talks about the next main event of the story, which is Naomi's return to Bethlehem, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, Ruth.

Many scholars agree that verses 1:7–21 describe this event in detail, and that verse 1:22 is the closing verse of this section, which summarizes the event.

However, scholars do not agree about the function of verse 1:6. Some scholars believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. It says that Naomi arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and returned from the region of Moab. Thus, this section begins and ends with a summary description of the main event. NICOT (pages 99–100): The common Hebrew idiom *qûm* plus a verb of motion (*šûb*) also signals the start of the story's main action: Then she...returned. Structurally, the idiom is a summary-introduction to the following events (vv. 7–21) and forms an *inclusio* with the chapter's summary-conclusion (cf. *wattāšāb*, v. 22). Further, it sounds the chapter's main theme, namely, the return of Naomi.

Some other scholars do not believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. Rather 1:6 describes the first part of the action. It says that she arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and prepared to return from the region of Moab.

The majority of versions follow the second suggestion. However, the first suggestion follows a pattern that is also in some other Hebrew narratives. An event is introduced by a summary statement, and the verses after it describe that event in detail. For example: Genesis 1:1 introduces the creation account of 1:2–31. Genesis 6:7 introduces the flood account of Genesis 6–9. Ruth 1:1–2 introduces the first section in Ruth 1:3–5. See the Note on 1:6b for more information.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi and Ruth Return to Bethlehem (NIV)

Naomi and Ruth Return (NLT)

Departure from Moab (GW)

1:19a

So Naomi and Ruth traveled until they came to Bethlehem.

- ¶ Then the two^(dual) of them kept walking until they arrived at Bethlehem.
- ¶ So, Naomi and Ruth continued to travel/walk, and they arrived at the town of Bethlehem.

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as *So* introduces the next event in the story. Introduce the next event in a way that is natural in your language.

Naomi and Ruth traveled until they came to Bethlehem: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “they went on the two of them until they came to Bethlehem.”

If your language uses dual forms, you could use them here.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

So the two women went on until they came to Bethlehem. (NET)

They went on until they came to Bethlehem. (GNT)

Naomi and Ruth travelled together to Bethlehem. (EASY)

1:19b

When they entered Bethlehem, the whole city was stirred because of them,

- When they^(dual/plur) arrived in Bethlehem, people throughout the whole town were excited to see them.
- They entered Bethlehem, and all the people in the town were surprised when they saw them.

When they entered Bethlehem: This clause links the previous sentence with the event that happened next.

the whole city was stirred because of them: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as stirred means “excited” or “agitated.” All the people of the town were very surprised to see Naomi return home after many years away.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

the entire town was excited by their arrival (NLT)

When they entered Bethlehem, all the people became very excited. (NCV)

1:19c

and the women of the city exclaimed, “Can this be Naomi?”

- The women asked each other, “Is this really Naomi?”
- The women shouted, “Amazing! It is Naomi!”

and: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as and introduces the next event.

the women of the city exclaimed: Here are some other ways to translate this:

The women who lived there asked (NCV)

and the women said (NRSV)

Can this be Naomi?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses surprise. The women were surprised that Naomi had come back after she had been gone for many years. There are at least three ways to translate this question to express surprise.

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Is it really Naomi? (NLT)

- Use a statement. For example:

Surely this cannot be Naomi!

- Use a statement followed by a tag question. For example:

This can’t be Naomi, can it? (GW)

Some languages may have an idiom or phrase that expresses surprise. For example:

How on earth can this be Naomi?

Ruth 1:20

Section 1:6–22: Naomi returned to Bethlehem with Ruth

This section talks about the next main event of the story, which is Naomi’s return to Bethlehem, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, Ruth.

Many scholars agree that verses 1:7–21 describe this event in detail, and that verse 1:22 is the closing verse of this section, which summarizes the event.

However, scholars do not agree about the function of verse 1:6. Some scholars believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. It says that Naomi arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and returned from the region of Moab. Thus, this section begins and ends with a summary description of the main event. NICOT (pages 99–100): The common Hebrew idiom *qûm* plus a verb of motion (*šûb*) also signals the start of the story’s main action: Then she...returned. Structurally, the idiom is a summary-introduction to the following events (vv. 7–21) and forms an *inclusio* with the chapter’s summary-conclusion (cf. *wattāšāb*, v. 22). Further, it sounds the chapter’s main theme, namely, the return of Naomi.

Some other scholars do not believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. Rather 1:6 describes the first part of the action. It says that she arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and prepared to return from the region of Moab.

The majority of versions follow the second suggestion. However, the first suggestion follows a pattern that is also in some other Hebrew narratives. An event is introduced by a summary statement, and the verses after it describe that event in detail. For example: Genesis 1:1 introduces the creation account of 1:2–31. Genesis 6:7 introduces the flood account of Genesis 6–9. Ruth 1:1–2 introduces the first section in Ruth 1:3–5. See the Note on 1:6b for more information.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi and Ruth Return to Bethlehem (NIV)

Naomi and Ruth Return (NLT)

Departure from Moab (GW)

1:20a

“Do not call me Naomi,” she replied. “Call me Mara,

- But Naomi said to them, “Do not call me Naomi any more. Call me Mara instead,
- But Naomi said, “My name should no longer be Naomi happy/pleasant. My name should now be Mara bitter.

Do not call me Naomi: The Hebrew name Naomi means “happy, pleasant.” The original readers would have understood that Naomi was telling the women that she was not happy.

she replied: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as she replied occurs at the beginning of the sentence. The BSB has placed these words in the middle of the verse for reasons of English style. It may be more natural in your language to put them at the beginning of the sentence. For example:

But she replied to them, “Don’t call me ‘Naomi’!
Call me ‘Mara’ (NET)

Call me Mara: The Hebrew name Mara means “bitter.” The original readers would have understood that Naomi was telling the women that now she was bitter and unhappy. This is the same Hebrew word as was used in verse 13. If possible, you should translate it with the same word in both places.

There are two ways to help the readers of your language understand why Naomi said this.

- Explain the meaning of these names in a footnote. For example:

FOOTNOTE: The name Naomi means “happy” in Hebrew. The name Mara means “bitter” in Hebrew.

- Explain the meaning within the text of the verse. For example:

Don’t call me Naomi [sweet]. Call me Mara [bitter]
(GW)

1:20b

because the Almighty has dealt quite bitterly with me.

- because the All-powerful One has brought lots of trouble into my life.
- The Almighty God has brought bitter things into my life.

because: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason why Naomi wanted the women to call her bitter.

the Almighty has dealt quite bitterly with me: The Hebrew term that the BSB translates as the Almighty is one of the names for God. The exact meaning of this term is uncertain. It probably refers to God’s power.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

God all powerful (ERV)

God who has all power

Almighty God (GNT)

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The Mighty One has made my life very bitter.
(NIRV)

God All Powerful has made my life very sad. (ICB)

For the All-powerful has brought much trouble to me. (NLV)

Ruth 1:21

Section 1:6–22: Naomi returned to Bethlehem with Ruth

This section talks about the next main event of the story, which is Naomi's return to Bethlehem, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, Ruth.

Many scholars agree that verses 1:7–21 describe this event in detail, and that verse 1:22 is the closing verse of this section, which summarizes the event.

However, scholars do not agree about the function of verse 1:6. Some scholars believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. It says that Naomi arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and returned from the region of Moab. Thus, this section begins and ends with a summary description of the main event. NICOT (pages 99–100): The common Hebrew idiom *qûm* plus a verb of motion (*šûb*) also signals the start of the story's main action: Then she...returned. Structurally, the idiom is a summary-introduction to the following events (vv. 7–21) and forms an *inclusio* with the chapter's summary-conclusion (cf. *wattāšāb*, v. 22). Further, it sounds the chapter's main theme, namely, the return of Naomi.

Some other scholars do not believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. Rather 1:6 describes the first part of the action. It says that she arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and prepared to return from the region of Moab.

The majority of versions follow the second suggestion. However, the first suggestion follows a pattern that is also in some other Hebrew narratives. An event is introduced by a summary statement, and the verses after it describe that event in detail. For example: Genesis 1:1 introduces the creation account of 1:2–31. Genesis 6:7 introduces the flood account of Genesis 6–9. Ruth 1:1–2 introduces the first section in Ruth 1:3–5. See the Note on 1:6b for more information.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi and Ruth Return to Bethlehem (NIV)

Naomi and Ruth Return (NLT)

Departure from Moab (GW)

1:21a

I went away full, but the LORD has brought me back empty.

- I had much when I left here, but Yahweh has brought me back with nothing.
- When I left here, I was rich with a family. But Yahweh has caused me to return poor, with no family.

I went away full, but the LORD has brought me back empty: The words full and empty are a figure of speech. Naomi was full when she left Bethlehem in the sense that she had a husband and two sons. When she returned to Bethlehem, she was empty because they were dead. In some languages, it will not be possible to use the words full and empty in this way.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

When I left, I had all I wanted, but now, the Lord has brought me home with nothing. (NCV)

I left here with everything that I needed. Now the Lord has brought me back here with nothing. (EASY)

1:21b

Why call me Naomi?

- Is there any reason to call me Naomi? No.
- Do not call me Naomi any more.

Why call me Naomi?: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a rebuke. Naomi had already said in 1:20a that the name Naomi did not fit her current bitter situation.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

There is no reason to call me Naomi.

Do not call me Naomi any more.

1:21c

After all, the LORD has testified against me,

- Yahweh has spoken/testified against me.
- Yahweh has turned against me.

the LORD has testified against me: There is a textual issue with the Hebrew verb phrase that the BSB translates as testified against me:

1. The Masoretic Text says Yahweh has testified against me. It means “to testify against,” as in a court case. For example:

the Lord has testified against me (ESV)

the Lord has spoken against me (NCV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, KJV, NABRE, NASB, NET, NJB, REB)

1. The Septuagint says Yahweh has afflicted me. For example:

the Lord has dealt harshly with me (NRSV) (GW, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with many versions and commentaries. UBS, WBC, NICOT. It is also recommended by HOTTP.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

The Lord Almighty has condemned me (GNT)

The Almighty Lord has turned against me (EASY)

the Lord has opposed me (CSB)

1:21d

and the Almighty has afflicted me.”

- The All-powerful one has caused me to suffer.”
- The Almighty God has brought disaster on me.”

the Almighty has afflicted me: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as afflicted can also be translated as “cause suffering,” “cause evil,” or “cause trouble.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

has caused me to suffer (NET)

and made my life so hard (CEV)

has given much trouble to me (ERV)

the Almighty: The term the Almighty is the same name for God that Naomi used in 1:20b. You should translate it the same way in both places.

Ruth 1:22

Section 1:6–22: Naomi returned to Bethlehem with Ruth

This section talks about the next main event of the story, which is Naomi’s return to Bethlehem, accompanied by her daughter-in-law, Ruth.

Many scholars agree that verses 1:7–21 describe this event in detail, and that verse 1:22 is the closing verse of this section, which summarizes the event.

However, scholars do not agree about the function of verse 1:6. Some scholars believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. It says that Naomi arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and returned from the region of Moab. Thus, this section begins and ends with a summary description of the main event. NICOT (pages 99–100): The common Hebrew idiom *qûm* plus a verb of motion (*šûb*) also signals the start of the story’s main action: Then she...returned. Structurally, the idiom is a summary-introduction to the following events (vv. 7–21) and forms an *inclusio* with the chapter’s summary-conclusion (cf. *wattāšāb*, v. 22). Further, it sounds the chapter’s main theme, namely, the return of Naomi.

Some other scholars do not believe that verse 1:6 is a summary introduction. Rather 1:6 describes the first part of the action. It says that she arose (she and her daughters-in-law) and prepared to return from the region of Moab.

The majority of versions follow the second suggestion. However, the first suggestion follows a pattern that is also in some other Hebrew narratives. An event is introduced by a summary statement, and the verses after it describe that event in detail. For example: Genesis 1:1 introduces the creation account of 1:2–31. Genesis 6:7 introduces the flood account of Genesis 6–9. Ruth 1:1–2 introduces the first section in Ruth 1:3–5. See the Note on 1:6b for more information.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Naomi and Ruth Return to Bethlehem (NIV)

Naomi and Ruth Return (NLT)

Departure from Moab (GW)

1:22a

So Naomi returned from the land of Moab with her daughter-in-law Ruth the Moabite.

- ¶ So, Naomi returned from the land of Moab, and her daughter-in-law Ruth, a woman from Moab, came with her.
- ¶ So this was how Naomi came back from the country of Moab, and how Ruth, her Moabite daughter-in-law, came to be with her.

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as *So* indicates that what follows is a summary. This clause summarizes verses 6 through 21 and sets the scene for the next part of the story. Introduce this summary in a natural way in your language.

Naomi returned from the land of Moab with her daughter-in-law Ruth the Moabite:

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

So Naomi came back from the territory of Moab with her daughter-in-law Ruth the Moabite. (CSB)

This, then, was how Naomi came back from Moab with Ruth, her Moabite daughter-in-law. (GNT)

1:22b

And they arrived in Bethlehem at the beginning of the barley harvest.

- They arrived^(dual/plur) in Bethlehem just as the barley harvest was beginning.
- At the time they reached the town of Bethlehem, people were just beginning to harvest the barley.

And they arrived in Bethlehem at the beginning of the barley harvest: The Hebrew text begins a new sentence here. This may be more natural in many languages. For example:

When they arrived in Bethlehem, the barley harvest was just beginning. (GNT)

barley harvest: The barley harvest was in late April or early May. Barley is a grain, like rice, corn, or millet. The grains grow in a cluster at the top of a thin stalk. People use the stalks and the grains as animal food, and they grind the barley grains into flour and make bread. If you have translated any of the following books, you should check these references to see how you translated “barley” there: John 6:9, Exodus 9:31, Judges 7:13.

If people in your culture are not familiar with barley, here are some ways you can translate it:

- Use a word from the national or trade language and explain it in a footnote.
- Use an expression like “a grain called barley.”
- If no grain is grown in your area, it may be possible to use an expression like “grass with edible seeds.”
- It may be helpful to include a picture.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

They arrived in Bethlehem in late spring, at the beginning of the barley harvest. (NLT)

The barley harvest was just beginning when Naomi and Ruth, her Moabite daughter-in-law, arrived in Bethlehem. (CEV)

Ruth 2:1

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

2:1a

Now Naomi had a relative on her husband's side,

- ¶ Now, there was a man living in Bethlehem who was related to Naomi's husband.
- ¶ A certain man there was a relative/cousin of Naomi's husband Elimelech, who had died.

Now Naomi had a relative on her husband's side:

This verse begins a new part of the story (2:1–23). It introduces an important character, Boaz, before he begins to speak or act in 2:4. This verse gives background information about Boaz. (See the Appendix, “Introduction to the Discourse Structure,” for more discussion about this.)

Introduce this verse in a way that is natural in your language to either begin a new part of the story or to indicate background information, or both. The BSB and many other English versions do this with the word *Now*. Used in this way, *Now* indicates a break in the sequence of actions from chapter 1. It is not a time word.

Naomi had a relative on her husband's side: The phrase on her husband's side means that Boaz and Naomi were related because of her marriage with Elimelech. The text does not exactly explain the relationship between Boaz and Elimelech, but it was a close one (see 2:20). Boaz may have been a cousin to Elimelech. He was not a "brother" in the sense of having the same father and mother. Probably Boaz was about the same age as Elimelech would have been if he were still alive. Use the correct kinship term in your language for such a relationship.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

who belonged to the family of her husband Elimelech (GNT)

There was a cousin to the former/deceased husband of Naomi

2:1a-b (combined/reordered)

- Now Naomi was related to a rich and respected/influential person through her deceased/former husband, Elimelech. The relative's name was Boaz.

2:1b

a prominent man of noble character from the clan of Elimelech, whose name was Boaz.

- His name was Boaz. He was a rich and important person from the same clan as Elimelech.
- In fact, he was from the same extended family. He was a respected man of outstanding/high character, and his name was Boaz.

a prominent man of noble character from the clan of Elimelech, whose name was Boaz: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as a prominent man of noble character has a several possible meanings. It is literally "a mighty man of strength/wealth/ability/character." Most often in the Hebrew Scriptures, the phrase describes a mighty warrior. But in the context of Ruth, it describes Boaz as an important and influential man in Bethlehem due to his wealth and good character.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

a rich and important man (CEV)

a respected man of outstanding character

a wealthy, prominent man (NET)

from the clan of Elimelech: Boaz was from the same extended family as Elimelech. The clan of Elimelech does not identify Elimelech as the head of the clan. Rather, Boaz and Elimelech shared a common ancestor. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as clan refers here to a unit smaller than a tribe (as in "tribe of Judah") but larger than a immediate family of parents and children. Some commentators such as Bush (Word) and Campbell (Anchor Bible) suggest that the Hebrew word *mišpāḥâ* here refers to something larger than extended family. But the words clan and extended family are quite fluid and dependent on context to determine their relative size. A clan (or sub-clan) is a large extended family.

Here is another way to translate this:

from the same extended family as Elimelech

General Comment on 2:1a-b

There is some repetition of information about Boaz. For example, saying that Boaz was a relative of Elimelech is similar to saying that he was from the same clan as Elimelech. In some languages, it may be more natural to combine and/or reorder some of this information. For example:

Now there was a man named Boaz who was from the same clan as Naomi's husband. He/Boaz was wealthy and respected.

See 2:1a-b (combined/reordered) in the Display for another example.

Ruth 2:2

Section 2:1-23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

2:2a

And Ruth the Moabitess said to Naomi,

- One day Ruth the Moabite said to Naomi,
- Then Ruth, who was a woman from the land/country of Moab, said to her mother-in-law, Naomi,

And: This verse continues the story from 1:22b after the background information in 2:1. In some languages, it may be helpful to use a phrase. For example:

One day, (GNT)

Then,

Ruth the Moabitess said to Naomi: Here, the Moabitess means “the woman from Moab.” (See Ruth 1:4, 22.) The identification that Ruth is a Moabite occurs seven times in the book to draw attention to her being a foreigner.

2:2b

“Please let me go into the fields and glean heads of grain after someone in whose sight I may find favor.”

- “Allow me go to the field to glean stalks/ears of grain, gathering them behind anyone who shows me goodwill/favor.”
- “I ask you to permit me to go to the fields and pick up grain/barley that was not gathered by the harvesters. I will look for someone who is kind to me to let me follow him.”

Please let me go into the fields: Ruth was asking Naomi for permission to go to the fields to glean. Use the form that younger women use to ask older women for permission to do something.

the fields: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as fields is singular. It probably refers to the entire area where crops were planted near Bethlehem. Different people owned different parts of the area, with the boundaries probably marked by rows or piles of stones. You should use a term that refers to this general area where people plant their crops.

and glean heads of grain: In Hebrew, the expression that the BSB translates as glean heads of grain includes the technical verb “to glean.” (See “Gleaning

and Harvesting” under “Important Cultural Items To Understand” in the Introduction for an explanation.) This refers to gathering grain that had fallen to the ground or that the reapers had not cut (intentionally or accidentally). If your language does not have a specific word for “glean,” you may need to use a brief description. If you do use a descriptive phrase like this, you may want to use a shortened form of it for some of the later occurrences of “glean.”

Here are some other ways to translate this:

gather the grain that the harvest workers leave (GNT)

pick the grain left behind by the reapers (GW)

pick up the remaining stalks of grain

gather grain after the harvesters

It may be helpful for you to insert a footnote here that explains that Old Testament law gave poor people the right to pick up grain that was left uncut or dropped. Here is a suggested footnote:

Old Testament law gave instructions to not harvest all the grain in a field at harvest time. Poor people, strangers, widows, and orphans had the right to harvest this grain that was left so they would have food. See Leviticus 19:9-10 and Deuteronomy 24:19-22.

heads of grain: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as heads of grain refers to stalks of grain including the grain itself (also referred to in English as the “ear” of the grain; NRSV, for example, “the ears of grain”). If you have a specific term in your language for “stalks of grain” or “heads/ears of grain,” consider using it here. We know from Ruth 1:22 (and 2:22) that they were harvesting barley. If you don’t have a general word for grain, but have a word for barley (or similar grain like wheat), you could use it here.

after someone: The Hebrew preposition that the BSB translates as after refers to coming along behind the owner or his workers had completed cutting grain in an area to harvest it. This preposition can refer to either place or time. In this case, both are true. The gleaner worked in the field physically “behind” the other workers. In relation to time, he or she gleaned “after” the workers had finished harvesting grain and removed the bundles from that part of the

field. Commentaries consistently cite two books where the process of gleaning is described and this point is made: Dalman, *Arbeit und Sitte*, 3:46–47, 62, and Borowski, *Agriculture in Iron Age Israel*, 59–61. But if your language does not have a preposition which can refer to both time or place in this way, choose one which refers to time, “after” the harvest workers.

in whose sight I may find favor: The Hebrew idiom often translated “to find favor in [someone’s] eyes” means to receive approval, favor, or goodwill from a person. Since the LORD had commanded his people to allow poor people to glean, it was not necessary to ask permission. However, Ruth wanted to glean in a field where the owner would treat her kindly. Because she was a foreigner, she realized that some owners might not be pleased to have her glean in their fields and might not allow it, in spite of the law.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

who shows me favor/goodwill

who treats me kindly/well

anyone who is kind enough to let me do it (NLT)

who will permit me to do that

2:2c

“Go ahead, my daughter,” Naomi replied.

- Naomi answered her, “You may go, my daughter.”
- Naomi replied, “Yes. Go and do that, my dear daughter-in-law.”

“Go ahead, my daughter,” Naomi replied: The Hebrew command that the BSB translates as Go ahead simply means “Go.” Naomi was giving Ruth permission to do as she asked. Make sure your translation includes this idea of giving permission.

my daughter: In some languages, it may be necessary to say “dear daughter-in-law.” Use the expression mothers-in-law use in your language to express affection to their daughters-in-law. See how you translated 1:11a.

Ruth 2:3

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this

time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

2:3a

So Ruth departed and went out into the field and gleaned after the harvesters.

- ¶ And Ruth went out of the village to the field and began to gather up leftover grain there behind the workers who were harvesting/cutting it.
- ¶ So Ruth left Naomi and went to the fields. She began to pick up grain/barley in a field behind the harvest workers.

So: After receiving permission from Naomi, Ruth went and began to glean. The BSB (and other English versions) connects 2:3 to 2:2 with the conjunction So to indicate that what Ruth did was as a result of what Naomi said in 2:2c (“Go”). Connect these verses in a way that is natural in your language.

Ruth departed and went out into the field and gleaned: Ruth left her home in the village and went out to the fields. She chose a field in which to work and started to gather the leftover grain there.

gleaned: See the translation advice at 2:2 under “and glean heads of grain.”

after the harvesters: This means that Ruth walked along picking up grain after and behind the workers who were harvesting the grain.

harvesters: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as harvesters refers to workers who cut or reap grain or grass using some type of cutting tool. The harvesters in Ruth’s time would have used a curved knife called a sickle. Here the term may be used to include all the workers who had a part in the harvest, both the

cutters and those who followed behind to gather the cut grain.

2:3b

And she happened to come to the part of the field belonging to Boaz,

- It was by luck/chance that the field belonged to Boaz,
- It so happened that she had entered a field whose owner was Boaz,
- She did not know at that time that she was working/gleaning in a field that belonged to Boaz.

And she happened to come to the part of the field belonging to Boaz:

The Hebrew words that the BSB translate as she happened to are more literally “her chance chanced upon.” Bush (Word), Hubbard (NICOT) and Schipper (AY) all give this as the literal rendering in their commentaries. Of the many fields in which she could have chosen to glean, Ruth happened to go to one that belonged to Boaz, a relative of her deceased father-in-law, Elimelech. From a human point of view, this was an accidental or unplanned event. It appears that Ruth did not know who owned the field in which she worked. At the same time, the reader of the book of Ruth can understand that God was behind the choice of field.

You should translate this in a way that indicates that Ruth’s choice of this particular field was not intentional on her part. It was coincidental. Here are some other ways to translate these words:

and, as luck would have it, it was the piece of land belonging to Boaz (NJPS)

Chance led her to a plot of land belonging to Boaz (NJB)

It just so happened that the field belonged to Boaz (NCV)

2:3c

who was from the clan of Elimelech.

- who was of/from the same clan as Elimelech.
- He was the relative who belonged to the same extended family that Elimelech belonged to.

who was from the clan of Elimelech: Boaz was from the same clan or extended family as Elimelech, Ruth’s father-in-law. This is repeated here for emphasis.

Ruth 2:4

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

2:4a

Just then Boaz arrived from Bethlehem and said to the harvesters,

- ¶ While she was there, Boaz himself arrived at that field from Bethlehem. He greeted the workers who were harvesting/cutting grain by saying to them,
- ¶ Some time later, Boaz left the village of Bethlehem and came to this particular field. He said to his harvest workers,

Just then Boaz arrived from Bethlehem: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Just then functions to draw attention to someone or something significant in the narrative. Here it probably highlights the seeming coincidence of Boaz’s arrival. In verse 3, we learned that Ruth, by chance, went to glean at a field owned by Boaz. Now Boaz happened to arrive in person at the same time that Ruth was there. If you have a word that functions as an attention-getter, consider using it here.

Here are some ways to draw attention to this event or to the person Boaz:

Now behold (NASB)

Boaz, as it happened,... (NJB)

and there was Boaz himself (REB)

Apparently Boaz was coming from his home in the village to the field to check on his workers. He probably arrived a few hours after Ruth's arrival at the field. We know from what the foreman says in verse 7 that Ruth had already worked "from morning until now." And Boaz's arrival was before the noon meal mentioned in verse 14.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Some time later Boaz himself arrived from Bethlehem (GNT)

While she was there, Boaz arrived from Bethlehem (NLT)

Soon Boaz came from Bethlehem (NCV)

and said to the harvesters:

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he said to the harvest workers (CEV)

and greeted his workers (NCV)

2:4b

"The LORD be with you."

- "May Yahweh be with you."
- "I pray that Yahweh will help you."

The LORD be with you: This is a greeting that is in the form of a blessing or short prayer. Boaz greeted his workers by expressing his desire that the LORD would be present with them.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

May the LORD be with all of you! (GW)

Yahweh be with you! (NJB)

I pray that the Lord will help you (EASY)

2:4c

"The LORD bless you," they replied.

- They answered, "May Yahweh bless you too."
- The harvest workers replied/responded, "We pray that Yahweh will be kind/good to you."

The LORD bless you: The workers responded by asking the LORD to bless or "do good actions" to benefit Boaz.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

May the LORD bless you! (GW)

Yahweh bless you! (NJB)

We pray that Yahweh will reward you

We ask that Yahweh give you success

they replied: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as replied is the general verb meaning "to say." The BSB has chosen the English verb replied because they responded to Boaz's greeting with a greeting for him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

they called back (NIV84)

they answered (NIV)

they greeted him in return

Notice that the BSB has placed the phrase they replied at the end of the verse. In Hebrew, these words occur at the beginning. You should place them wherever it would be natural in your language.

Ruth 2:5

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

2:5a

And Boaz asked the foreman of his harvesters,

- Then Boaz asked the servant who was in charge of those harvesting/cutting grain,
- Boaz asked the man in charge of the other workers,

And Boaz asked the foreman of his harvesters: This refers to the man who was in charge of Boaz's harvest workers. He was Boaz's servant, but Boaz had made him the leader of the other harvesters.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Then Boaz asked his servant in charge of the workers (NCV)

Boaz asked the man in charge (GNT)

2:5b

"Whose young woman is this?"

- "To whom is that young woman related?"
- "To what family does that young woman belong?"

Whose young woman is this?: Boaz was asking to whom Ruth was related or associated. He was wondering whose wife or daughter she was, or perhaps whose servant she was.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

To what family does that young woman belong?

To whom is that young woman related?"

young woman: We know from Ruth 1:4 that Ruth had married Mahlon about ten years before this time. So she may have been approximately twenty-five years old. Use a word for young woman that shows respect and is fitting for a woman of this age.

this: You should use a word for this which is natural in this context for a man to use in pointing out someone a short distance away.

Ruth 2:6

Section 2:1-23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this

time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

2:6a

The foreman answered,

- The servant answered,
- The man in charge replied,

2:6b

"She is the Moabitess who returned with Naomi from the land of Moab.

- "She is the young woman from Moab, the one who returned with Naomi from that country.
- "She is from the land/country of Moab. She is the one who came back from there with Naomi.

2:6a-b

The foreman answered, "She is the Moabitess who returned with Naomi from the land of Moab: In the Hebrew text, the foreman, or overseer, first explained that Ruth was a young Moabite woman. Then he added that she was the one who returned with Naomi from Moab. He implied that Boaz already knew that one of Naomi's daughters-in-law had returned with her.

The foreman's response may reflect a negative, neutral, or positive attitude. There is no consensus among the scholars. For this reason, it is recommended that you translate (and express in oral or video translation) the attitude of the foreman in a neutral way. He simply responded in a truthful way to Boaz's question.

Here are some other ways to translate these verse parts:

And the foreman replied, “She is the young woman from Moab who came back with Naomi. (NLT)

The servant who was in charge of the reapers answered, “She is the Moabite who came back with Naomi from the country of Moab. (NRSV)

Ruth 2:7

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

2:7a

She has said, ‘Please let me glean and gather among the sheaves after the harvesters.’

- She asked me, ‘May I please pick up grain here and gather it into bundles behind/after the harvesters?’
- She politely asked me if she could follow the other workers and gather the grain that they had left.

She has said, ‘Please let me glean and gather among the sheaves after the harvesters.’: The foreman was reporting Ruth’s words. So Ruth’s words were reported as direct speech embedded in the speech of the foreman. Translate this in whatever way is natural in your language, using either direct or indirect speech.

Here are some ways to do this using indirect speech:

She asked if she might glean.... (REB)

She asked me to let her follow the workers and gather grain. (GNT)

Please let me glean and gather among the sheaves after the harvesters: There is a textual issue in this verse part:

1. The Masoretic Text includes the words which the BSB translates as among the sheaves. Ruth either asked to gather among the sheaves or “into sheaves.” (See the note just below addressing the interpretation issue.) For example:

She asked, ‘May I follow the harvesters and gather grain among the bundles?’ (NET) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NABRE, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NRSV, REB)

1. The words among the sheaves are omitted. Support for this text is found in the Syriac and Vulgate translations. Ruth only asked to follow after or behind the harvesters and gather grain. For example:

‘Please let me follow the workers cutting grain and gather what they leave behind.’ (NCV) (CEV, GNT, NCV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions. This interpretation also has strong textual support. The LXX also includes the words in question (*καὶ συναῶν ἐν τοῖς δράγμασιν*). HOTTP supports the MT reading with a B-rating. The inclusion of these words, and particularly if they are interpreted to mean “among the sheaves/bundles,” creates the difficulty of Ruth asking for special privilege in her gleaning. So, many scholars support the text that includes them as the more difficult reading. UBS recommends textual reading (2), but they seem to exaggerate the difficulty of the MT reading and the textual support for omitting the words “among the sheaves” (only the Syriac and Vulgate).

Normally in Jewish practice, gleaners were not permitted to begin to glean in a field until the harvesters had finished their work and removed their bundles of grain from the field. As a result, the Hebrew words that the BSB translates as among the sheaves have different emphases. Ruth may have wanted to gather grain into “sheaves/bundles” after the harvesters had finished their work. She may also have wanted to gather grain at the same time as the other women harvesters. Bush (Word), in particular, makes a detailed and cogent case for “after the harvesters.” About Ruth he says: “Ruth was a stranger and a foreigner. It would be almost unthinkable for her to have requested the

right to glean ‘among the sheaves,’ a right of gleanage that far exceeded anything accorded by custom to native Bethlehemites. It could have caused her only the ill will and enmity of all the other women whom circumstances (cf. Deut 24:19) had also driven to the exigencies of the poverty stricken.” Commentators who support versions like the NIV reinterpret the character of Ruth based on the assumption that she asks for special privilege in gleaning. They describe her as “courageous” and “brash” (Hubbard) or “resolute” and “stubborn” (Block).

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

‘I would like to gather the gleanings into sheaves after the harvesters.’ (NABRE)

She asked me this morning if she could gather grain behind the harvesters. (NLT)

She said, ‘Please let me gather grain. I will only gather among the bundles behind the reapers.’ (GW)

Translate in a way that shows that Ruth was being polite and humble. She was also determined to provide for the needs of Naomi and herself.

You may want to include a footnote to explain that Ruth asked for a special privilege in gleaning that went beyond what was customary. Here is a suggested footnote:

While it is not stated specifically in the Old Testament, scholars believe that the custom was that gleaners could only glean in a field after the harvesters had completed their work and removed their bundles of grain. Ruth requested the special privilege to glean close to his woman workers at the same time as they were bundling the harvest.

sheaves: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as sheaves means stalks of grain that have been gathered into a “bundle.” A bundle was often the amount formed by filling the arms with stalks of grain. A sheaf is a bundle that has been tied or bound. Sheaves were left in the fields until they were gathered up and taken to the threshing floor.

2:7b

So she came out and has continued from morning until now,

- Since she arrived this morning, she has remained in the field working all the time.
- I permitted her to work/glean, and she started to glean. She has continued from early morning until now.

So she came out and has continued: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as has continued has a range of meaning including “stand, continue, remain.” In this context, it probably means that she “remained.” Many versions are ambiguous about where Ruth remained. The context seems to indicate that Ruth continued to work in the field after the foreman had given her permission to do so.

Some versions make explicit what Ruth did in the field. For example:

She asked if she could pick up grain left by the harvest workers (CEV)

She asked me to let her follow the workers and gather grain. (GNT)

from morning until now: This is literally “from then, the morning, and until now.” “From then” probably refers to the time when the foreman had talked to Ruth. He was saying that Ruth had stayed in their field and worked steadily at gleaning. For example:

She has been hard at work ever since (NLT)

now: The workers had probably come early in the morning. It was later when Boaz came to see how they were doing. It may have been mid-morning, since the mealtime at midday mentioned in 2:14a seems to have been a little later.

2:7c

except that she rested a short time in the shelter.”

- She has only rested for a short time in the shelter.”
- However, she did stop for a few moments to sit in the shade of the hut.”

There are two textual issues in this part of the verse.

except that she rested a short time: One textual issue has to do with the Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as except that she rested a short time:

1. The Hebrew Masoretic text says that Ruth rested in the shelter for a short time (literally “a little”). That is, she worked for most of the morning but took a brief rest. For example:

except for a few minutes' rest (NLT)

She has stopped only a few moments to rest (NCV) (BSB, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NABRE, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB)

1. The LXX (Septuagint) indicates that Ruth did not rest at all. For example:

without resting even for a moment (NRSV) (CEV, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1).

in the shelter: The other textual issue has to do with the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as in the shelter:

1. The Masoretic text includes the word that the BSB translates as in the shelter. For example:

except for a short rest in the shelter (NIV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, REB, NET, GW, NLT, NCV, KJV, NASB, NJPS)

1. The Septuagint (LXX) does not include a word meaning "house" or shelter. For example:

with hardly a rest (NJB) (CEV, ESV, NABRE, NJB, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1).

shelter: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as shelter (literally "house") was probably a temporary building that provided shade for the harvest workers when they rested. Perhaps it was built with poles and had a roof made from leafy branches or straw. People in many cultures build some similar type of temporary shelter when their garden or field is not near their homes. If your language has a name for such a shelter, use it here. NET note.

Ruth 2:8

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic

and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

Paragraph 2:8–13

In this paragraph, Boaz told Ruth that she should stay and glean in his field along with his other women workers. He told her that he had instructed the young men not to bother her. He also said that she should feel free to drink from the water jars that the young men had filled. Ruth asked Boaz why he was being so kind to her. He replied that he had heard about everything she had done for her mother-in-law. He had also heard about her decision to leave her homeland and come to live with people she did not previously know.

2:8a

Then Boaz said to Ruth, "Listen, my daughter.

- ¶ So Boaz said to Ruth, "I consider you to be like my own daughter, so pay attention to me.
- ¶ Then Boaz went to Ruth and said, "Dear young lady, be sure to do what I will tell you.

Then Boaz said to Ruth: After hearing from his foreman who Ruth was and understanding her situation, he responded in 2:8–9 with kind instructions to Ruth.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

So Boaz said to Ruth (NIV)

Boaz went over and said to Ruth (NLT)

Listen: Boaz spoke to Ruth gently but forcefully. He wanted her to be sure to follow his instructions in 2:8–9, which were for her own good.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Listen carefully, my dear! (NLT)

Let me give you some advice. (GNT)

my daughter: Boaz was older than Ruth and had greater social status than her, but he spoke to her in a gentle way and addressed her as a father to a daughter. You should use a term that shows respect and kindness from a man, older and more important, to a younger woman.

One way to use the word daughter and avoid the literal meaning is to use a simile. For example:

You are like a daughter to me

Although daughter may be appropriate in some languages, a different term such as “little sister” may be better in others.

In some languages, it may not be appropriate to use a kinship term at all because Boaz was only related to her by marriage. If it is not appropriate for you to use a kinship term, here are some other ways to translate this:

You are a woman whom I respect.

Dear young lady,

2:8b

Do not go and glean in another field, and do not go away from this place,

- Do not go/leave to gather grain in any other field. You must not leave this field.
- Stay and pick up grain/barley only in my fields. Be sure not to go into someone else’s fields.

Do not go and glean in another field, and do not go away from this place: Boaz told Ruth to stay in his fields. He did not want her to glean in any fields that belonged to other people. Notice that these two clauses have essentially the same meaning. This is good Hebrew style. The repetition adds emphasis to Boaz’s instruction that Ruth should glean only in his fields.

The verb form used in the second clause strengthens the meaning of the first. It may imply that Ruth should be sure not to cross boundary markers to go into someone else’s field. Bush (Word) in particular argues for this sense. He appeals to the Hebrew conjunction *gam* ‘also’ which suggests the second command adds somehow to the first. He takes the view (together with other commentators) that Boaz “is granting her more than the ordinary rights of gleanage” by allowing her to glean so close to his women workers. This explains the stronger negative verb form used to say that

Ruth must be careful not to go beyond the boundary markers. Bush further comments, “Boaz’s admonition is necessary since fields in the ancient Near East were separated by no clearly visible boundaries.” One more point in support of this view is the verb ‘avar which often includes the sense of passing or crossing boundaries.

Here are some other ways to translate these clauses:

Do not leave to gather grain in another field. You need not go beyond the limits of this field. (NET)

Don’t gather grain anywhere except in this field. (GNT)

Don’t go in any other field to gather grain, and don’t even leave this one. (GW)

2:8c

but stay here close to my servant girls.

- Keep close to my young female workers.
- Continue to closely follow the women who work in my field.

but stay here close to my servant girls: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as stay here close to could also be translated as “keep close.” Boaz wanted Ruth to stay near his other female workers. This had two advantages for her. First, being close to the women who work for him would be a safe place for her. Second, it was probably an advantage and special privilege for Ruth to glean so close to the harvest workers. Gathering grain among those who were bundling and tying the stalks meant that she would gather more than a usual gleaner.

my servant girls: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as my servant girls is literally “my young women.” These were probably hired workers, mostly young adults. Normally, the men would cut the grain and place it in piles on the ground. Women workers would then gather it into bundles, tie them, and take them to the threshing floor.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

stay close to my servant-girls (REB)

Stay right behind the young women working in my field. (NLT)

continue following closely behind my women workers (NCV)

Ruth 2:9

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

Paragraph 2:8–13

In this paragraph, Boaz told Ruth that she should stay and glean in his field along with his other women workers. He told her that he had instructed the young men not to bother her. He also said that she should feel free to drink from the water jars that the young men had filled. Ruth asked Boaz why he was being so kind to her. He replied that he had heard about everything she had done for her mother-in-law. He had also heard about her decision to leave her homeland and come to live with people she did not previously know.

2:9a

Let your eyes be on the field they are harvesting, and follow along after these girls.

- Observe carefully which field my workers are harvesting, and follow close behind the female workers.
- Follow right behind the women wherever you see my harvesters working.

Let your eyes be on the field they are harvesting:

The fields for the residents of Bethlehem were outside the village and one man's field would be adjacent to that of another person. So Boaz instructed Ruth to watch carefully where his harvest crew was working

and to stay with them. That is where she would be able to gather the most grain, and where she would be safest (2:9b).

they are harvesting: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as they are harvesting is literally “they (masculine) are harvesting.” Masculine gender in Hebrew can be used for a mixed group of men and women, so scholars have interpreted this in two ways:

1. It refers to all the harvest workers including both men and women. In versions that translate with they, the referent will be understood as “the women who work for me” (2:8c.) For example:

Keep your eyes on the field they are reaping (NJPS)

Watch to see into which fields they go to cut grain and follow them. (NCV) (BSB, ESV, NJB, KJV, NASB, NJPS, GNT, NCV, NLT; NRSV, NABRE) The NRSV and NABRE both use passive constructions which give attention to “the field that is being reaped” (NRSV) and leave implicit who the reapers are. This results in the reapers not being limited to one gender or the other.

1. It refers only to the male workers. For example:

Take note of the field where the men are harvesting (NET)

and follow along behind them, as they gather up what the men have cut (CEV) (NIV, NET, REB, GW, CEV)

The Notes will follow interpretation (1) and use a word that can refer to all the harvest workers. However, both interpretations have good commentary support. Commentaries that support interpretation (1) include: WBC, AYB, ZECOT, and NICOT. Commentaries that support (2) include: UBS, ZIBBC, KEL, and NET note. It is clear that the men did the actual harvesting/reaping, whereas the women gathered and tied the stalks into bundles. You may follow whatever interpretation people will understand best in your culture.

and follow along after these girls: Boaz here granted Ruth the privilege of gleaning close to the women workers, not just after them. For example:

Stay right behind the young women working in my field. (NLT)

continue following closely behind my women workers (NCV)

2:9b

Indeed, I have ordered the young men not to touch you.

- Have I not commanded the young men not to harm you?
- By my words, I am ordering my men workers not to disturb/bother you.

Indeed, I have ordered the young men not to touch you: In Hebrew, this statement is a rhetorical question. Boaz used it to emphasize the certainty of his instructions to the men. There are two ways to translate this question:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Have I not commanded the young men to do you no harm? (NABRE)

- As a statement. For example:

I will tell the men to leave you alone. (NET)

not to touch: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew verb in this context that the BSB translates as to touch :

1. It means “to bother, harm, or treat roughly.” For example:

I have ordered the young men not to bother you. (NRSV)

I have ordered the young men not to treat you roughly. (NLT) (CEV, NABRE, NET, NRSV)

1. It mean to come against a person violently or to abuse sexually. For example:

I have forbidden my men to molest you. (NJB) (GNT, NAB, NJB, NJPS, REB, RSV)

Phrases such as “lay a hand on” (NIV) and touch (BSB) are ambiguous.

The Notes will follow interpretation (1). Some feel that sexual assault is not in view in this context. CBC, for example, points out that this is harvest time and the fields were full of workers who could respond to a cry for help. KEL similarly finds it “highly unlikely that

Boaz’s workers were so prone to attack women that he had to prohibit such an action!” Boaz had given special permission to Ruth to glean close to his female workers. Without this command his male workers may have treated her roughly and told her that she could only glean after those workers were finished with their work.

However, you should also feel free to follow interpretation (2). It is followed by a majority of versions and a number of scholars. Ruth 2:9 is mentioned specifically as one of the OT references where “touch a woman” is a euphemism for sexual intercourse. Church of Christ study on 1 Corinthians 7, AYB7, IBC, Schwab. As IBC states: It is quite possible that any young woman working alone in the fields might be subject to unsolicited advances by men in the area...A foreigner from a disliked ethnic group would be even more likely to be victimized. It is unlikely that a man would molest Ruth in broad daylight, but someone might well attempt it in the evening as she walked home.

2:9c

And when you are thirsty, go and drink from the jars the young men have filled.”

- When you become thirsty, go and drink from the containers of water that the young men have filled.”
- When you are thirsty, you may drink from the water jars that my my servants have filled for themselves.”

And when you are thirsty, go and drink from the jars the young men have filled: Boaz was again granting Ruth a special favor. Normally, a gleaner would have to get her own water. She would not be allowed to drink from the water jars that the workers had filled for themselves.

the jars: These are not specified as water containers in the Hebrew text, but are just called “containers” or “vessels.” However, from the context it is clear that they were containers for water.

the young men have filled: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as have filled refers specifically to drawing (pulling up) water from a well. In your translation, use the words that people in your culture normally use to describe filling their water containers.

the young men: The masculine plural noun that the BSB translates as the young men can refer to a mixed group of servants. So if it would seem strange to your readers that men would fill water jars, you may use a general term such as “servants” or “workers.”

Ruth 2:10

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

Paragraph 2:8–13

In this paragraph, Boaz told Ruth that she should stay and glean in his field along with his other women workers. He told her that he had instructed the young men not to bother her. He also said that she should feel free to drink from the water jars that the young men had filled. Ruth asked Boaz why he was being so kind to her. He replied that he had heard about everything she had done for her mother-in-law. He had also heard about her decision to leave her homeland and come to live with people she did not previously know.

2:10a

At this, she fell on her face, bowing low to the ground,

- She knelt with her face close to the ground.
- Then Ruth knelt down and bowed her face to the ground to show how thankful she was.

At this: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as *At this* indicates that Ruth's actions and words are the results of what Boaz said in 2:8–9. Some languages may not need a conjunction to connect these verses because the relationship between them will seem obvious. In other languages, it may be natural to use a conjunction such as "So" or "Then."

she fell on her face, bowing low to the ground: Ruth probably knelt down, then bowed forward until her forehead touched the ground. She was doing this to show respect and gratefulness. If Ruth's purpose for bowing like this is not clear, you may need to supply some information.

Here are some ways to make the purpose clear:

she humbly bowed down to the ground

2:10b

and said to him, "Why have I found such favor in your eyes that you should take notice of me, even though I am a foreigner?"

- She said to him, "Why are you^(sing) kind enough to even notice me, though/when I am only a foreigner here?"
- She replied, "What is the reason that you are so good/kind to me? Why should you pay attention to me? I am not even an Israelite!"

and said to him: Ruth asked a question in response to what Boaz had said to her. Use a word that is natural for this in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

She asked him

She replied

Why have I found such favor in your eyes: The Hebrew phrase that means "to find favor in [someone's] eyes" is an idiom that means "to receive approval, favor, or goodwill from a person." This favor would normally be expressed in kind acts toward the person receiving approval. See how you translated the similar phrase in 2:2b.

Ruth was asking Boaz to tell her the reason why he would be so kind to her. This was a real, and not a rhetorical, question. That is shown by the fact that Boaz answered it.

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

Why are you so kind as to take notice of me (REB)

Why are you so kind and attentive to me (NET)

What have I done to deserve such kindness (NLT)

that you should take notice of me, even though I am a foreigner: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as take notice of means “give attention to” or “to regard with care/concern.” Ruth was amazed that Boaz was treating her so kindly, even though she was foreigner from Moab.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

when I am just a foreigner (REB)

since I am a foreigner (ESV)

I am not an Israelite. (NCV)

Ruth 2:11

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

Paragraph 2:8–13

In this paragraph, Boaz told Ruth that she should stay and glean in his field along with his other women workers. He told her that he had instructed the young men not to bother her. He also said that she should feel free to drink from the water jars that the young men had filled. Ruth asked Boaz why he was being so kind to her. He replied that he had heard about everything she had done for her mother-in-law. He had also heard about her decision to leave her homeland and come to live with people she did not previously know.

2:11a

Boaz replied, “I have been made fully aware of all you have done for your mother-in-law since the death of your husband,

- Boaz answered, “I have heard about everything that you^(sing) have done for your mother-in-law since your husband died.
- Boaz said to her, “People have told me all that you have done to help/support your mother-in-law after the death of her son, your husband.

Boaz replied: The Hebrew is more literally “and Boaz answered and said.” Introduce Boaz’s reply to Ruth in a way that is natural in your language.

I have been made fully aware of all you have done for your mother-in-law: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as made fully aware is more literally “have been told, have been told.” This repetition emphasizes the fact that Boaz had been told about Ruth’s actions toward her mother-in-law. Perhaps several people had talked to him about her. In addition, the word fully is used. This indicates that Ruth’s actions had been explained to him in detail. Boaz had heard a lot about Ruth and what she had done for Naomi.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

People have told me about everything you have done for your mother-in-law (GW)

I know about all the help you have given your mother-in-law (NCV)

I have been hearing all about your kind actions to your mother-in-law

I have been made fully aware: The verb phrase I have been made fully aware is passive in form. Boaz does not say who had told him about Ruth. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

I have been given a full report (NET)

- Use an active verb. For example:

People have told me

I have heard

I have had a complete account (NABRE)

all you have done for your mother-in-law: This refers to the various things that Ruth had done to help and support Naomi. In some languages, it may be natural to make it explicit that Ruth had behaved well toward her mother-in-law. For example:

how you've helped your mother-in-law (CEV)

all the help you have given your mother-in-law (NCV)

since the death of your husband: The phrase since the death of your husband refers in general to the period of time that had passed since the death of Ruth's husband Mahlon. Here are some other ways to translate this:

following the death of your husband (NET)

ever since your husband died (CEV)

2:11a-c (combined)

- Boaz answered her, "People have told me about everything you have done for your mother-in-law since your husband died. They told me how you left your father and mother in the country where you were born. They also told me how you came to people that you didn't know before. (GW)

2:11b

how you left your father and mother and the land of your birth,

- I have been told that you^(sing) left your father and your mother and the country where you were born
- They told me that you said farewell/goodbye to your father and mother and your own/native land

how you left your father and mother and the land of your birth: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as how does not refer to the way Ruth left, but rather to the fact that she left. This verse part begins an explanation of what exactly Ruth had done for her mother-in-law. She had left her own parents and her own land.

In some languages, it may be more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

You even left your own father and mother to come and live in a foreign land (NCV)

I have heard how you left your own father and mother and your own land (NLT)

the land of your birth: This refers to the land of Moab, where Ruth had been born and where her family still lived.

2:11c

and how you came to a people you did not know before.

- to come and live with a group of people you did not know before.
- and came here to live among people you never met before.

and how you came to a people you did not know before: This verse part continues to make explicit what Ruth had done for Naomi. She had come to live in Israel among strangers. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as a people is a general word. It is contrasted with Ruth's "land of...birth" of Moab in 2:11b, so here it refers to the people of Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

and came to live among people you did not know previously (NET)

to come to a nation where you did not know anyone (NCV)

a people you did not know before: This clause indicates that Ruth had not known the Israelites well or personally before this time. Ruth had never lived in Israel before. She knew about the Israelites but perhaps only knew the family of Elimelech personally.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

among complete strangers (NLT)

us^(excl) foreigners

General Comment on 2:11a-c

This verse consists of a very long sentence. In the Book of Ruth, Boaz often speaks in long sentences. This seems to be part of the way that the author shows his character as a serious and dignified man. However, in some languages it may be better to translate this verse as two or three sentences. For example:

^{11a}Boaz answered her, "People have told me about everything you have done for your mother-in-law

since your husband died. ^{11b}They told me how you left your father and mother and the country where you were born. ^{11c}They also told me how you came to people that you didn't know before...." (GW)

Ruth 2:12

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

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In this paragraph, Boaz told Ruth that she should stay and glean in his field along with his other women workers. He told her that he had instructed the young men not to bother her. He also said that she should feel free to drink from the water jars that the young men had filled. Ruth asked Boaz why he was being so kind to her. He replied that he had heard about everything she had done for her mother-in-law. He had also heard about her decision to leave her homeland and come to live with people she did not previously know.

2:12a

May the LORD repay your work,

- May Yahweh reward you^(sing) for what you have done for her/Naomi.
- I pray that Yahweh will repay/bless you for the kind things you have done for your mother-in-law.

May the LORD repay your work: This is a blessing. Boaz was saying that he hoped and prayed that God would do good to Ruth. Here are some other ways to translate this:

May the Lord reward you for your deeds! (NRSV)

I ask the LORD to reward you for what you have done.

repay: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as repay refers here to doing good to someone as a reward for a good action that that person has done.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

reward you

do good to you

your work: Boaz was referring to the work, or actions, he had spoken of in 2:11b-c. These were good things, kind actions. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

for being good to your mother-in-law

for your kind deeds/actions

2:12b

and may you receive a rich reward from the LORD, the God of Israel,

- May Yahweh, the God of Israel, give you^(sing) a rich/great reward.
- I pray that Yahweh, the God whom we^(excl) Israelites worship, will be very kind to you.

may you receive a rich reward from the LORD, the God of Israel: The Hebrew is more literally "May your wages be complete from Yahweh, the God of Israel." This repeats the meaning of 2:12a but with greater emphasis.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

and a full reward be given you by the Lord, the God of Israel (RSV)

May you receive a rich reward from the Lord God of Israel (GW)

the LORD, the God of Israel: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the LORD is Yahweh, and the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as God is ʾelo-him, the normal term for God. This sort of double expression is common in the Old Testament. How you

translate it will depend on the term that you have chosen for Yahweh. For example:

the Lord God of Israel (CEV)

Yahweh, the God whom the people of Israel serve/
worship

2:12c under whose wings you have taken refuge.”

- He is the one to whom you have come to find safety like a baby bird under its mother’s wings.”
- For he is the God whom you are trusting to protect you.”

under whose wings you have taken refuge: This is a metaphor. The picture is of a young bird seeking protection under the wings of its mother. Boaz meant that Ruth was relying on the LORD to protect her and care for her, just as a mother bird protects and cares for her young ones.

There are several ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

under whose wings you have come for
refuge!” (NRSV)

- Use a simile. For example:

to whom you have come for protection like a baby
bird hiding under its mother’s wings.”

- Explain the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

to whom you have come to find protection/
safety.”

from whom you have sought protection!” (NET)

- Use another simile or metaphor from your language that means the same thing. Avoid referring to anything that Boaz could not have known or talked about.

taken refuge: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as taken refuge means “to go for protection” or “to seek a safe place.” This implies that Ruth was trusting the God of Israel to protect her.

The Notes have used closed quote marks above to indicate that Boaz’ words to Ruth end with this verse part. Verse 2:13a continues this paragraph with Ruth’s response. In some languages, it may be easier for readers to identify a new speaker if there is a new paragraph.

Ruth 2:13

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

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Paragraph 2:8–13

In this paragraph, Boaz told Ruth that she should stay and glean in his field along with his other women workers. He told her that he had instructed the young men not to bother her. He also said that she should feel free to drink from the water jars that the young men had filled. Ruth asked Boaz why he was being so kind to her. He replied that he had heard about everything she had done for her mother-in-law. He had also heard about her decision to leave her homeland and come to live with people she did not previously know.

2:13a

“My lord,” she said, “may I continue to find favor in your eyes,

- “I hope that you^(sing) will continue to be pleased with me, my master,” she said.
- Ruth replied, “I always want to please you, sir.

My lord: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as lord also means “master” or “sir.” It is a polite form of

address that is often used of men as well as of God. Ruth used this form of address in order to express her respect for Boaz.

she said: The BSB has placed this phrase in the middle of what Ruth was saying. You should place this speech introduction wherever it would be natural in your language.

may I continue to find favor in your eyes: The expression find favor in your eyes is an idiom that means to receive approval or goodwill from a person. This favor would normally be expressed in kind acts. See how you translated this idiom in 2:2b and 2:10b.

It is possible to understand this verse part in two ways:

1. Ruth was expressing a hope or a wish that Boaz would continue to be pleased with her and be kind to her. For example:

I hope you will always look on me with favour
(NJB)

I hope I can continue to please you, sir. (NCV) (BSB, GW, KJV, NABRE, NCV, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. Ruth was thanking Boaz for acting kindly toward her. For example:

You are very kind to me, sir. (GNT) (CEV, ESV, NASB, NET, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Ruth was respectfully expressing her desire that Boaz would continue to be pleased with her (and so be kind to her).

2:13b

for you have comforted and spoken kindly to your maidservant,

- “You^(sing) have comforted and reassured your servant,
- For you have been kind enough to encourage me, your servant,

for you have comforted and spoken kindly to your maidservant: This verse part indicates Ruth’s appreciation for what Boaz was doing. She was thanking Boaz for speaking in an encouraging and reassuring way to her.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

You have comforted me by speaking so kindly to me (NLT)

You have said kind and encouraging words to me, your servant (NCV)

You have comforted me and reassured me (GW)

and spoken kindly: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as spoken kindly is literally “spoken upon the heart.”

your maidservant: Here Ruth referred to herself in the third person. In many languages, you may need to make it explicit that Ruth was speaking about herself. For example:

me, your servant (NET)

Ruth was not actually a servant in the same sense as the other servant girls. She was speaking in a humble and respectful way. It was common at that time to refer to oneself as someone’s “servant” in order to show respect for the other person.

2:13c

though I am not like one of your servant girls.”

- even though I am not actually/even one of your servants.”
- although I am not even as important as one/any of your servant women/girls.”

though I am not like one of your servant girls: Ruth said that she was not actually one of Boaz’s servants. She implied that she was less important than they were, and that he need not have noticed her. By speaking in this way, she was showing great humility.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

even though I am not one of your servants (NRSV)

and I’m not even one of your own servants (GW)

Ruth 2:14

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic

and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

2:14a

At mealtime Boaz said to her, “Come over here;

- ¶ When it was time to eat, Boaz said to Ruth, “Come here and eat something with us^(excl).
- ¶ At noon, Boaz invited Ruth to come and sit with them.

At mealtime Boaz said to her: The phrase At mealtime indicates the time when Boaz next spoke to Ruth. The KJV includes the words “at mealtime” in the quotation from Boaz. However, the majority of translations understand the words “at mealtime” to refer to the time when Boaz addressed Ruth. It would probably have been about noon.

Come over here: Boaz invited Ruth to join his workers. The word here refers to the general area where Boaz and his hired workers, both males and females, were eating. You may wish to translate this as an invitation or as a polite command. Consider how a landowner or employer would speak kindly to his workers. For example:

You may come and join us

Come, eat with us. (CEV)

2:14b

have some bread and dip it into the vinegar sauce.”

- You^(sing) can dip your bread/food in the vinegar sauce.”
- He invited/encouraged her to take some bread and dip it in the sauce with them.

have some bread: Again, this can be translated as an invitation or as a polite command. The Hebrew word meaning bread is used here to refer to the ordinary food served at the noon meal. Bread was the main food in Ruth’s time. If the speakers of your language

do not eat bread every day and think of it as a special or luxury food, then use your own common word for “food.” For example:

and have some food (NET)

and help yourself to some food (NLT)

and dip it into the vinegar sauce: Apparently the vinegar sauce was some kind of tasty sauce, probably fermented. Boaz was offering Ruth something that tasted good. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Dip your bread in the vinegar. (NET)

You can dip your bread in the sour wine. (NLT)

If people in your culture do not dip bread in a sauce, or if you have referred to food in general in the previous clause, you may need to translate this in a different way. For example:

Help yourself to the sauce.

2:14c

So she sat down beside the harvesters, and he offered her roasted grain,

- So she sat down beside the harvesters. Then he handed her some roasted grain. (NET)
- So Ruth sat down next to the harvest workers. Boaz handed her some grain that someone/they had cooked over the fire.

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So indicates that what happened next is the result of Boaz’s invitation in 2:14a.

she sat down beside the harvesters, and he offered her roasted grain: The two verbs she sat down and he offered refer to two consecutive actions. Here are some other ways to translate them:

So she sat down beside the harvesters. Then he handed her some roasted grain. (NET)

So she sat beside the reapers, and he handed her some roasted grain. (GW)

she sat down beside the harvesters: The harvesters, both men and women, were sitting eating together, and Ruth joined them.

and he offered her roasted grain: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as offered is not found anywhere else in the Old Testament. In this context, it seems to indicate that Boaz handed or gave Ruth some grain.

roasted grain: This refers to fresh grain that the workers had roasted over the fire. Probably it was some of the barley that they had just harvested.

2:14d

and she ate and was satisfied and had some left over.

- Ruth ate until she was full, and she even had some food remaining.
- Ruth ate until she was satisfied, and she still had food left.

and she ate and was satisfied: Ruth ate until she was satisfied and was no longer hungry. Here are some other ways to translate this:

She ate until she was full (GW)

She ate all she wanted (NIV)

and had some left over: Boaz gave Ruth more roasted grain than she was able to eat. Though this verse does not mention it, Ruth saved this extra food, and she later took the leftover grain home to Naomi.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

and she still had some food left over (GNT)

she even had some food left over (NCV)

Ruth 2:15

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic

and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

2:15a

When Ruth got up to glean, Boaz ordered his young men,

- After she left to continue gleaning. Boaz commanded his workers,
- Then Ruth got up to gather some more grain. Boaz said to his servants,

When Ruth got up to glean, Boaz ordered his young

men: The Hebrew is not clear about the order in which these two events happened. It literally says, “And she got up to glean and Boaz commanded his men.” Most English translations other than the BSB are ambiguous about the time sequence. It is better to assume that Ruth got up while the others were still eating and then Boaz spoke to his men about her. Boaz probably would not talk to his men about her while she was still close by.

Here is a way to express the probable time sequence:

After she had left to go and gather grain, Boaz ordered the workers (GNT)

his young men: This phrase refers to Boaz’s field workers.

2:15b

“Even if she gathers among the sheaves,

- “If she picks up grain near the bundles of harvested/cut grain,
- “Let that young woman gather grain near the harvested/grain sheaves.

Even if she gathers among the sheaves: This clause implies that Boaz wanted Ruth to be able to gather grain among the sheaves. In many languages, it may be best to translate this as a command directed to the harvest workers. For example:

Allow/Permit her to glean among the sheaves

Let her gather even among the piles of cut grain.
(NCV)

the sheaves: The sheaves were bundles of cut grain. Normally gleaners would only pick up grain in the part of the field that the workers had finished clearing. They would not pick up grain right near the sheaves.

2:15c

do not insult her.

- do not humiliate/shame her.
- Do not speak harshly to her.

do not insult her: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as insult means “humiliate.” In this context, it probably refers to a verbal rebuke that would humiliate someone.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

do not reproach her (NRSV)

don't embarrass her (NIV84)

do not make her feel bad

don't say anything to stop her (GNT)

Ruth 2:16

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

2:16a

Rather, pull out for her some stalks from the bundles

- Instead, drop some of the cut grain on the ground for her,
- But pull out some stalks from the handfuls of grain you have cut. Let them fall to the ground for her.

Rather: In this context the Hebrew words that the BSB translates as Rather introduce a further and unusual command. Boaz told the workers to drop some cut stalks so that there would be plenty of grain for Ruth to gather. This was a very unusual and generous command.

pull out for her some stalks from the bundles: The way in which reapers cut grain was to gather as many stalks as possible in one hand, while the stalks were still upright and in the ground. Then they cut off the stalks with a swing of their sickle, which they held in the other hand. Boaz apparently instructed his men to pull some stalks out of the handfuls they cut and let them fall on the ground. This would help Ruth gather more grain.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

pull out some heads of grain from the bundles
(GNT)

drop some full heads of grain for her from what
you have in your hands (NCV)

bundles: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as bundles can also be translated as “handfuls.” It probably refers to the bunches of grain stalks that the reapers held in their hands.

2:16b

and leave them for her to gather.

- and let her gather it too.
- Leave them on the ground so that she can pick them up.

and leave them for her to gather: Boaz told the workers to let the dropped stalks lie on the ground so that Ruth would be able to collect them.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

and let her gather them (NCV)

and leave it for her to gather (GW)

2:16c

Do not rebuke her.”

- Do not scold her.”
- Do not tell her that she is doing something wrong.”

Do not rebuke her: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as rebuke refers to telling someone that what they are doing is wrong or not allowed. In some languages, it may be natural to translate this command as a separate sentence. For example:

Don't tell her not to! (NET)

Don't give her a hard time about it. (GW)

Ruth 2:17

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

2:17a

So Ruth gathered grain in the field until evening.

- ¶ So Ruth gleaned in the field until it began to get dark.
- ¶ And so Ruth gathered grain in that field the entire day.

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So here introduces what Ruth did as a result of what Boaz had said in 2:16.

Ruth gathered grain in the field until evening: Ruth worked gathering grain until dusk or evening, when it began to get dark.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

So Ruth gleaned in the field until evening. (NIV)

Ruth worked in the field until evening. (CEV)

2:17b

And when she beat out what she had gleaned,

- Then she took a stick and beat the barley stalks she had picked up.
- When evening came, she separated the barley grain from the stalks she had gathered.

And when she beat out what she had gleaned: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as beat out refers to the process of separating grain from its stalks and husks or chaff. This process is also called threshing. Ruth beat the heads of grain, probably with a stick, to separate out the good grain, the seed kernels. This would make her load lighter, and she would only have to carry the good grain home.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Then she separated the grain from its husks. (GW)

Then after she had pounded the grain off the stalks (CEV)

Then she threshed the barley she had gathered (NIV)

2:17c

it was about an ephah of barley.

- There was enough grain to fill a fifteen-liter container.
- The grain weighed about twelve kilograms.

it was about an ephah of barley: After the threshing, Ruth ended up with approximately an ephah of barley. An ephah was a basket of a standard size that the Israelites used for measuring and carrying dry materials. Scholars are not certain as to how much an ephah held in modern measurements.

The following estimates are the most likely possibilities:

- by quantity:

15 liters, or approximately 4 gallons, or half a bushel

- by weight:

12 kilograms, or 25 pounds

However, the exact amount is not the important point. The main point is that this was a very large amount for someone to glean in one day. You should make this clear in your translation. Apparently Boaz's workers had obeyed his instructions and left extra stalks of grain for Ruth to pick up. She herself must have worked hard to obtain this large amount.

There are several ways of translating the ancient measurement of ephah:

- You can transliterate the Hebrew word ephah. If you do this, you should include a footnote to explain how much this. Use a unit of measurement that would be meaningful to your readers. You could include this information in the text itself. For example:

an ephah, that is, half a bushel

- You can use a word from your language that represents a measure that is more or less the same volume as the Hebrew ephah
- You can use an approximate measure. For example:

Then after she had pounded the grain off the stalks, she had a large basket full of grain. (CEV)

Translate this unit of measurement in the way that best indicates to your readers that this was a lot of grain.

Ruth 2:18

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth

already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

2:18a

She picked up the grain and went into the town, where her mother-in-law saw what she had gleaned.

- Ruth took the grain back into town with her. Her mother-in-law saw what she had gleaned.
- Ruth went/walked back to town and brought the grain to her mother-in-law. Naomi saw what a lot of barley she had gathered.

She picked up the grain and went into the town: The text does not say how Ruth carried the grain. She may have had a basket, a bag, or a large piece of cloth into which she put the grain. She may have carried it on her shoulder or on her head.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

She picked it up and went into the town (GW)

She took the grain to town (CEV)

where her mother-in-law saw: There is a textual problem with the Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as saw. There are two possibilities:

1. The original text read saw. That is, Naomi saw what Ruth had brought. For example:

and her mother-in-law saw what she had gleaned (NASB) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NRSV)

1. The original text read “caused to see.” That is, Ruth showed Naomi what she had brought. For example:

and showed her mother-in-law how much she had gathered (GNT) (CEV, GNT, NABRE, NLT, REB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with the majority of Hebrew manuscripts and English versions. NICOT (note 3) recommends interpretation (1), because “the LXX reflects the Qal form.” Also, the Hiphil (causative) form would normally have “the direct object sign before “her mother-in-law.” UBS (page 39) prefers option (2) on the grounds that it “produces a far smoother sequence of events.”

what she had gleaned: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as what she had gleaned does not emphasize that Ruth had gathered a large amount, but this is implied.

2:18b

And she brought out what she had saved from her meal and gave it to Naomi.

- Ruth also took out from her container/bag what she had left of her midday meal after she had eaten all that she wanted. She gave that to Naomi too.
- Ruth gave Naomi the barley/grain and also food she had left over from her noon meal.

And she brought out what she had saved from her meal and gave it to Naomi: The phrase what she had saved from her meal refers to the food that Ruth had left from her noon meal. See 2:14d. Boaz must have given her a very generous amount to eat, so she had some of that roasted grain to give to Naomi also.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Ruth also gave her the roasted grain that was left over from her meal. (NLT)

Ruth also took out the food that was left over from lunch and gave it to Naomi. (NCV)

Ruth 2:19

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

2:19a

Then her mother-in-law asked her, “Where did you glean today, and where did you work?”

- ¶ Her mother-in-law questioned her, “Where did you^(sing) glean today? In what field did you work?”
- ¶ Naomi asked, “Wherever did you gather that much grain?”

Then her mother-in-law asked her: This speech indicates that Naomi spoke to Ruth. Refer to the women in a way that is natural in your language for this point in the story.

Where did you glean today, and where did you work?: These questions imply that Naomi was happy and excited to see the large amount of grain. She quickly asked these two questions, and before Ruth had time to answer her, she blessed the landowner.

Here is another example of asking two questions:

Where did you gather all this grain today? Whose field have you been working in? (GNT)

The two questions are basically asking the same thing. In some languages, it may not be natural to repeat questions to show surprise. In those languages, it may be better to translate them as one question that implies that Naomi was astonished and excited. For example:

Wherever did you gather grain today?

2:19b

Blessed be the man who noticed you.”

- May the man who noticed/helped you receive blessing from Yahweh!”
- May Yahweh show his favor to the man/one who gave special attention to you!”

Blessed be the man who noticed you: This Hebrew blessing is like a short prayer that asks God to do good to someone.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

God bless the man who treated you so well! (CEV)

May the man who paid attention to you be blessed. (GW)

noticed you: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as noticed you means “paid attention to you.” Naomi meant that the owner of the field had not only seen Ruth but had deliberately acted kindly to her. The same word was used in 2:10b.

2:19c

So she told her mother-in-law where she had worked.

- Then Ruth told her mother-in-law about the owner of the field where she had worked.
- And Ruth explained to Naomi in whose field she had been gleaning.

So she told her mother-in-law where she had worked: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as where she had worked is more literally “who I worked with him.” Since Ruth was answering Naomi’s questions about where she had worked, “with him” actually means “at his field/place.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

So Ruth told her mother-in-law with whom she had worked. (NET)

Ruth told her mother-in-law whose field she had worked in. (NCV)

2:19c-d

(combined/reordered)

- Then Ruth told her that she had worked in the field of a man named Boaz. (CEV)

2:19d

“The name of the man I worked with today is Boaz,” she said.

- “The man I worked with/for today is called Boaz,” she told Naomi.
- She said, “I worked today in the field of a man named Boaz.”

The name of the man I worked with today is Boaz:

This is a direct quotation of what Ruth said to Naomi. The author did not mention the name of Boaz until the end of the statement in order to increase suspense. Try to keep the same effect in your translation and emphasize the name Boaz.

she said: Notice that the BSB has placed this phrase at the end of what Ruth was saying. You should place this speech introduction wherever it would be most natural in your language.

General Comment on 2:19c-d

In the Hebrew and the BSB, 2:19c is an indirect quotation of Ruth’s words, and 2:19d is a direct quotation. In some languages, it may be more natural to combine these two verse parts and use only indirect speech. For example:

So Ruth told Naomi that she had been working in a field belonging to a man named Boaz. (GNT)

Use direct speech or indirect speech, whichever is most natural in your language.

Ruth 2:20

Section 2:1-23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

2:20a

Then Naomi said to her daughter-in-law, “May he be blessed by the LORD,

- Naomi responded to her daughter-in-law, “May Yahweh be kind/good to him!
- Naomi said to her, “May Yahweh show him favor!

May he be blessed by the LORD: Naomi again asked the LORD to bless Boaz.

2:20b

who has not withdrawn His kindness from the living or the dead.”

- Yahweh has not stopped being kind to those who are living and those who have died.”
- Yahweh is continuing to do kind things for us who are alive and our husbands who are dead.”

who has not withdrawn His kindness from the living or the dead: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as withdrawn His kindness is more literally “forsaken, abandoned.”

There are two interpretation issues in this clause. The first is whether His kindness is the object or the subject of the Hebrew clause. The possibilities are:

1. His kindness is the object of the verb. According to this interpretation, “he” is the subject of the verb, and kindness is something that “he” has not abandoned or forsaken. For example:

he has not abandoned his loyalty to the living or to the dead (NET) (BSB, CEV, GNT, GW, KJV, NABRE, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB)

1. His kindness is the subject of the verb. According to this interpretation, God’s kindness has not abandoned or forsaken his people. For example:

whose kindness has not forsaken the living or the dead (NRSV) (ESV, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

The second issue is that in Hebrew it is not clear who has not withdrawn His kindness. Scholars have interpreted the clause in two ways:

1. The LORD is the subject of the verb. For example:

May he be blessed by the Lord, who never fails to show kindness to the living and to the dead. (NABRE) (BSB, CEV, GNT, GW, KJV, NABRE, NASB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, REB)

1. Boaz is the subject of the verb. For example:

May he be rewarded by the Lord because he has shown loyalty to the living on behalf of the dead. (NET) (ESV, NET, NIV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with the majority of English versions.

who has not withdrawn His kindness: The verb that the BSB translates as withdrawn is more literally “abandoned” or “forsaken.” Naomi was saying that the LORD was still being kind and faithful to her family. The LORD was showing his kindness through Boaz.

In some languages, it may be more natural to say:

He has not stopped being kind

He has not stopped acting kindly

He has continued to act with kindness/faithfulness

His kindness: The Hebrew word *hesed* that the BSB translates as kindness means faithfulness, love, and loyalty. See also the note at 1:8d.

from the living: The phrase the living here refers to Naomi and Ruth. The LORD had been kind to them by guiding Ruth to the field of a relative who was generous to her.

or the dead: The phrase the dead here probably refers to Elimelech and his sons. Perhaps Naomi was already thinking that Boaz might act as a guardian-redeemer, marry Ruth, and so continue Elimelech’s family line. This would be considered a great kindness to Elimelech and his sons, who had all died.

2:20c

Naomi continued, “The man is a close relative.

- Naomi added/said, “That man, Boaz, is a close relative of ours.”^{incl}
- Then Naomi continued, “The owner of the field is in my husband’s clan,

Naomi continued: The phrase Naomi continued indicates that Naomi continued speaking to Ruth. She started to talk about Boaz directly. Use the words that are normal in your language to indicate that the speaker continued to speak but changed the topic slightly.

The man is a close relative: Naomi referred to Boaz as The man. In some languages, it might not be polite to refer to a wealthy relative as The man. You should translate this with words that indicate respect.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Boaz is a close relative (CEV)

That gentleman/landowner is a close relative

a close relative: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as a close relative is literally “close/near to us.” It is clear from the context that Naomi was talking of kinship and family ties. Naomi refers to him as a close relative even though Boaz was a relative of her deceased husband. In some languages, it may be necessary to say “a close relative of our family/husbands.”

2:20d

He is one of our kinsman-redeemers.”

- He is one of those responsible to care for our^{incl} family.”
- so he is a relative with the duty to help us.”

He is one of our kinsman-redeemers: In Israel, close relatives had a responsibility to preserve the property and family name of those related to them. The closest relatives—a brother, uncle, or cousin—had the main responsibility. These closest relatives were called kinsman-redeemers. By using this special term, Naomi was saying that Boaz was one of the men who had a close enough family relationship to help both her and Ruth.

In some languages, a term such as “guardian/kinsman-redeemer” may be misunderstood, because most people will associate it with Christ’s role as the redeemer of sinners.

In some languages, it may be necessary to translate kinsman-redeemers with a phrase that clarifies the meaning in the context of this book. For example:

one of those who is supposed to look after us (CEV)

one who should take care of us (NCV)

one of those responsible for taking care of us (GNT)

one of those who have responsibility to care for our family

a relative with the duty to help us

It is suggested that you use one or more of the above examples where the phrase kinsman-redeemer occurs in the source line. In this verse part, Naomi is speaking to Ruth, so the inclusive pronoun “us” is used. In other contexts, such as where Ruth speaks to Boaz, the exclusive pronoun should be used.

Ruth 2:21

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

2:21a

Then Ruth the Moabite said, “He also told me,

- Then Ruth, the woman from Moab, said, “Better still, he said to me,
- Then Ruth the Moabite woman said, “More than that, Boaz told me

Then Ruth the Moabite said: In many languages, it may be more natural to simply say Ruth rather than repeating the phrase Ruth the Moabite. However, it is recommended that you repeat the information that Ruth was a woman from Moab. It is probable that the author wished to emphasize this at this point in the narrative.

He also told me: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as also:

1. It adds force or emphasis, so it intensifies what follows. For example:

and what is more he said to me (REB) (CEV, GNT, NET, NIV, NABRE, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. It means “also,” so it introduces something additional that Boaz had said. For example:

He also said to me (GW) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NASB, NCV, NJB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). WBC (page 138) says that this expression adds “force or distinctness to the affirmation which follows.” UBS supports interpretation (2) with the brief comment that a phrase such as “added” expresses the meaning.

2:21b

‘Stay with my young men until they have finished gathering all my harvest.’”

- ‘Keep close to my workers until they finish harvesting all the barley and wheat in my fields.’”
- that I should continue gleaning near his workers during the entire harvest season.”

Stay with my young men: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as Stay with means “keep close to.” In this context, Boaz was telling Ruth to remain near his own workers while they were in the field.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

You may go along beside my servants (NET)

Keep close to my workers (NCV)

my young men: This is a masculine plural noun. In this context, it probably refers to both the men and the women who were working in Boaz’s fields. Ruth was reporting what Boaz had said in 2:8c, where Boaz told Ruth to remain close to “my servant girls.”

until they have finished gathering all my harvest: Boaz was referring to both the barley and the wheat harvests, as mentioned in 2:23b.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

until they have finished my whole harvest (NCV)

until the entire harvest is completed (NLT)

General Comment on 2:21a-b

2:21b is an embedded quotation. It gives Ruth’s report of what Boaz had said. In some languages, it is not possible to have a direct quotation of a quotation. It may be necessary or more natural to report Boaz’s words using indirect speech. For example:

Then Ruth the Moabite said, “He also told me to stay close to his workers until they finish harvesting all the grain.”

Ruth told her, “Boaz even said I could stay in the field with his workers until they had finished harvesting all his grain.” (CEV)

Ruth 2:22

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

2:22a

And Naomi said to her daughter-in-law Ruth, “My daughter, it is good for you to work with his young women,

- Naomi said to her daughter-in-law, “My daughter, it would be best/wise for you to go and glean/work with his female servants.

- Naomi said to her, “Dear Ruth, you would do well to stay near the women who bundle the grain for him/Boaz.

And Naomi said to her daughter-in-law Ruth: In some languages, it may not be natural to repeat the relationship between the two women. Refer to them in a natural way in your language.

My daughter, it is good for you to work with his young women: This statement functions as advice. Naomi advised Ruth that she ought to do as Boaz had said. She was giving Ruth advice about her safety and well-being.

Here are some other ways to translate this advice:

It is better for you to continue working with his women workers (NCV)

Do as he said, my daughter. Stay with his young women right through the whole harvest. (NLT)

My daughter, it's good that you can pick up grain alongside the women who work in his field. (CEV)

That would be a good thing to do, my daughter. Go and glean with Boaz's servant women.

2:22b

so that nothing will happen to you in another field.”

- In a field belonging to someone else, someone might harm you.”
- If you went to another person's field, the workers there might mistreat you.”

so that nothing will happen to you in another field:

The conjunction so that here introduces the reason why it would be good for Ruth to stay in Boaz's field. Naomi was afraid that in a different place Ruth would not be safe.

In the BSB this is a passive clause with a passive verb, nothing will happen to you. In the Hebrew it is an active clause with an active verb, “they might molest you.” Naomi was implying that in another field the owner or the workers might treat Ruth badly.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Who knows what might happen to you in someone else's field! (CEV)

If you work in another field, someone might hurt you. (NCV)

Ruth 2:23

Section 2:1–23: Ruth gathered grain in a field belonging to Boaz

This third section in the book of Ruth tells how Ruth met Boaz. Since Naomi and Ruth were poor at this time, Ruth asked Naomi for permission to glean in the grain fields in order to find them some food.

Ruth chose a field in which to glean. Although she did not know it, the man who owned that field, Boaz, was a relative of Elimelech. Boaz had heard about Ruth already, but he had not met her. He was sympathetic and kind to her that day, and told her to continue to work in his field during the rest of the harvest time.

That evening, Ruth returned home and told Naomi that the owner of the field where she had gleaned was called Boaz and that he had treated her well. Naomi was very pleased. She encouraged Ruth to continue to work there just as Boaz had invited her to do.

Here are some other examples of section headings:

Ruth Meets Boaz (ESV)

Ruth Works in the Field of Boaz (NET)

2:23a

So Ruth stayed close to the servant girls of Boaz to glean grain

- ¶ So Ruth stayed close to Boaz's female servants while she gleaned.
- ¶ So Ruth continued to bundle the grain near Boaz's women workers

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So here introduces what Ruth did as a result of what Naomi had told her in 2:22a–b.

Ruth stayed close to the servant girls of Boaz to glean grain:

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as stayed close is the same word that is translated as “stay with” in 2:21b. Ruth did as Boaz and Naomi had told her and continued to glean in Boaz's field near his female workers. However, as 2:23c says, she still lived with Naomi.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

So Ruth continued working closely with the workers of Boaz (NCV)

So Ruth worked beside Boaz's female servants,
gathering grain (NET)

2:23b

until the barley and wheat harvests were finished.

- She continued doing this until the end of both the barley harvest and the wheat harvest.
- until the workers finished harvesting all of Boaz's barley and wheat.

until the barley and wheat harvests were finished:

The barley harvest was in late April and early May. The wheat harvest was after that, in late May and early June.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

until the barley and wheat were harvested (CEV)

until both the barley harvest and the wheat harvest ended (GW)

until the end of the barley harvest. Then she continued working with them through the wheat harvest in early summer. (NLT)

barley and wheat: Both barley and wheat are grain crops. The seeds or grains grow on a "head" which is at the top of a thin stalk. People ground the grains into flour and used it for making bread. See the note on barley in 1:22b.

2:23c

And she lived with her mother-in-law.

- During this time, she continued to live with her mother-in-law.
- She still lived in the home of Naomi.

And she lived with her mother-in-law: Ruth continued to live in Naomi's house and sleep there, although she gleaned each day in Boaz's fields. Each evening she would bring home the grain she had gathered that day.

Here is another way to translate this verse part:

And all this time she lived with Naomi. (CEV)

In some languages, it may be helpful to start this sentence with a phrase like "During this time...."

Ruth 3:1

Section 3:1-18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed Naomi's plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi's Plan for Ruth's Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

3:1a

One day Ruth's mother-in-law Naomi said to her,

- ¶ Then Naomi her mother-in-law said to her, (ESV)
- ¶ Some time later Naomi said to Ruth, (GNT)

One day: In Hebrew, this chapter begins with a conjunction that introduces a new major event in the story. Some versions do not use a conjunction or time phrase here.

Here are some other ways to introduce this event:

Then (ESV)

Some time later (GNT)

After a while

Consider the natural way in your language to introduce a new major event in the story. If you use a word

or phrase that refers to a period of time, be sure that it can refer to an indefinite amount of time, perhaps a few weeks. By this time, the barley harvest was finished.

Ruth's mother-in-law Naomi: In Hebrew, this phrase is literally "Naomi her mother-in-law."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

her mother-in-law Naomi (NASB)

Naomi, Ruth's mother-in-law (REB)

Naomi (GNT)

Ruth is such an important character in this story that the author did not think it was necessary to mention her here by name. Instead, the Hebrew text only refers to her by the pronoun "her." But Naomi is mentioned both by her name and by her relationship to Ruth, because Naomi is about to do something important in the story. These different ways of referring to the main characters in the story follow the pattern of Hebrew stories.

In some languages, it will not be necessary or natural to refer to Naomi here by both her name and her relationship to Ruth as mother-in-law. If this is true in your language, consider following the CEV and some others by simply referring to her as Naomi.

said to her: This clause introduces a direct quotation of Naomi to Ruth.

In some languages, it may be natural to mention Ruth by name. For example:

said to Ruth (GNT)

In other languages, it may already be obvious whom Naomi is talking to, so it would not be necessary to use any form of reference. For example:

Naomi then said (NJB)

3:1b

"My daughter, should I not seek a resting place for you, that it may be well with you?"

- "My daughter-in-law, should I not look for a suitable/permanent home for you, so you can have all you need?"
- "Dear Ruth, I think that I should arrange for you to have a better life in the future."

My daughter: Ruth was not Naomi's daughter, but the word that the BSB translates as My daughter is a natural way for mothers-in-law to address daughters-in-law in Hebrew culture. It expresses Naomi's affection for Ruth. You should translate these words the same way as in 2:2c.

Here are some other ways to translate these words:

Daughter (NJB)

My daughter-in-law

My dear daughter

My child

In some languages, it may be more natural for Naomi to not use any form of address to Ruth. The CEV and GNT do not include an explicit translation of these words.

Translate this form of address in a way that is natural and appropriate in your language.

should I not seek a resting place for you, that it may be well with you?: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasized the responsibility she felt to find a better living situation for Ruth.

Here are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

should I not try to find a home for you, where you will be well provided for? (NIV84)

Is it not my duty to see you happily settled? (NJB)

- Use a statement. For example:

I must find a suitable home for you (NCV)

it's time that I found a permanent home for you (NLT)

I must find a husband for you, so that you will have a home of your own. (GNT)

I think I should try to arrange for you to have a husband who will...provide for you. (T4T)

seek: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as seek means “search out.”

a resting place for you: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as resting place is literally “rest” or “place of rest.” But here it is a figure of speech that means “a secure future.” See how you translated the related word “rest” in 1:9.

Naomi wanted Ruth to have a quiet, settled, permanent situation in which to live the rest of her life. Such a situation could only come about through marriage. Naomi’s use of the phrase resting place here is an indirect reference to marriage.

Naomi seemed to deliberately avoid being explicit, so you should keep the reference to marriage indirect if possible. Translate this phrase in a natural and meaningful way in your language.

that it may be well with you: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as that it may be well with you is literally “which will be good for you.” In this context, it refers to being in a good, secure situation, with a husband who will provide the food, clothes, and home she needed.

Most versions translate this part of 3:1b as a purpose clause. For example:

so that it may be well with you (NRSV)

so that you will be taken care of (CSB)

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

that will be good for you (NCV)

so you will be secure (NET)

It may be more natural in some languages to combine the two phrases “a resting place for you” and that it may be well with you into one phrase. For example:

a good home for you

a better life for you in the future

Ruth 3:2

Section 3:1–18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because

women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed Naomi’s plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi’s Plan for Ruth’s Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

3:2a

Now is not Boaz, with whose servant girls you have been working, a relative of ours?

- So then, you have been working with the female servants of Boaz. Is he not one of our^(incl) relatives?
- You have been gathering/bundling grain behind the young women who work for Boaz. Boaz, as you know, is a relative of our dead husbands.

Now: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as Now introduces a conclusion or main point of discussion. It does not refer to time. So you should not translate it literally as “Now,” unless that is how your language naturally introduces a conclusion or main point of discussion. Some versions do not use a conjunction here.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

So then,

Now then,

is not Boaz, with whose servant girls you have been working, a relative of ours?: In Hebrew, this clause is more literally “Is not Boaz a relative of ours whom

you were with his young women?” This is another rhetorical question. Its function was to draw Ruth’s attention to an important fact. She emphasized the words relative of ours, even though Ruth already knew that Boaz was a relative.

There are two ways to translate this clause:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Isn’t Boaz, whose young women you’ve been working with, our relative? (GW)

- Use a statement. For example:

Remember that this man Boaz, whose women you have been working with, is our relative. (GNT)

with whose servant girls you have been working:

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as servant girls means “young women.” These were probably hired workers, mostly young adults. See how you translated 2:8c.

a relative: Boaz was related to the women only through Elimelech’s marriage to Naomi. See how you translated 2:1a. See also the note on Levirate marriage in the Introduction.

3:2b

In fact, tonight he is winnowing barley on the threshing floor.

- Listen, this very evening he will be winnowing his barley at the threshing place/area.
- Pay attention. Late this afternoon, he will be working at the place where they remove the chaff/husks from the barley grain.

In fact: In Hebrew, this sentence begins with a word that BSB translates as In fact and other traditional English versions translate as “Behold.” It functions here to draw Ruth’s attention to a very important opportunity.

Here are some ways to express this function:

Look (NET)

Listen carefully

Now listen. (GNT)

tonight: This word could be translated as “this night” or “this very night.” Naomi was probably referring to the late afternoon and early evening. You should not

translate this in a way that implies that Boaz would have worked for a long time after dark.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

This evening (GNT)

Late this afternoon

he is winnowing barley on the threshing floor: This clause describes one of the steps in the preparation of harvested barley. The term threshing floor refers to an open area with a hard level surface where harvested barley plants were crushed or “threshed.” The next step was winnowing. It refers to the work of separating the edible barley grain from its waste material or “chaff.” See the notes below for a more detailed explanation of these steps.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He will be separating the barley from its husks on the threshing floor (GW)

he will be working at the threshing floor (NCV)

he will be separating barley seeds from the chaff at the place where they crush the grain

To translate this clause well, it is important to understand how harvested barley was prepared. When harvesters took bundles of barley from the field, they brought it to the threshing floor and did two things:

1. Threshing: The first thing they did with harvested barley was to “thresh” it. The workers “threshed” grain by beating or crushing it. This crushing process caused the heads or clusters of grain to break off from the stems of the plant, and the husks which contain the edible seeds would crack open.
2. Winnowing: The people who winnowed the barley used a tool (shovel, fork, fan, or shallow basket) to pick up a bunch of crushed grain. They would then shake the grain and throw it up in the air. A gentle wind would blow the chaff and dust a distance away, and the heavier grain seeds would fall close by, where they were collected in heaps.

There are several options to translate the term winnowing:

- If there is no word in your language for winnowing, use a short phrase that describes the process. For example:

he will be separating the seeds/kernels of barley from the chaff/husks

- Use a more general term such as “working.” See the NCV example above.

Naomi implied that after Boaz had finishing winnowing the grain, he would stay the whole night at the threshing floor, probably so that he could guard it. See 3:4a.

Ruth 3:3

Section 3:1–18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed Naomi’s plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi’s Plan for Ruth’s Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

3:3a

Therefore wash yourself, put on perfume, and wear your best clothes.

- So, bathe, rub on sweet-smelling oil, and put on your nicest clothes.
- This is what you must do. Take a bath, rub on sweet-smelling oil, and dress in your best clothing.

Therefore: In Hebrew, this sentence starts with a conjunction that the BSB translates as Therefore. It begins a series of instructions from Naomi to Ruth. So

far, Naomi’s speech to Ruth which began in 3:1b has been describing a situation. Here in 3:3a she switched to giving instructions.

Here are some ways to introduce the series of instructions:

So... (NET)

Now do as I tell you (NLT)

Therefore I want you to...

You should... (CEB)

Consider the way that your language naturally switches from describing the important facts about a situation to giving instructions.

wash yourself, put on perfume: Naomi told Ruth to wash yourself, which means to bathe. The verb which the BSB translates as put on perfume means to “anoint” or “apply oils or perfumes to the body.” Perfumed oil was a luxury item. Poor people would have used it only on special occasions.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

So bathe yourself, rub on some perfumed oil (NET)

take a bath and put on perfume (NLT)

and wear your best clothes: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as and wear your best clothes is literally “and you will put your clothing on yourself.” There is no Hebrew word that means best here, but many translations supply a description of the clothes as “best,” “nice,” or “good,” because it fits the context.

clothes: There is a textual issue here:

1. In some Hebrew manuscripts the word for clothes is plural and refers to clothing in general. For example:

and put on your best clothes (NRSV) (BSB, CEV, GNT, GW, KJV, NET, NIV, NABRE, NASB, NRSV, NCV, NLT, REB)

1. In other Hebrew manuscripts and in the LXX, the word for clothes is singular, referring specifically to a “cloak,” “robe,” or “outer garment.” For example:

and put on your cloak (ESV) (ESV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most versions. Also, it has strong manuscript support.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and dress in your nicest clothes (NLT)

and get dressed up (NET)

dress up (NJPS)

3:3b

Go down to the threshing floor,

- Then go over to the threshing place,
- Then get up and go to the place where they remove the chaff/husks from the barley grain.

Go down to the threshing floor: Bethlehem was built on a hill that is higher than the surrounding land. A person would need to Go down to get to any place nearby. Threshing floors were also located on the tops or ridges of hills in order to catch good wind for blowing away the chaff. The threshing floor where Boaz worked was probably on the top of a lower hill close to Bethlehem.

In some languages, it may not be natural to say “go down” if a person goes slightly downhill. If that is true in your language, see the last three examples below.

Then go down the hill to the threshing place

After that, go over to the place where they crush/thresh the grain

Then go to the threshing floor (NLT)

Go where he is working (CEV)

3:3c

but do not let the man know you are there until he has finished eating and drinking.

- but do not let him know that you are there before/ until he has finished eating and drinking.
- But stay where Boaz cannot see you while he is having his meal.

but: The instructions in 3:3a-b have all been positive commands (“wash...put on...wear...Go down...”). Here in 3:3c, she gave a negative command, telling Ruth what not to do. The Hebrew text does not use any con-

junction here. In many languages, it will be natural to use a conjunction that indicates contrast. For example:

However,

But be careful...

But make sure...

do not let the man know you are there until he has finished eating and drinking: Naomi told Ruth to remain out of Boaz’s sight until he had finished eating and had gone to sleep.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Do not let him recognize you while he is still eating and drinking

but don’t let Boaz see you until he has finished eating and drinking (NLT)

but don’t let him recognize you. Once he’s finished eating and drinking,... (FBV)

In some languages, it may be more natural to use a positive command here rather than a negative one. For example:

But keep yourself out of his sight while...

But stay hidden until...

the man: There are three ways to translate this phrase:

- Translate it literally as the man, as in the BSB. Boaz is referred to as “the man” here and in 3:8, 16, and 18. (Compare the use of “woman” in reference to Ruth in 3:8, 11, and 14.) Hubbard (page 202) explains that this form of reference reminds the reader that this is a story about the relationship between a man and a woman. Consider whether referring to Boaz here as “the man” would have a similar effect in your language. If not, use the form of reference that is most natural in your language.
- Use the pronoun “him.”
- Refer to him by his name “Boaz.”

eating and drinking: The phrase eating and drinking is a Hebrew idiom that means “having a meal.”

Ruth 3:4

Section 3:1–18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed Naomi's plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi's Plan for Ruth's Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

3:4a

When he lies down, note the place where he lies.

- Then when he gets ready to sleep, notice carefully where he is.
- Watch him to see where he lies down to sleep.

When he lies down: This refers to when Boaz would lie down to sleep.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When he gets ready to go to sleep (NET)

When he is about to lie down for the night

note the place where he lies: The verb that the BSB translates as note is literally "know." The place where Boaz went to sleep would have been dark, and others were probably sleeping not far away. Ruth had to watch carefully and remember exactly where Boaz was so she could find him in the dark.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

make sure you know the place where he is (REB)

take careful notice of the place where he lies down (NET)

see and remember the place he lies down

General Comment on 3:4a

In some languages, it may not be natural to repeat the verbs "lies down" and "lies." If this is true in your language, combine these two clauses into a single clause. For example:

Be sure to notice where he lies down (NLT)

Watch where he goes to lie down

3:4b

Then go in and uncover his feet, and lie down,

- Next, go over to where he is sleeping and take the cover off his feet, and then lie down there.
- After he is asleep, go and remove the cover from his feet. Then lie down at his feet.

Then: The conjunction which the BSB translates as Then introduces the next instruction in a series of instructions.

Here are some other ways to introduce it:

After that

Later

Next

In some languages, it may not be natural to use a conjunction or time reference here.

Naomi implied that Ruth should wait until Boaz was asleep before going to uncover Boaz's feet. In some languages, it may be helpful to make this information explicit. For example:

After he falls asleep

Wait until he is asleep and then

go in and uncover his feet: Boaz would have used his outer cloak or some type of blanket to keep warm from the cool night winds at the threshing floor. Naomi told Ruth to lift the covering off his feet so that his feet would be bare.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

go and turn back the covering at his feet

take the blanket off his feet (T4T)

Go there and lift the cover off his feet (ERV)

and lie down: The Hebrew text and many translations do not say specifically where Ruth was supposed to lie down. But it is clear from this context (and 3:8b) that Naomi wanted Ruth to lie down at Boaz's feet rather than beside him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and lie down at his feet (GNT)

and lie down there next to his feet

and lie down there (GW)

3:4c

and he will explain to you what you should do."

- Then he will explain to you what you should do." (CSB)
- When he wakes up and sees you, he will let you know what he wants you to do."

he will explain to you what you should do: In this verse part, Naomi made a final comment to Ruth. She assured Ruth that after Boaz discovered her at his feet, he would tell her what she should do.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He will make it clear what you must do (GW)

When he wakes up, he will tell you what to do (T4T)

Ruth 3:5

Section 3:1–18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed Naomi's plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi's Plan for Ruth's Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

3:5

"I will do everything you say," Ruth answered.

- Ruth answered, "I will do everything you say."
- Then Ruth replied, "I will follow your advice/instructions."

This verse gives Ruth's reply to Naomi. In Hebrew, verse 5 begins with a common conjunction that introduces the next event. The BSB does not translate this conjunction here.

Here are some ways to begin this sentence:

And (ESV)

Then (NCV)

"I will do everything you say," Ruth answered: In many languages, it is more natural to put the quote introducer at the beginning of the sentence. For example:

Ruth answered, “I will do everything you say.” (GNT)

I will do everything you say: There is a minor textual issue here. Many Hebrew manuscripts include a word that means “to me” at the end of this clause. Here are the two options:

1. The words “to me” should not be included. (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NABRE, NASB, NCV, NIV, NLT, REB, RSV)
2. The words “to me” should be included. For example:

I shall do everything you tell me. (NJB) (KJV, NET, NJB, NJPS, NRSV)

The Notes will follow option (1), The LXX also follows this option. Although the MT suggests option (2) as the way the text should be read, it acknowledges option (1) as an earlier written form of the text. but there is little practical difference in meaning. In some languages, it may be more natural to follow a wording like the NJB.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I will do everything you say. (NCV)

All that you say I will do (ESV)

I will do what/as you say.

Ruth: The Hebrew text does not use Ruth’s name here but refers to her by the pronoun “she.” You should follow whatever approach is natural in your language.

Ruth 3:6

Section 3:1–18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed Naomi’s plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man

did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi’s Plan for Ruth’s Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

3:6a–b (combined/reordered)

- ¶ So Ruth did exactly what her mother-in-law had advised her to do. And later that evening she went over to the threshing place.
- ¶ And so Ruth followed all of Naomi’s instructions. She went to the place where they remove the chaff/husks from the barley grain and remained hidden.

General Comment on 3:6a–b

This is a summary of Ruth’s actions from here to verse 9, but it omits some of the details. In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder these two clauses. For example:

^{6b}So Ruth did everything her mother-in-law told her to do ^{6a}and went down to the threshing floor.

3:6a So she went down to the threshing floor

- ¶ So later that evening she went over to the threshing place
- ¶ Then she went to the place where they remove the chaff/husks from the barley grain

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So begins the summary of what Ruth did after she agreed to follow Naomi’s instructions.

Here are some other ways to begin this summary:

Then she went to the threshing floor

She said that and then

In some languages, it may be natural to not use a connection here.

she went down to the threshing floor: See how you translated 3:3b.

3:6b

and did everything her mother-in-law had instructed her to do.

- and did exactly what her mother-in-law had advised her to do.
- and followed all of Naomi's instructions.

and did everything her mother-in-law had instructed her to do: This clause means that Ruth followed Naomi's instructions. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as instructed means "commanded."

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and did everything her mother-in-law had instructed her to do (NET)

and did just as her mother-in-law had commanded her (ESV)

and did just as her mother-in-law had instructed her (NRSV)

her mother-in-law: The Hebrew and most versions refer to Naomi here by the phrase her mother-in-law rather than by her name. This form of reference here follows the pattern of Hebrew stories. It also showed Ruth's respect for Naomi.

In some languages, it may be clearer or more natural to use Naomi's name. For example:

And she did everything that Naomi had asked her to do. (EASY)

...her mother-in-law Naomi...

Ruth 3:7

Section 3:1-18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed Naomi's plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi's Plan for Ruth's Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

3:7a

After Boaz had finished eating and drinking and was in good spirits,

- Boaz finished eating and drinking and was feeling satisfied/happy.
- After Boaz had his meal, he was in a good mood

After Boaz had finished eating and drinking: In Hebrew, this clause is literally "And Boaz ate and he drank."BART. This clause simply means that Boaz had a meal. The BSB and some other versions use a time phrase such as After. They also supply the word finished. One of the reasons Boaz was in good spirits is that he was full after he had eaten.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Boaz ate and drank (CEB)

After his evening meal (NCV)

Not much later, Boaz finished eating and drinking (VOICE)

and was in good spirits: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as was in good spirits is literally "his heart was good." This is an idiom that means Boaz was "feeling happy and satisfied" after his meal.

There are two options to translate this idiom:

- Translate the meaning of the idiom. For example:

and he was in a good mood (CEB)

and he was in a contented mood (NRSV)

and was feeling happy (CEV)

- Use an idiom in your language that means “feeling happy” or “satisfied/content.”

3:7b

he went to lie down at the end of the heap of grain.

- Then he went to the end/edge of the pile of grain and lay down.
- and found a place behind the heap of grain and lay down there to sleep.

he went to lie down at the end of the heap of grain:

This clause describes the movement of Boaz from where he ate to where he would sleep. This would probably have been a short distance away.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and went to lie down at the edge of the pile of grain (NABRE)

and lay down beside the pile of barley (NJB)

He lay down next to the heap of barley seeds (EASY)

Then he went over to the far end of the pile of grain. He lay down and went to sleep (T4T)

at the end of the heap of grain: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the end refers to the distant or opposite end of a space or area. Here it probably refers to the side of the pile of grain opposite from where Ruth could see him. Block (page 178).

3:7c

Then Ruth went in secretly, uncovered his feet, and lay down.

- Then Ruth went over to him without making a sound and removed the cover from his feet and lay down there.
- Ruth waited a while, and then walked quietly over to him, lifted the cover from his feet, and lay down there at his feet.

Verse 7a–b described Boaz’s actions. Here the story describes what Ruth did. She probably waited until some time had passed. You should follow a natural way in your language to describe the change of actions from one character in a story to the actions of another.

Then: In Hebrew, this sentence begins with the common conjunction which the BSB translates as Then which is used for introducing the next event in a series of events.

Here are some ways to begin this sentence:

After a while

A little later

Ruth went in secretly: The word which the BSB translates as secretly means to do something quietly or without making a sound in order to avoid being seen, heard, or known.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Then Ruth went to him very quietly (ERV)

Then she went over to him secretly (GW)

she was quiet and came to where he was

Ruth: The Hebrew text does not use Ruth’s name here but refers to her by the pronoun “she.” You may follow either approach. Be sure your readers clearly understand who is referred to.

uncovered his feet, and lay down: Translate similarly to 3:4b.

Ruth 3:8

Section 3:1–18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed Naomi’s plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that

Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi's Plan for Ruth's Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

3:8a

At midnight, Boaz was startled, turned over,

- During the night he woke up suddenly, turned over, (GNT)
- At about midnight, he suddenly woke up shivering.

In Hebrew, this sentence begins with a word that means “And it happened” or “And it was.” The conversation between Ruth and Boaz that begins in the next verse (3:9–15) is the main event or climax of this part of the book of Ruth. This word introduces the dramatic event that leads up to this climax. For an explanation of the use of this Hebrew word (*wayəhî*) to introduce an event that leads to the climax of a story, see Van der Merwe (page 332, section 44.5.1.i.b).

Here are some ways to begin this sentence:

Suddenly (LB)

Just then

Now it happened...that (NKJV)

The BSB and most English versions do not translate this word here. But you should consider how your language naturally leads up to the main event or climax of a story.

At midnight: This phrase refers to an approximate time around midnight. The Hebrew language and culture did not divide the night hours into exact units.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Around midnight (NLT)

In the middle of the night (NIV)

During the night (GNT)

Boaz was startled: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as Boaz was startled is literally “the man trembled.” The verb that means “tremble” usually refers to shaking from fear. The text does not say what made Boaz “tremble,” but the most likely reason was the cold air on his feet. And this is exactly what Naomi had planned.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he woke up suddenly (GNT)

the man was shivering (GW)

the man was startled (ESV)

Boaz suddenly woke up (NLT96)

If the options in your language for translating “trembled” force you to be specific about why Boaz trembled, it should be from the cold rather than from fear.

Boaz: As in 3:3c, you may translate this phrase literally as “the man,” use the pronoun “he,” or refer to Boaz by name.

turned over: The word which the BSB translates as turned over is rare in the OT, so scholars are not sure what it means. There are four ways to interpret this word:

1. It means he turned or rolled over. For example:

and turned over (ESV)

and he rolled over (NCV) (BSB, ESV, GNT, GW, KJV, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. It means he groped around (for his covers). For example:

groped about (NABRE)

reached out (NABRE) Interpretation (2) is also supported by LEB and Block (page 179).

1. It means he looked all around. For example:

looked about him (NJB) (NJB)

1. It means he sat up or bent forward. For example:

bent forward (NASB) (NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

3:8b

and there lying at his feet was a woman!

- and discovered a woman lying at his feet. (NIV)
- and was surprised to find a woman lying at his feet. (GNT)

and there lying at his feet was a woman!: The author of Ruth used dramatic language in this clause to help the reader to experience how surprising it was for Boaz to find a woman lying at his feet. In Hebrew, this clause begins with a phrase that means “and behold.” The BSB does not use words to translate this phrase, but the exclamation mark (!) at the end of the sentence helps to match this dramatic and lively Hebrew expression.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and Look! A woman lying at his feet!AYB7 (page 147).

and was shocked to see a woman lying at his feet (CEV)

He was surprised to find a woman lying at his feet! (NLT)

he discovered there was a woman lying at his feet (VOICE)

he saw a woman who was lying there at his feet (EASY)

Translate this clause in a way that will help your readers to understand how very surprised Boaz must have felt by what he found.

Ruth 3:9

Section 3:1–18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed

Naomi’s plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi’s Plan for Ruth’s Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

3:9a

“Who are you?” he asked.

- And he said, “Who are you?”
- He asked, “Who is there?”

“Who are you?” he asked: As in previous verses, you may want to put the quote introducer at the beginning. For example:

He asked, “Who are you?” (CJB)

3:9b

“I am your servant Ruth,” she replied.

- And she answered, “I am Ruth, your female servant.
- She replied, “Sir, it’s me, Ruth.

“I am your servant Ruth,” she replied: Again, the BSB has placed the words she replied after the quoted words of Ruth. In most languages, it is more natural to put this quote introducer at the beginning of the sentence. For example:

And she answered, “I am Ruth, your servant. (ESV)

your servant: When Ruth referred to herself as your servant, she spoke in a figurative way. She did not literally mean that she was his slave or servant. 3:9 + Many commentators discuss here the slight difference in meaning between these two Hebrew words for a female servant. Both terms could be used by a woman to address someone with respect. But the word used

here implies a slightly higher social status than the one used in 2:13 and it can imply that Ruth was available to Boaz as a wife or concubine. Ruth used this figure of speech to indicate her respect and humility to someone who had higher status than herself.

There are two options to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the literal meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

I am Ruth, your servant girl (NCV)

- Use a term of respect that expresses the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

Sir, I am Ruth (CEV)

My lord, it is I, Ruth

3:9c-d (combined/reordered)

- You are a relative who is supposed to take care of me. So spread the edge of your robe/covering over me.”
- You are one of my husband’s relatives and you have a duty to protect our^(excl) family. So please take me into your care/protection as your wife.”

General Comment on reordering in 3:9c-d

Before you translate 9c-d you should consider the natural order in which your language should place the two clauses of this sentence. In 9c Ruth made an appeal or request to Boaz, and in 9d she gave the basis or reason for that appeal. In many languages, it will be more natural to reorder these clauses. For example:

^{9d}You are a kinsman-redeemer of our family, ^{9c}so spread the corner of your garment over me.

3:9c

“Spread the corner of your garment over me,

- Cover me, your servant, with the edge of your robe/covering,
- Please take me into your care/protection as your wife,

Spread the corner of your garment over me: This clause is a Hebrew idiom with a double meaning. The figurative meaning of the idiom is “marry me” or “take me as your wife.” However, the literal meaning (expressed in the BSB) also fits this context. (See

the note and footnote under corner of your garment below.) With this statement, Ruth was asking for two things. She wanted Boaz to take her as his wife, and she also wanted him to cover her up from the cold night air.

Here are some options to translate this idiom:

- Translate the literal meaning and put the figurative meaning in a footnote. For example:

So spread the edge of your cover over me. (CEV)

FOOTNOTE: In Hebrew, these words have another meaning, which is, “Look after me as your wife.”

- Translate the figurative meaning and put the literal meaning in a footnote. For example:

Please marry me.

FOOTNOTE: In Hebrew she said, “Cover me with the edge of your robe/blanket.” But these words have another meaning which is, “Look after me as your wife.”

- Use a short clause that expresses both the literal and figurative meaning. For example:

Spread the edge of your robe over me to show that you will marry me.

Translate this clause in a natural and meaningful way in your language.

Spread...over me: This means “cover me with” or “stretch out over me.”

the corner of your garment: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the corner of your garment refers to the “edge,” “boundary,” or “corner” of a blanket, covering, or item of clothing. This Hebrew word has a double meaning which is important in this context. It can also refer to the “wings” of a bird or animal. This was a figure of speech that referred to care and protection, like a young bird seeking protection under the “wings” of its mother. With this meaning, the whole idiom would be expressed literally as, “Spread your wings over me” (similarly as ESV). In 2:12b Boaz spoke to Ruth with a similar figure of speech, “under whose wings you have come to take refuge.” There, the Lord’s “wings” were a figurative reference to his care and protection for Ruth in a lasting relationship. Here Ruth was asking Boaz for care and protection in

a lasting relationship of marriage. In ancient Hebrew culture, when one spoke of a man covering a woman with his “wings” (or edge of his robe), it meant that he was promising to take her into his protection and care as a wife (Block, page 180, and Bush, pages 164–165). See also Ezekiel 16:8.

me: In Hebrew, Ruth spoke of herself to Boaz here as “your servant.” She did not use the pronoun me. This is the same word for “servant” that she used to refer to herself in 3:9b. See the note there. In both places, she used this word as a figure of speech to show humility and respect to Boaz.

If referring to yourself as someone’s “servant” is a natural or possible way in your language to show respect, consider saying it that way here. For example:

Spread out your robe over your servant. (CEB)

If your audience would assume that Ruth meant that she was a literal servant to Boaz, you should follow the BSB and some other translations by using the pronoun me.

3:9d

for you are a kinsman-redeemer.”

- because you are a relative who is responsible to care for our^(excl) family.”
- for you are one of my husband’s relatives. And you have a duty to help our family.”

for: The Hebrew conjunction which the BSB translates as for means “because.” Here it introduces a basis or reason for the request that Ruth made to Boaz in 9c. If you are reordering 9c–d as described in the General Comment above, it may not be necessary to include an explicit translation of this conjunction.

you are a kinsman-redeemer: See the notes on 2:20d. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as kinsman-redeemer refers to someone who was responsible to defend and protect the rights of needy relatives, including widows. Ruth reminded Boaz that this was his duty because he was a close relative of her dead husband.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you are the relative who is supposed to take care of me (CEV)

one of those who have responsibility to care for our family

Because you are a close relative, you are responsible for taking care of me. So please marry me. (GNT)

you have a duty to help/protect our^(excl) family

See how you translated this word in 2:20d and use a similar expression here.

Ruth 3:10

Section 3:1–18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed Naomi’s plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi’s Plan for Ruth’s Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

3:10a

Then Boaz said, “May the LORD bless you, my daughter.”

- ¶ And Boaz answered, “You are like my own daughter. I pray that Yahweh will be good/kind to you^(sing).”
- ¶ Boaz said, “Dear young lady, may Yahweh show you his favor.”

Then Boaz said, “May the LORD bless you, my daughter: In Hebrew, this sentence indicates that Boaz wanted the LORD to bless Ruth. See how you

translated the word bless. in 2:19b and 2:20a and translate it the same way here.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

Boaz replied, “May the LORD bless you, my daughter. (GW)

Boaz replied: The LORD bless you! (CEV)

After Ruth said this, Boaz answered, “May the LORD show you his favor.”

my daughter: Boaz addressed Ruth in a kind and polite way as my daughter. You should use the same term as in 2:8a.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

my dear (NET)

dear young lady

young woman

you who are like my own daughter

3:10b

You have shown more kindness now than before,

- “This act of loyalty and love is even better than what you^(sing) did before.
- “What you have done now shows more faithful love to your husband’s family than what you did at first.

You have shown more kindness: The Hebrew word *hesed* that the BSB translates as kindness combines the ideas of love and loyalty. The BSB, like the Hebrew, does not say to whom Ruth was kind or loyal. However, in some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. Boaz was speaking of Ruth’s kindness to Naomi and to Naomi’s family. Ruth was kind to Naomi because she was willing to marry Boaz. In that way, she made it possible for him to take care of Naomi and give her a grandchild as her kinsman-redeemer. See the notes in the “Introduction to Ruth” on *hesed* and refer to how you translated this term in 1:8c and 2:20b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

this second act of faithful love (NJB)

family loyalty in what you are doing now (GNT)

This act of kindness (NCV)

devoted to the family (REB)

now than before: This phrase means that the kindness that Ruth showed by seeking to marry Boaz was even better than her previous kindness to Naomi. Boaz mentioned those ways in 2:11.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

is greater than what you did before (NET)

is better than the first (GW)

is greater than the kindness you showed to Naomi in the beginning (NCV)

even greater...than in what you did for your mother-in-law (GNT)

3:10c

because you have not run after the younger men, whether rich or poor.

- You did not try to find a young man to marry you, whether he is rich or whether he is poor.
- That is because you^(sing) have not pursued the young men, neither the poor ones nor the rich ones.

because you have not run after the younger men, whether rich or poor: This sentence gives the reason why Ruth’s second kindness was greater than her first. She could have tried to marry a younger man, but chose to marry Boaz instead to give Naomi a grandchild.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

by not running after any young man, whether rich or poor (REB)

because you have not pursued younger men, whether rich or poor (CSB)

You didn’t look for a young man to marry, either rich or poor. (NCV)

You could have looked for a younger man, either rich or poor, but you didn’t. (CEV)

The Hebrew verb phrase that the BSB translates as run after is an idiom used commonly in the OT that means “seek to marry.” Boaz knew that Ruth was concerned about doing what was best for Naomi. She could have encouraged some younger man to marry her, but she had not done this. She had approached only someone who could act as Naomi’s kinsman-redeemer.

the younger men: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the younger men has the definite article as part of the word. It therefore refers to “the young men” of Bethlehem, meaning those who lived close by and whom Ruth could have married.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

one of the young men (NET)

someone younger

whether rich or poor: The BSB has reversed the order of the Hebrew words meaning rich and poor because this sounds better in English. Use the order that is most natural in your language.

Ruth 3:11

Section 3:1–18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed Naomi’s plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi’s Plan for Ruth’s Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

3:11a

And now do not be afraid, my daughter.

- My daughter, there is no need to fear.
- So, dear woman, do^(sing) not worry about anything.

And now: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as And now introduces a new idea or subject. Here Boaz will make a promise to Ruth. The BSB is not using the English word now as a time word. Some translations leave this Hebrew word implicit. Introduce the next idea in a way that is natural in your language.

do not be afraid: This clause indicates that Boaz did not want Ruth to fear or worry. The next clause suggests that she might be afraid of what Boaz would do after her request.

my daughter: Boaz again addressed Ruth in a kind and polite way. See how you translated this phrase in 2:8a and 3:10a.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

do not fear (ESV)

don’t worry (NET)

3:11b

I will do for you whatever you request,

- All that you^(sing) have asked of me, that I will do.
- I will do for you everything that you have asked me to do.

I will do for you whatever you request: This sentence gives the reason why Ruth did not need to be afraid. It showed that Boaz agreed to do what Ruth asked. By saying whatever you request, Boaz showed that he realized that he had to do more than marry Ruth. He showed that he was willing to perform all the duties of a kinsman-redeemer.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

Everything you propose, I will do for you (TLV)

I will do whatever you say. (GW)

I intend to do for you everything you propose (NET)

3:11c

since all my fellow townspeople know that you are a woman of noble character.

- All the people in this town recognize that your^(sing) character is very good.
- Everyone in town knows that you deserve respect.

since all my fellow townspeople know that you are a woman of noble character: This statement gives the reason that Boaz was willing to do all that Ruth asked. Boaz was glad to marry Ruth because everyone knew that she had excellent character.

Here are some other ways to translate this statement:

for everyone in the village knows that you are a worthy woman (NET)

because all the people in our town know you are a good woman (NCV)

all my fellow townspeople: This phrase is a general statement. It may not be true that every single person in the town knew about Ruth. The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as “all my fellow townspeople” is more literally “all the gate of the town.” The gate of the town was at the entrance of the town where leaders would gather and people would do business as in 4:1. Some think that the phrase just refers to the leaders of the town, but nearly every English translation understands it to refer to all the people in the town. Boaz meant that many people in the town of Bethlehem knew Ruth’s excellent character and faithfulness to Naomi, and they respected her.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

everyone in town (CEV)

the whole town (REB)

a woman of noble character: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as noble character indicates here that Ruth was a woman who had a good, moral character and perhaps also had good abilities. It suggests that everyone in town respected her. Think about how your language would describe a woman like that. You might want to use a figure of speech.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a very good woman (ERV)

what a fine woman you are (REB)

a worthy woman (NET)

You are respected by everyone in town. (CEV)

Ruth 3:12**Section 3:1–18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi**

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed Naomi’s plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi’s Plan for Ruth’s Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

3:12a

Yes, it is true that I am a kinsman-redeemer,

- It is true that I am a close relative who is responsible to care for you^(sing).
- You are right that I am a close relative and my duty is to help the family,

Boaz continued to speak to Ruth. He began to explain that there was another closer relative who could be the guardian-redeemer.

Yes, it is true: The Hebrew adverb that the BSB translates as it is true means “indeed” or “no doubt.” Boaz acknowledged that Ruth was correct.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

But now, though it is true (NRSV)

Yes, it is true...but (REB)

Even though it is true that

that I am a kinsman-redeemer: See how you translated this term in 3:9d.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

It is true that I am a close relative of yours (GW)

It is true that I am a close relative and am responsible for you (GNT)

Although it is true that I am a close relative and have a duty to help/protect the family

Although I am indeed a relative who has the duty to take care of you

3:12b

but there is a redeemer nearer than I.

- However, there is another man who is a closer relative to Elimelech than I am.
- but another man is a closer relation to Naomi than I am.

but there is a redeemer nearer than I: Boaz told Ruth that there was one other man who was related more closely to Elimelech than he was. That man had to decide if he wanted to act as kinsman-redeemer before Boaz could legally do that.

It appears that the nearest male relative was expected to act as the kinsman-redeemer. However, if the nearest male relative could not or would not redeem (buy back) property for his relative, then another close relative would sometimes take that responsibility.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

but there is someone who is an even closer relative (CEV)

there is another man who is more closely related to you than I am (NLT)

Ruth 3:13

Section 3:1–18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed Naomi's plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi's Plan for Ruth's Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

3:13a

Stay here tonight,

- Sleep^(sing) here the rest of the night.
- You should remain here tonight.

Stay here tonight: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Stay here means "lodge" or "stay." It is the same word that Ruth used in 1:16 to tell Naomi, "where you stay I will stay." It does not imply that Boaz suggested that Ruth have sexual relations with him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Stay here the rest of the night (GNT)

Remain here tonight (NET)

3:13b-c

(combined/reordered)

- and in the morning we will find out whether or not he will take responsibility for you. If so, well and good; if not, then I swear by the living Lord that I will take the responsibility. (GNT)

and in the morning, if he wants to redeem you, good. Let him redeem you. But if he does not want to redeem you, as surely as the LORD lives, I will. Now lie here until morning: These two “if/then” statements tell two possible results of Boaz talking to the closer relative (which is implied). It lists the possible results and their consequences one at a time. Some translations list both possibilities first and then the consequence of each. For example:

and in the morning we will see if he will take care of you. If he decides to take care of you, that is fine. But if he refuses, I will take care of you myself, as surely as the LORD lives. (NCV)

until morning, then I will find out if he is willing to look after you. If he isn't, I promise by the living God to do it myself. (CEV)

Arrange these clauses in a way that is natural and clear in your language.

3:13b

and in the morning, if he wants to redeem you, good. Let him redeem you.

- If, in the morning, the closer relative says that he wants to take care of you^(sing) that will be fine. He may do it.
- Tomorrow morning, if this other man wants to be responsible for you, he may do so, and it will be good.

and in the morning: It is implied that Boaz would do something in the morning. Some versions make this explicit. For example:

Tomorrow morning, I will tell this man about you. (T4T)

and in the morning I will talk to him (NLT)

if he wants to redeem you, good: This clause is the if clause of the first of two conditional statements. The first possibility is that the closer relative will care for Naomi and Ruth and marry Ruth. Because this man was a closer relative of Elimelech than Boaz, he had the right to choose first whether or not he would do that.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If he is willing to do his duty and help you, that is good.

if he will agree to take care of you, that is good (GW)

If he says that he will marry you and take care of you, fine (T4T)

he: This pronoun refers to the closer relative. He is never named, so if simple pronouns are not clear, you may need identify him more explicitly. For example:

the closer relative

wants to redeem you: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as wants to redeem you is based on the same root as “kinsman-redeemer” in 3:12a. See how you translated this term there. Also see the examples above in 3:13b.

good: This word is a comment on the first possible result. Boaz realized that if the other man would properly care for Ruth's and Naomi's needs, it would be good.

Let him redeem you: This clause is the “then” clause of the first conditional statement. If the other man wanted to fulfill this responsibility toward Ruth and Naomi, he should do so. It was his right.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He can take care of you. (GW)

Let him marry you. (NLT)

Let him help you. (NIRV)

3:13c

But if he does not want to redeem you, as surely as the LORD lives, I will.

- But if he does not want to, as certainly as Yahweh lives, I myself will do it.
- But I solemnly promise you^(sing), as surely as Yahweh lives, that I will be responsible for you myself if he does not want to.

But if he does not want to: This clause tells the other possible result of Boaz's talk with the closer relative. This "if" clause is the opposite of the one in 3:13b.

The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as But if he does not want to is more literally "But if he is not pleased to redeem you." The BSB leaves the last words implicit. You may need to make them explicit in your translation.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

But if he does not wish to do so (NJB)

If he refuses to help (ERV)

But if he does not wish to take care of you (GW)

as surely as the LORD lives: This was a common oath or promise. It meant that it is absolutely true that the LORD lives. In the same way, it was just as certain that the person would keep his promise.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I promise, as surely as the Lord lives (NET)

I solemnly promise that as surely as Yahweh lives (T4T)

You can be sure that the Lord lives. And you can be just as sure that (NIRV)

I will: The Hebrew uses an emphatic pronoun I here. Boaz was emphasizing to Ruth that he himself would redeem her if the other man chose not to do so.

In some languages, you may want to make explicit what Boaz will do.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I promise...to marry you (NET)

I promise...to do it myself (CEV)

I will take care of you myself (NCV)

3:13d

Now lie here until morning."

- Lie^(sing) down again until dawn/daybreak."
- So just lie here until the morning." (EASY)

Now lie here until morning: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as morning is the same general word that was used in 3:13b. However, here it probably refers to sunrise.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Lie down here until morning. (NIRV)

Now lie down and stay here till morning. (GNT)

Ruth 3:14

Section 3:1–18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed Naomi's plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi's Plan for Ruth's Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

Paragraph 3:14–15

This paragraph says that Ruth spent the rest of the night at Boaz's feet. Then it describes what they did when they first woke up.

3:14a

So she lay down at his feet until morning,

- ¶ So she lay by Boaz's feet until nearly sunrise,
- ¶ So Ruth slept near Boaz's feet until the night was ending.

So she lay down at his feet: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So introduces what Ruth did in response to what Boaz told her in 3:13.

Because this is the beginning of a new paragraph, it may be appropriate to identify the participants by name here. For example:

So Ruth stayed near his feet until morning (NCV)

Ruth lay beside Boaz's feet... (EASY)

until morning: From the statement in 3:14b, it is obvious that Ruth got up before the sun arose. Use a suitable word that can indicate a time very early in the morning, even before the sun rises.

3:14b

but she got up before anyone else could recognize her.

- but she got up while it was still too dark for people to see one another's faces.
- But she got up before there was enough light for a person to recognize someone else.

but she got up before anyone else could recognize her: In some languages, it will be necessary to explain why people could not recognize one another. They could not recognize one another because it was still too dark to see well. For example:

but she got up before it was light enough for her to be seen (GNT)

But she got up and left before it was light enough that people would be able to recognize her (T4T)

but rose before it was light enough for one man to recognize another (REB)

She got up while it was still dark, before it was light enough for people to recognize each other. (ERV)

A few translations just translate the meaning that it was still dark. They leave implied the idea that people could not recognize others. For example:

She woke up while it was still dark. (NET)

but she got up before daylight (CEV)

The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as before anyone else could recognize her is more literally "before one could recognize his companion."

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

She rose before one person could distinguish another (NJPS)

Then she got up before anyone could see her. (EASY)

3:14c

Then Boaz said, "Do not let it be known that a woman came to the threshing floor."

- Boaz thought, "No one should find out that this woman came here to this place for threshing."
- And Boaz said to himself that no one should know that Ruth was there at the area for threshing grain.

Then Boaz said: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as said can be used in some cases for a person speaking to himself (thinking). Therefore, there are two ways to interpret 3:14c:

1. This is something Boaz thought. For example:

for he thought (NJPS) (GW, NET, NCV, NJB, NJPS, REB)

1. This is something Boaz said aloud. For example:

for Boaz had said (NABRE) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GNT, KJV, NABRE, NASB, NIV, NLT, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).UBS (page 57), WBC, ZECOT. If Boaz were talking aloud to Ruth, he would probably not refer to her in the third person, especially as "the woman" (see below).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Boaz thought (NET)

And Boaz said to himself

"Do not let it be known that a woman came to the threshing floor.": There is a textual issue concerning the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as a woman:

1. The Masoretic Text (Hebrew) has "the woman." For example:

“People in town must not know that the woman came here to the threshing floor.” (NCV) (CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NABRE, NASB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NRSV, REB)

1. The Septuagint (LXX) has “a woman.” For example:

“No one must know that a woman visited the threshing floor.” (NET) (BSB, KJV, NET, NIV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). There is no reason to doubt the accuracy of the MT. Boaz was worried about the reputation of Ruth, not the reputation of any woman.

The BSB does not follow interpretation (1) for either of the above issues, so the NJB has been used as an alternate Source Line in the Display.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

“Let it not be known that the woman came to the threshing floor.” (NJPS)

“I hope that no one will ever know that this woman came to the threshing floor.” (GW)

In some languages, it might be better to use an indirect quotation to report what Boaz thought. For example:

Boaz had it in mind that no one should know that the woman had been to the threshing-floor. (REB)

Ruth 3:15

Section 3:1–18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed Naomi’s plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told

Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi’s Plan for Ruth’s Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

Paragraph 3:14–15

This paragraph says that Ruth spent the rest of the night at Boaz’s feet. Then it describes what they did when they first woke up.

3:15a

And he told her, “Bring the shawl you are wearing and hold it out.”

- Then he said to Ruth, “Take^(sing) the shawl that you have on and bring it to me and stretch it out.”
- Then he asked Ruth to bring him the shawl/cape that she was wearing and grip its corners to hold it open.

Bring the shawl you are wearing and hold it out:

Boaz asked Ruth to unwrap the shawl from around her shoulders, and then hold it open so that he could put grain into it.

This shawl was probably a wrap for her head and shoulders on top of her dress. It must have been fairly large and strong enough to carry a large amount of grain in it.

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as hold...out also means “seize” or “grip (tightly).” The shawl was only a large piece of cloth, and not a bag. So Ruth would have to hold it firmly on the corners as Boaz poured the grain to prevent it from spilling.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Hold out the shawl you are wearing and grip it tightly. (NET)

Bring me your shawl and hold it open. (NCV)

Stretch out the cape you’re wearing and hold it tight. (GW)

In some languages, it may be more natural to use an indirect quotation here. For example:

Then he told her to bring her shawl and hold it firmly.

3:15b

When she did so, he shoveled six measures of barley into her shawl.

- While she held it tightly, he poured six measures of barley into her shawl, and then he placed it on her.
- Ruth gripped the corners of her shawl, and Boaz poured about thirty (30) kilograms of barley into it. Then he lifted it onto her head.

When she did so: This clause is more literally “And she held it.” In some languages, you may want to make explicit what she did as in the Hebrew. For example:

As she held it tightly (NET)

So Ruth held her shawl open (NCV)

So she held it tight while (GW)

he shoveled six measures of barley: The Hebrew of this clause is more literally “He measured (out) six (of) barley.” It means that Boaz measured the barley as he put it in Ruth’s shawl. The text does not say what measuring container or unit was used. However it is clear that this was a generous amount but not too much for a strong young woman to carry alone. Most scholars think it was around thirty kilograms (sixty-five pounds).

If you can, use a special unit of weight that can be used for grain, such as rice. Then use the number of units that will make a total of about thirty kilograms. If you do not have a special unit of weight for grain, you may translate six measures as “Thirty (30) kilograms” or “sixty-five (65) pounds.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and he measured six measures of barley (NASB)

he poured about 30 kilograms of barley into her shawl

He poured more than fifty pounds of barley into it (NIRV)

And he filled it with a lot of grain (CEV)

into her shawl: Women at that time often carried heavy loads on their heads. Sometimes they needed help to get a very heavy load into position to carry it. Boaz helped her lift this heavy weight and get it properly balanced on her head, or possibly on her back or shoulders.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Boaz then put it on her head (NCV)

and placed it on her back (NLT)

and helped her lift it to her shoulder (GNT)

3:15c

Then he went into the city.

- After that, he returned to the town.
- Then Boaz left the threshing floor and went into town.

Then he went into the city: There is a textual problem with this verse:

1. The Masoretic Text has “he went into the town.” For example:

Then he returned to the town. (NLT) (BSB, GW, NABRE, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT, NRSV)

1. The Syriac and Vulgate have “she went into the town.” Some scholars think that the feminine verb was the original text because 3:16a continues the story with Ruth arriving home. For example:

When Ruth got back to town (CEV) (CEV, GNT, KJV, NASB, NJB, NJPS, REB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). ZECOT. There does not seem to be a strong reason to not follow it. Boaz wanted to take care of his responsibility quickly, and the text here indicates that he returned to town as soon as he gave Ruth. The KJV has “Who are thou, my daughter? No other versions understand the question this way, so the Notes have not made it an interpretation issue. the grain.

Ruth 3:16

Section 3:1–18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because

women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed Naomi's plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi's Plan for Ruth's Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

Paragraph 3:16–18

This paragraph tells what happened when Ruth went back to Naomi. Ruth told her what had happened and about the barley. Naomi told her to wait for Boaz to act.

In this paragraph, the author does not give the names of the people involved, but uses pronouns. Some names have been included in many English versions as implied information from the context. In your translation, you may also need to name the individuals so that your readers can better understand the story.

3:16a

When Ruth returned to her mother-in-law, Naomi asked her, "How did it go, my daughter?"

- ¶ When Ruth arrived at her mother-in-law's home, Naomi said, "What happened, my daughter?"
- ¶ Ruth went back to her mother-in-law. Naomi asked her, "How did things go for you^(sing), dear daughter-in-law?"
- And when Ruth went to Naomi's house, Naomi asked her daughter-in-law what Boaz said.

When Ruth returned to her mother-in-law, Naomi asked her: This clause tells what Ruth did while Boaz was going to town.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

When Ruth returned to her mother-in-law, Naomi asked (NET)

When Ruth returned home to Naomi, Naomi asked her (EASY)

Ruth went to the home of her mother-in-law, Naomi. Naomi went to the door and asked (ERV)

How did it go, my daughter?: The Hebrew question that the BSB translates as How did it go, my daughter? is more literally "Who are you, my daughter?" In this context, it means that Naomi wanted to know what happened when Ruth met with Boaz.3:16

Here are some other ways to translate this question:

How did things go with you, daughter? (NJB)

What happened, my daughter? (NLT)

Did you have success, my daughter?

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this question as an indirect quotation. For example:

Naomi asked her what had happened (CEV)

3:16b

Then Ruth told her all that Boaz had done for her.

- Then Ruth told her all that Boaz did for her.
- And Ruth told Naomi everything that Boaz said that he would do for her

Then Ruth told her all that Boaz had done for her:

The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as all that Boaz had done for her refers to his promises to talk to the closer relative and marry her if that relative would not do it. It also refers to the gift of barley. Because the barley is mentioned in 3:17, you might want to make the promises explicit here. For example:

Then Ruth told her all that Boaz promised to do for her

And Ruth told Naomi everything that Boaz said to her

Ruth 3:17

Section 3:1-18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed Naomi's plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi's Plan for Ruth's Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

Paragraph 3:16-18

This paragraph tells what happened when Ruth went back to Naomi. Ruth told her what had happened and about the barley. Naomi told her to wait for Boaz to act.

In this paragraph, the author does not give the names of the people involved, but uses pronouns. Some names have been included in many English versions as implied information from the context. In your translation, you may also need to name the individuals so that your readers can better understand the story.

3:17a-b

And she said, "He gave me these six measures of barley, for he said, 'Do not go back to your mother-in-law empty-handed.'" The quotation of what Boaz said gives the reason that he gave Ruth the barley. In some languages, it may be more natural to reverse the order of these clauses. For example:

She added, "He told me I must not come back to you empty-handed, so he gave me all this barley." (GNT)

3:17a

And she said, "He gave me these six measures of barley,

- She also said, "These six measures of barley, he gave all this to me.
- And she said, "Look at these thirty (30) kilograms of barley that Boaz gave me!"

And she said, "He gave me these six measures of barley...": The Hebrew text emphasizes the phrase

that the BSB translates as these six measures of barley. That emphasis implies that it was a very large gift. The size of the gift showed that Boaz was concerned for Naomi and Ruth's welfare.

If you can communicate this emphasis in your language, then you should do so. One way to show the emphasis is to add a word like "all." For example:

She also said, "He gave me all these six measures of barley."

She said to Naomi, 'He also gave me all this barley. (EASY)

3:17b

for he said, 'Do not go back to your mother-in-law empty-handed.'"

- He said to me, 'Do^(sing) not return to your mother-in-law with empty hands.'
- And when he gave this to me, he said that I should not go back to you unless I took something for you."

for he said, 'Do not go back to your mother-in-law empty-handed': The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as Do not go back to your mother-in-law empty-handed is a quotation inside another quotation. Ruth was telling Naomi exactly what Boaz said. In many languages, it will be necessary to translate this as indirect speech. For example:

Boaz said that I should not return to you without bringing a gift.

Boaz said that I should not return to you without bringing a gift.

empty-handed: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as empty-handed is the same word that the BSB translates as "empty" in 1:21a. There, Naomi said that the LORD had brought her back to Israel empty. She meant that her husband and sons had died and she

was poor. If you can translate the word the same in both verses, it would be good. However, in some languages it may necessary to say here that Boaz wanted Ruth to return with something, or with hands full of grain. For example:

Do not return to Naomi with nothing to give to her. (EASY)

He said that I must not go home without bringing a gift for you. (ERV)

Ruth 3:18

Section 3:1–18: Ruth asked Boaz to help her and Naomi

Life for widows in ancient Israel was difficult, especially for those who had no grown sons, because women depended on men to protect and provide for them. This fourth section tells how Naomi wanted to find a new husband for Ruth so that she could have a better living situation. So, she instructed Ruth to go and meet Boaz secretly at night. Ruth followed Naomi's plan and asked him to take her into his care as his wife. She told him that this was his duty as a relative of her dead husband.

Boaz was happy to do this, but there was a problem. There was another relative who was more closely related to Naomi and Ruth than he was. If that man did not want to marry Ruth, Boaz promised that he would marry her. When Ruth returned home and told Naomi what had happened, Naomi assured her that Boaz would work hard to take care of the situation that very day.

Here are some other examples of a heading for this section:

Naomi's Plan for Ruth's Marriage (GW)

Ruth and Boaz at the Threshing Floor (NIV)

Ruth asked Boaz to marry her

Paragraph 3:16–18

This paragraph tells what happened when Ruth went back to Naomi. Ruth told her what had happened and about the barley. Naomi told her to wait for Boaz to act.

In this paragraph, the author does not give the names of the people involved, but uses pronouns. Some names have been included in many English versions as

implied information from the context. In your translation, you may also need to name the individuals so that your readers can better understand the story.

3:18a

“Wait, my daughter,” said Naomi, “until you find out how things go,

- Then Naomi said, “Just wait^(sing), my daughter-in-law. Be patient until you know the outcome of this situation.
- Naomi said, “Be patient, dear child, until you hear what will happen.

“Wait, my daughter,” said Naomi, “until you find out how things go:

This verse part indicates that Naomi wanted Ruth to be patient until there was more news. She did not need to leave their home to seek news about Boaz's actions, or to do anything more herself.

The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as how things go refers to the results of what Boaz said that he would do. Naomi was referring to whether Boaz or the other redeemer would act as the kinsman-redeemer and marry Ruth.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Naomi said to her, “Now be patient, Ruth, until you see how this all turns out. (GNT)

Then Naomi answered, “Child! We must wait until we know what will happen when Boaz talks with the other relative.

3:18b

for he will not rest unless he has resolved the matter today.”

- That man will not stop working until this situation is resolved, this very day.”
- You can be patient, because Boaz will keep working to make an agreement today about what will happen.”

for: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as for introduces a reason clause and is often translated as “because.” Naomi told Ruth that she should be patient, because Boaz would most certainly do what he said that he would do. However, the idea of reason is not very strong here, so in some languages, it may be more natural to omit it.

he will not rest: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as he refers to Boaz, so you could also use his name.

The expression will not rest is used here as a figure of speech. Naomi believed that Boaz would keep trying to settle this matter and would not stop until he did so.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

that man will not stop

Boaz will surely do what he needs to do (EASY)

unless he has resolved the matter today: This clause means that Boaz would not rest or stop until he resolved the problem of who would redeem Ruth. He would talk with the closer relative and then know whether that relative or Boaz would redeem Ruth. Naomi knew that Boaz would do what he said that same day. Either the closer relative would redeem and marry Ruth or Boaz would. By the end of the day, Ruth would know which would happen.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

until he solves the problem, which he will do today

until they decide the matter of your marriage today

until he has finished doing what he should do today (NCV)

has resolved: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as resolved more literally means “finished” or “completed.” Here it refers to a legal decision about what will happen. It could be translated as “decided.”

today: Naomi was putting emphasis on this word. She believed that Boaz would conclude this important issue on that day.

Ruth 4:1

Section 4:1–12: Boaz assumed responsibility for Ruth
In this final chapter of the book, Ruth received the reward for her loyalty to Naomi.

Boaz is in focus in the first twelve verses. He met with the other close relative in the presence of many witnesses to discuss the entire situation. The other relative did not want to buy Elimelech’s property that Naomi was selling, if the arrangement also meant that he had to marry Ruth. So Boaz said that he would act as the redeemer himself.

In section 4:13–17, Boaz and Ruth were married, and the LORD soon gave them a son. The women in Bethlehem named the son Obed and rejoiced that Naomi now had a “son” to carry on her family line and care for her in her old age. So both Naomi and Ruth were going to be cared for, and the women went from “emptiness” to “fullness.”

Section 4:18–22 concludes the book with a genealogy that lists of the family line of Perez, who was a son of Judah and grandson of Jacob (who is also called Israel). The family line is listed from Perez through Obed to King David.

Here are some other examples of section headings for 4:1–12:

Boaz Redeems Ruth (ESV)

Boaz Settles the Matter (NET)

Structure:

Some commentaries divide this section into four scenes: NICOT, Sakenfield, Cornerstone, and Sakenfield. These divide the scenes in at least two different ways.

1. 4:1–2 Introduction: Boaz Convenes a Legal Assembly
2. 4:3–8 Boaz Obtains the Rights of Redemption
3. 4:9–10 Boaz Formalizes the Agreement
4. 4:11–12 Witnessing and Blessing

One commentary divides this section into three scenes. Block (pages 203–204).

1. 4:1–2 setting the stage for the legal drama
2. 4:3–8 report of the legal drama
3. 4:9–12 significance of legal drama

You may divide the paragraphs in these scenes in whatever way best fits the structure of your language.

Paragraph 4:1–2

This paragraph describes how Boaz convened a legal assembly at the town gate prior to the actual legal proceedings.

4:1a

Meanwhile, Boaz went to the gate and sat down there.

- ¶ Meanwhile Boaz went to the meeting place inside the gate of the town. As he was sitting there,
- ¶ During this time, Boaz had gone to the place where the leaders met in the town gate area, and he had sat down there to wait.

Meanwhile, Boaz went to the gate: The Hebrew conjunction that connects this to the previous verse does

not indicate when this action took place in relation to the events that occurred at the end of chapter 3. The BSB uses *Meanwhile* to begin the sentence, since it seems quite probable that Boaz went up to the gate area of the city and sat down there to wait during the same time that Ruth was returning home to Naomi and talking with her (3:16–18).

Here is another way to translate *Meanwhile*:

Before the close relative arrived

to the gate: Here the phrase to the gate is probably an idiom that means “went to court.” At that time it was normal for the town meeting place to be just inside the town gate. UBS (pages 61–63). Block (pages 203–204) defines the city gate here as equivalent to a town court. That is where Boaz went. He did not go to the gate itself.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Boaz went to the meeting place at the town gate (GNT)

Boaz went to the place where leaders met to decide important things/cases

If people in your culture are not familiar with towns that have walls and gates, it may be necessary to explain in a footnote that towns had walls and gates in OT times.

and sat down there: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as *sat down* is the same verb translated as “wait” in 3:18a. Boaz may have expected that he would have to wait for a while. Apparently, the relative he wanted to see was not there when he arrived. So he sat down to wait for him.

4:1b

Soon the kinsman-redeemer of whom he had spoken came along,

- right then Elimelech’s closest relative came by. He is the one Boaz had mentioned.
- At that very time, the one who was responsible to care for the family was walking past. He is the one Boaz had told Ruth about.

In Hebrew, this part of the verse includes the word *hinneh*, which is often translated as “Behold” or “Look.” See how you translated it in 3:8b.

This word calls the readers’ attention to what happened. Use whatever special words, word order, or

other method your language uses to focus attention on someone or some event.

Soon the kinsman-redeemer of whom he had spoken came along: This refers to the man whom Boaz had mentioned to Ruth. This man had the right and duty to redeem Naomi’s land and to marry Ruth. Here are some other ways to translate kinsman-redeemer:

nearest relative (GNT)

the one who was responsible to care for the family

the relative with the duty to help the family

See how your translated “kinsman-redeemer” in 2:20c and 3:9d.

came along: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as *came along* indicates that the man was in the process of “passing by” or “going through” the gate area when Boaz saw him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

was passing by (NASB)

came past (REB)

4:1c

and Boaz said, “Come over here, my friend, and sit down.”

- Boaz called out, “My brother/friend, please come over here and sit down.”
- Then Boaz called to him and asked him to come and sit down.

and Boaz said, “Come over here, my friend, and sit down.”: Boaz called out to the man and asked him to Come over to where Boaz was sitting. The man was apparently going somewhere else, but Boaz asked him to stop and take care of this business first.

my friend: Boaz was looking for this particular man, and he certainly knew his name. But the author of the book of Ruth did not know the name or did not wish to provide it.

There are two ways to translate what Boaz said:

- Use a direct quotation, but leave the form of address general. For example:

“My friend/brother, come over here...”

- Use an indirect quotation. For example:

Boaz invited the man to come over.

4:1d

So he went over and sat down.

- So he approached and sat down.
- So the man walked over to Boaz and sat down.

So: The same Hebrew conjunction that was used in 4:1a, in this verse part indicates result. The other relative came over to Boaz, because Boaz had called him.

he went over and sat down: The important status that Boaz had in the community is clearly seen here and in 4:2b. When Boaz asked the relative and the elders of the town to do something, they promptly did exactly what he asked.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

So the man came over and sat down. (GW)

So Boaz invited him to come over and sit down, and he did. (CEV)

Ruth 4:2

Section 4:1–12: Boaz assumed responsibility for Ruth

In this final chapter of the book, Ruth received the reward for her loyalty to Naomi.

Boaz is in focus in the first twelve verses. He met with the other close relative in the presence of many witnesses to discuss the entire situation. The other relative did not want to buy Elimelech's property that Naomi was selling, if the arrangement also meant that he had to marry Ruth. So Boaz said that he would act as the redeemer himself.

In section 4:13–17, Boaz and Ruth were married, and the LORD soon gave them a son. The women in Bethlehem named the son Obed and rejoiced that Naomi now had a “son” to carry on her family line and care for her in her old age. So both Naomi and Ruth were going to be cared for, and the women went from “emptiness” to “fullness.”

Section 4:18–22 concludes the book with a genealogy that lists of the family line of Perez, who was a son of Judah and grandson of Jacob (who is also called Israel). The family line is listed from Perez through Obed to King David.

Here are some other examples of section headings for 4:1–12:

Boaz Redeems Ruth (ESV)

Boaz Settles the Matter (NET)

Structure:

Some commentaries divide this section into four scenes: NICOT, Sakenfield, Cornerstone, and Sakenfield. These divide the scenes in at least two different ways.

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1. 4:1–2 setting the stage for the legal drama
2. 4:3–8 report of the legal drama
3. 4:9–12 significance of legal drama

You may divide the paragraphs in these scenes in whatever way best fits the structure of your language.

Paragraph 4:1–2

This paragraph describes how Boaz convened a legal assembly at the town gate prior to the actual legal proceedings.

4:2a

Then Boaz took ten of the elders of the city

- Boaz chose ten of the leading men of the town
- Next/Then Boaz chose ten men from among the town's leaders

Then: In Hebrew, this verse begins with the same Hebrew conjunction as in 4:1d. Here the BSB translates it as Then. In some languages, it may be helpful to use a conjunction that indicates the next action. For example:

Next

Boaz took ten of the elders of the city: The elders were the leading men of the town who discussed important things and made the decisions that governed the town. They were usually older men whom the people of the town recognized as its leaders. In this situation, the elders were called together to witness a legal process. See 4:9a–b.

took: In this verse, the Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as took means that Boaz “selected” the

elders. He may have asked some men to stop as he saw them about to pass through the gate, or he may have sent someone to ask certain men that he knew to come to a meeting.

In Hebrew, it says “ten of the elders,” so apparently there were more than ten elders in the town.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Then Boaz chose ten men who were leaders of that city (GW)

Boaz gathered ten of the older leaders of the city (NCV)

4:2b

and said, “Sit here,” and they did so.

- and said to them, “Please sit here.” So they sat down.
- and asked them to sit down with him. So they did as he asked.

and said, “Sit here,” and they did so: Translate this in a way that shows that Boaz politely asked the elders to sit down. For example:

and asked them to sit down there too (GNT)

Please sit down here

and: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as and introduces what happened as a result of what Boaz had said. You could translate it as “so.”

they did so: This refers to the request Boaz made that the elders sit down with him. Here are some other ways to translate these words:

So they also sat down. (GW)

When they were seated (GNT)

Ruth 4:3

Section 4:1–12: Boaz assumed responsibility for Ruth
In this final chapter of the book, Ruth received the reward for her loyalty to Naomi.

Boaz is in focus in the first twelve verses. He met with the other close relative in the presence of many witnesses to discuss the entire situation. The other relative did not want to buy Elimelech’s property that Naomi was selling, if the arrangement also meant that

he had to marry Ruth. So Boaz said that he would act as the redeemer himself.

In section 4:13–17, Boaz and Ruth were married, and the LORD soon gave them a son. The women in Bethlehem named the son Obed and rejoiced that Naomi now had a “son” to carry on her family line and care for her in her old age. So both Naomi and Ruth were going to be cared for, and the women went from “emptiness” to “fullness.”

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1. 4:1–2 setting the stage for the legal drama
2. 4:3–8 report of the legal drama
3. 4:9–12 significance of legal drama

You may divide the paragraphs in these scenes in whatever way best fits the structure of your language.

Paragraph 4:3–6

This paragraph describes the legal discussion between Boaz and the closest relative to Naomi about whether he was willing to redeem the land. It concludes with this man’s refusal to do so.

4:3a

And he said to the kinsman-redeemer,

- ¶ Then Boaz said to the man who was a closer relative to Ruth than he was,
- ¶ Then he said to man who had responsibility to care for the family,

And he said to the kinsman-redeemer: This is the beginning of a new paragraph. Follow the grammar of your language in choosing whether you should use the name Boaz or the pronoun he.

kinsman-redeemer: This word is used often in this chapter. Therefore, even if it is necessary to use a long phrase in your language to explain the word clearly the first time it occurs, it may be possible to shorten the phrase in some cases.

4:3b

“Naomi, who has returned from the land of Moab, is selling the piece of land that belonged to our brother Elimelech.

- “Naomi has returned from Moab. She wants to sell the land that belonged to our relative Elimelech.
- “I want to talk to you about the portion of land that belonged to our relative, Elimelech. Naomi, his widow, who has recently returned from Moab, hopes/intends to sell it.

Naomi, who has returned from the land of Moab, is selling the piece of land that belonged to our brother Elimelech: This is new information. There is no mention of how Boaz knew this.

is selling the piece of land: This means that Naomi intended to put the land up for sale. She had not yet sold it. NICOT (pages 236–247), UBS (page 64). Boaz wanted to discuss the land before he mentioned that he would also marry Ruth. Naomi was selling the land, or the rights to the land, and a close relative had the duty and opportunity to buy it. This duty is also mentioned in Jeremiah 36:6–12.

land: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as land can also be translated as “field.”

Here are some other ways to translate the whole clause “Naomi, who has returned from the land of Moab, is selling the piece of land”:

“Now that Naomi has come back from Moab, she wants to sell the field (GNT)

“You know Naomi, who came back from Moab. She is selling the land (NLT)

that belonged to our brother Elimelech: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as our brother can refer to either a literal brother, a cousin, another near relative, or someone else in the same clan. In this case, the reference is to a near relative. Elimelech was probably not an actual brother of Boaz or the other relative.

Ruth 4:4

Section 4:1–12: Boaz assumed responsibility for Ruth
In this final chapter of the book, Ruth received the reward for her loyalty to Naomi.

Boaz is in focus in the first twelve verses. He met with the other close relative in the presence of many witnesses to discuss the entire situation. The other relative did not want to buy Elimelech’s property that Naomi was selling, if the arrangement also meant that he had to marry Ruth. So Boaz said that he would act as the redeemer himself.

In section 4:13–17, Boaz and Ruth were married, and the LORD soon gave them a son. The women in Bethlehem named the son Obed and rejoiced that Naomi now had a “son” to carry on her family line and care for her in her old age. So both Naomi and Ruth were going to be cared for, and the women went from “emptiness” to “fullness.”

Section 4:18–22 concludes the book with a genealogy that lists of the family line of Perez, who was a son of Judah and grandson of Jacob (who is also called Israel). The family line is listed from Perez through Obed to King David.

Here are some other examples of section headings for 4:1–12:

Boaz Redeems Ruth (ESV)

Boaz Settles the Matter (NET)

Structure:

Some commentaries divide this section into four scenes: NICOT, Sakenfield, Cornerstone, and Sakenfield. These divide the scenes in at least two different ways.

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1. 4:1–2 setting the stage for the legal drama
2. 4:3–8 report of the legal drama
3. 4:9–12 significance of legal drama

You may divide the paragraphs in these scenes in whatever way best fits the structure of your language.

Paragraph 4:3–6

This paragraph describes the legal discussion between Boaz and the closest relative to Naomi about whether

he was willing to redeem the land. It concludes with this man's refusal to do so.

4:4a

I thought I should inform you

- I want to bring this to your attention
- I decided that I should inform you about this.

I thought: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as I thought is literally “I said.” Boaz apparently said this to himself, thought it, or “decided.”

I should inform you: The Hebrew clause is literally “I will uncover your ear.” This is an idiom that means “give information to someone” or “cause someone to know the facts.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

I promised to open the matter with you (REB)

I thought I should tell you about this (NJB)

So I decided to tell you about it (NCV)

4:4b

that you may buy it back

- and suggest that you buy the land
- If you want to buy that land, then buy it now

that you may buy it back: The BSB uses an indirect quotation here. The Hebrew uses a direct quotation. In some languages, it may be more natural to use a direct quotation. For example:

^{4a}I thought I should tell you about it ^{4b}and say,
“Acquire it...” (NJB)

4:4c

in the presence of those seated here and in the presence of the elders of my people.

- in front of these town leaders and other people who are sitting here.
- as these ten elders and other people are here watching.

in the presence of: This means “in front of.” Boaz was saying that the other man should decide if he wanted to buy the land from Naomi, while the people Boaz had selected were there and could be witnesses.

those seated here and in the presence of the elders of my people: There are two ways to interpret these two phrases:

1. They refer to two groups of people. For example:

in the presence of these men sitting here and in the presence of the leaders of our people (GW) (BSB, CEV, ESV, KJV, NABRE, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NRSV, REB)

1. They refer to the same group of people that Boaz selected in 4:2a. For example:

in the presence of these men sitting here (GNT) (GNT, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with most versions.

The BSB and the Hebrew mention the elders last. In many languages, it will better to mention the more important group, the elders, before mentioning the other people seated there. For example:

These ten men and the others standing here can be witnesses. (CEV)

4:4d

If you want to redeem it, do so.

- If you want to do your duty as the nearest relative, please do it.
- If you are willing to buy it back, you to have the first chance.

If you want to redeem it, do so: In 4:4b Boaz used the general verb “buy.” But here he uses the term redeem that refers to the action of a kinsman-redeemer.

In this context, the verb includes the idea that a man buys back property to help a poor relative. So if possible you should keep the distinction here by using a different verb or verb phrase. For example:

If you wish to buy back the property, you can buy back the property. (GW)

If you are going to do your duty as next-of-kin, then do so (REB)

4:4e

But if you will not redeem it, tell me so I may know,

- But if you do not want to do that, tell me, so that I will know what you intend to do.
- But if you are not willing to buy it back, please tell me what you decide.

But if you will not redeem it, tell me so I may know:

Boaz told the man to redeem the land if he wished to do so, but asked the man to inform him if he did not want to do it. When Boaz heard the man's answer, he would know what he himself could do.

tell me: These two wealthy men were having a formal, legal discussion. In many languages, a direct command would be inappropriate in such a situation. Translate this direct command in a way that shows that Boaz was speaking politely to the other relative.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

But if you don't want it, let me know right away
(NLT)

But if you decide not to buy it back, please tell me
so that I will know what to do

4:4f**because there is no one but you to redeem it, and I am next after you."**

- For you are the first one with the right to buy it back, but I am the next person after you with this right."
- I say this, because it is you who has the responsibility to do it. If you do not do it, I will need to take that responsibility instead of you."

because there is no one but you to redeem it:

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason that Boaz wanted to know the man's decision. Boaz wanted to buy back the property himself, but this man had the right to choose first.

and I am next after you: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as I am next after you is literally "I am after you." Boaz was the next relative to have the right to buy back the property.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

for I am the only person to redeem it besides
yourself, and I myself come after you (NJB)

because the right to buy it belongs first to you
and then to me (GNT)

4:4g**"I will redeem it," he replied.**

- The other man said, "I am willing to take this responsibility."
- The closest relative replied, "I will buy it back."

"I will redeem it," he replied: The nearer relative made his decision and gave a positive response. For example:

He replied, "I will redeem it." (NET)

The close relative answered, "I will buy back the land." (NCV)

Notice that the BSB placed he replied after the quote. In some languages, it is more natural to put the quote after the introductory words, as in the examples above.

Ruth 4:5**Section 4:1–12: Boaz assumed responsibility for Ruth**

In this final chapter of the book, Ruth received the reward for her loyalty to Naomi.

Boaz is in focus in the first twelve verses. He met with the other close relative in the presence of many witnesses to discuss the entire situation. The other relative did not want to buy Elimelech's property that Naomi was selling, if the arrangement also meant that he had to marry Ruth. So Boaz said that he would act as the redeemer himself.

In section 4:13–17, Boaz and Ruth were married, and the LORD soon gave them a son. The women in Bethlehem named the son Obed and rejoiced that Naomi now had a "son" to carry on her family line and care for her in her old age. So both Naomi and Ruth were going to be cared for, and the women went from "emptiness" to "fullness."

Section 4:18–22 concludes the book with a genealogy that lists of the family line of Perez, who was a son of Judah and grandson of Jacob (who is also called Israel). The family line is listed from Perez through Obed to King David.

Here are some other examples of section headings for 4:1–12:

Boaz Redeems Ruth (ESV)

Boaz Settles the Matter (NET)

Structure:

Some commentaries divide this section into four scenes: NICOT, Sakenfield, Cornerstone, and Sakenfield. These divide the scenes in at least two different ways.

1. 4:1–2 Introduction: Boaz Convenes a Legal Assembly

2. 4:3–8 Boaz Obtains the Rights of Redemption
3. 4:9–10 Boaz Formalizes the Agreement
4. 4:11–12 Witnessing and Blessing

One commentary divides this section into three scenes. Block (pages 203–204).

1. 4:1–2 setting the stage for the legal drama
2. 4:3–8 report of the legal drama
3. 4:9–12 significance of legal drama

You may divide the paragraphs in these scenes in whatever way best fits the structure of your language.

Paragraph 4:3–6

This paragraph describes the legal discussion between Boaz and the closest relative to Naomi about whether he was willing to redeem the land. It concludes with this man's refusal to do so.

4:5a

Then Boaz said, “On the day you buy the land from Naomi

- But then Boaz said, “At the time you get/buy the land from Naomi,
- Then Boaz said, “When you take over the land from Naomi,

Then Boaz said: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Then introduces a significant and unexpected addition to what Boaz told the other relative.

On the day you buy the land from Naomi: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates literally as On the day means “when” or “whenever.” At the same time that the man bought the land from Naomi, he would also acquire Ruth (4:5b).

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Boaz continued: “On the day you take over the field from Naomi (REB)

Then Boaz explained, “When you buy the land from Naomi (NCV)

4:5b

and also from Ruth the Moabitess, you must also acquire the widow of the deceased

- you will also get Ruth, the Moabite, the wife of the dead man.
- you must also marry Ruth, the woman from Moab. She is Mahlon's widow.

and also from Ruth the Moabitess, you must also acquire: There is a textual problem with this part of

the verse. Scholars suggest two ways to understand the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as from Ruth:

1. It should say “Ruth.” The word “Ruth” is the object of the verb that the BSB translates as you...acquire. When the man acquired the land, he would also acquire Ruth. For example:

you also acquire Ruth the Moabitess (NJB)

you will also assume responsibility for the Moabite Ruth (GW)

you must also marry Ruth the Moabite (NCV) (CEV, ESV, GNT, GW, NABRE, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. It should say “from Ruth.” Ruth as well as Naomi was the seller of the land. For example:

On the day you buy the land from Naomi and from Ruth, you acquire (NIV84) (BSB, KJV, NIV84, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with a majority of versions. Block (page 212), Schipper (pages 165–167)

the widow of the deceased: The Hebrew phrase the BSB translates as the widow of the deceased is literally “the wife of the dead man.” It refers here to Ruth. The dead man is Mahlon, Elimelech's son.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the dead man's wife (NCV)

4:5c

in order to raise up the name of the deceased on his inheritance.”

- You must marry her, so that she may have a son in order to keep the land in the name of the family of her dead husband.”
- Then she may bear an heir for her dead husband and his family's descendants can continue to possess his land/inheritance.”

in order to raise up the name of the deceased on his inheritance: The custom of marrying a dead relative's widow was intended to provide an heir for the dead man. The first male child born to the widow and the redeemer would be considered the heir of the man who had died. The land and the family name of the one who had died would belong to this son. In this

case, people would consider Elimelech and Mahlon to be the ancestors of the first son born to Ruth and the redeemer.

the deceased: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the deceased is singular and primarily refers to Mahlon.

Here is one way to clarify that the name of the dead will be maintained:

This keeps the inheritance in the dead man's name. (GW)

his inheritance: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as inheritance refers here to the land that a man left to his son as an inheritance.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

to maintain the dead man's name on his inheritance (NRSV)

so that the field will stay in the dead man's family (GNT)

Ruth 4:6

Section 4:1–12: Boaz assumed responsibility for Ruth
In this final chapter of the book, Ruth received the reward for her loyalty to Naomi.

Boaz is in focus in the first twelve verses. He met with the other close relative in the presence of many witnesses to discuss the entire situation. The other relative did not want to buy Elimelech's property that Naomi was selling, if the arrangement also meant that he had to marry Ruth. So Boaz said that he would act as the redeemer himself.

In section 4:13–17, Boaz and Ruth were married, and the LORD soon gave them a son. The women in Bethlehem named the son Obed and rejoiced that Naomi now had a "son" to carry on her family line and care for her in her old age. So both Naomi and Ruth were going to be cared for, and the women went from "emptiness" to "fullness."

Section 4:18–22 concludes the book with a genealogy that lists of the family line of Perez, who was a son of Judah and grandson of Jacob (who is also called Israel). The family line is listed from Perez through Obed to King David.

Here are some other examples of section headings for 4:1–12:

Boaz Redeems Ruth (ESV)

Boaz Settles the Matter (NET)

Structure:

Some commentaries divide this section into four scenes: NICOT, Sakenfield, Cornerstone, and Sakenfield. These divide the scenes in at least two different ways.

1. 4:1–2 Introduction: Boaz Convenes a Legal Assembly
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3. 4:9–12 significance of legal drama

You may divide the paragraphs in these scenes in whatever way best fits the structure of your language.

Paragraph 4:3–6

This paragraph describes the legal discussion between Boaz and the closest relative to Naomi about whether he was willing to redeem the land. It concludes with this man's refusal to do so.

4:6a

The kinsman-redeemer replied, "I cannot redeem it myself,

- When he heard this, the nearest relative answered, "But I cannot buy it back,
- Then the one who was responsible to care for the family said, "If that is so, I cannot redeem it,

The kinsman-redeemer replied, "I cannot redeem it myself: This verse introduces the response of the other kinsman-redeemer. The man answered without hesitating.

Here are some other ways to translate his response:

"Then I cannot act," said the next-of-kin (REB)

The man with the right of redemption then said, "I cannot use my right of redemption (NJB)

The man answered, "In that case I will give up my right to buy the field (GNT)

4:6b

or I would jeopardize my own inheritance.

- because then I will harm my own family's inheritance.
- because the result is that I would reduce the inheritance I want to pass on to my own children.

or I would jeopardize my own inheritance: The man's desire was that his own inheritance would belong to his own son or children after he died. If he bought the land from Naomi and married Ruth, he would have to pay for that land. Also, when a son was born to Ruth, that son would be considered a descendant of Elimelech and Mahlon, and would inherit that land. Chisholm (pages 675–676), UBS (page 67).

jeopardize: He would jeopardize his own inheritance, because his own sons would have to share it with Ruth's son. They would thus have a smaller share.

inheritance: This refers to the land, buildings, and possessions the man hoped to leave to his own sons when he died.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

without damaging my own inheritance (NRSV)

If I did, I might harm what I can pass on to my own sons. (NCV)

4:6c

Take my right of redemption, because I cannot redeem it."

- It will be good if you buy it yourself. I am not able to do it."
- You may buy it back yourself, because I am not willing to do it."

Take my right of redemption: The man gave the right of redemption to Boaz. In many languages, it would not be polite for a man to give a command in this situation.

Here are some other ways to translate the command:

You may take over my responsibility/right to redeem it.

You are free/welcome to buy it back yourself.

because I cannot redeem it: The man felt that he was not able to redeem Elimelech's property without risking some loss to his own wealth, as explained above. He repeated this at the end of his speech to Boaz for emphasis.

Ruth 4:7

Section 4:1–12: Boaz assumed responsibility for Ruth

In this final chapter of the book, Ruth received the reward for her loyalty to Naomi.

Boaz is in focus in the first twelve verses. He met with the other close relative in the presence of many witnesses to discuss the entire situation. The other relative did not want to buy Elimelech's property that Naomi was selling, if the arrangement also meant that he had to marry Ruth. So Boaz said that he would act as the redeemer himself.

In section 4:13–17, Boaz and Ruth were married, and the LORD soon gave them a son. The women in Bethlehem named the son Obed and rejoiced that Naomi now had a "son" to carry on her family line and care for her in her old age. So both Naomi and Ruth were going to be cared for, and the women went from "emptiness" to "fullness."

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You may divide the paragraphs in these scenes in whatever way best fits the structure of your language.

Paragraph 4:7–8

This paragraph describes the sandal ceremony that finalized the redemption of property.

4:7

This verse is background material. Use whatever way is appropriate in your language to indicate that this is background material and not part of the main story.

Apparently, at the time that the author wrote this story, the people of Israel were no longer practicing the same customs for legal matters, so he needed to explain it.

4:7a**Now in former times in Israel,**

- ¶ (In the past in Israel,
- ¶ In Israel long ago,

Now: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Now introduces background information about an old custom. It is not a time word here.

in former times in Israel: This phrase refers to a period of time in the past, long before the author wrote this book. Campbell (page 147) points out that the time period indicated by the Hebrew words can refer to anything from less than a generation to 700 years, but that here the shorter time period is more likely. NICOT (pages 247–249) suggests that “that the author wrote at some temporal distance from the events of his story.”

Here are some other ways to translate it:

in former times, it was the custom in Israel (NJB)

Long ago in Israel (NCV)

(This is the way it used to be in Israel (GW)

4:7b**concerning the redemption or exchange of property, to make any matter legally binding**

- people used to finalize/complete their purchase and exchange of items in this way:
- there was a custom to show that people had completed buying or exchanging possessions.

concerning the redemption or exchange of property, to make any matter legally binding: The custom mentioned in 4:7c was followed:

1. when there was a redemption of property or possessions, and
2. when there was some exchange of property or other possessions.

redemption: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as redemption is the noun that refers to the responsibility of purchasing the land of a poor relative.

exchange: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as exchange refers to a transfer or exchange.

of property: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as of property is literally “of all things.” It refers to any object or possession, not just to land.

to make any matter legally binding: The Hebrew phrase to make any matter legally binding means “to confirm,” “to establish,” or “to show that they had agreed.”

Here are other ways to translate this verse part:

to confirm a transaction in matters of redemption or inheritance (NJB)

when people traded or bought back something (NCV)

to settle a sale or an exchange of property (GNT)

4:7c**a man would remove his sandal and give it to the other party,**

- one man took off his sandal and handed it to the other man.
- A man would take off his sandal and give it to the other man to show that the business action was complete.

a man would remove his sandal and give it to the other party:

The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as a man...the other party refers to the two people involved in the matter. Probably only men took part in such legal transactions, so it is acceptable to use masculine words in your translation here.

one party took off his sandal and give it to the other (NIV)

for the seller to take off his sandal and give it to the buyer (GNT)

remove his sandal: The sandal referred to here was most likely the common footwear of that time. It probably had a hard leather sole, with straps or strips of leather crossing over the top of the foot. If you do not have a word meaning sandal in your language, there are at least two options for translating this term:

- Use a general word that refers to footwear.
- Use a specific word in your language that refers to something similar to a sandal. For example:

thong/flip-flop

4:7d

and this was a confirmation in Israel.

- This was the way men publicly confirmed business exchanges in Israel.)
- This was what a man used to do in Israel to show everyone that he agreed to sell a valuable property to someone else.

and this was a confirmation in Israel: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as a confirmation occurs in only three places. NICOT (pages 250–252) lists Ruth 4:7d, Isaiah 8:16, 20. It probably refers to the way that people in Israel confirmed their agreements at that time. For example:

This was the way a contract was publicly approved in Israel. (GW)

In this way the Israelites showed that the matter was settled. (GNT)

Ruth 4:8

Section 4:1–12: Boaz assumed responsibility for Ruth

In this final chapter of the book, Ruth received the reward for her loyalty to Naomi.

Boaz is in focus in the first twelve verses. He met with the other close relative in the presence of many witnesses to discuss the entire situation. The other relative did not want to buy Elimelech's property that Naomi was selling, if the arrangement also meant that he had to marry Ruth. So Boaz said that he would act as the redeemer himself.

In section 4:13–17, Boaz and Ruth were married, and the LORD soon gave them a son. The women in Bethlehem named the son Obed and rejoiced that Naomi now had a “son” to carry on her family line and care for her in her old age. So both Naomi and Ruth were going to be cared for, and the women went from “emptiness” to “fullness.”

Section 4:18–22 concludes the book with a genealogy that lists of the family line of Perez, who was a son of Judah and grandson of Jacob (who is also called Israel). The family line is listed from Perez through Obed to King David.

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You may divide the paragraphs in these scenes in whatever way best fits the structure of your language.

Paragraph 4:7–8

This paragraph describes the sandal ceremony that finalized the redemption of property.

4:8

After the author explained the custom in 4:7, he continued the main story in 4:8.

4:8a

So the kinsman-redeemer removed his sandal

- Therefore, the closer relative pulled off his sandal
- So the closer relative took off his own sandal

So: This word introduces the result of the custom. You can also translate it as “Then.”

the kinsman-redeemer removed his sandal: There is a textual difference here:

1. The Hebrew text ends with the word sandal: For example:

he took off his sandal (NRSV) (BSB, ESV, GW, KJV, NABRE, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV)

1. The Greek translation (LXX/Septuagint) has the additional words “and gave it to Boaz.” For example:

he took off one of his sandals and handed it to Boaz (CEV)

he drew off his sandal and handed it over (REB)
(CEV, GNT, REB)

The Notes will follow interpretation (1). The words “and handed it to Boaz” were not in the original text of Ruth but were added later. However, 4:7c specifies that one man handed the sandal to the other. So if it is clearer in your language to complete the action, you may follow one of the versions listed under interpretation (2).UBS (page 69).

4:8b

and said to Boaz, “Buy it for yourself.”

- and said to Boaz, “You should buy it for yourself.”
- and told Boaz to buy it himself.

Here are some other ways to introduce this verse:

So when the man said to Boaz (GNT)

Then the man said...

and said to Boaz, “Buy it for yourself.”: The command Buy it for yourself has almost the same meaning as “Take my right of redemption” in 4:6c. But here the more general word Buy is used.

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Buy is a command. However, the other redeemer was giving Boaz permission to buy it rather than saying that he must buy it. So in many languages, it may be better to use a more polite expression. For example:

You may buy it yourself.

Ruth 4:9

Section 4:1–12: Boaz assumed responsibility for Ruth

In this final chapter of the book, Ruth received the reward for her loyalty to Naomi.

Boaz is in focus in the first twelve verses. He met with the other close relative in the presence of many witnesses to discuss the entire situation. The other relative did not want to buy Elimelech’s property that Naomi was selling, if the arrangement also meant that he had to marry Ruth. So Boaz said that he would act as the redeemer himself.

In section 4:13–17, Boaz and Ruth were married, and the LORD soon gave them a son. The women in Bethlehem named the son Obed and rejoiced that Naomi now had a “son” to carry on her family line and care for her in her old age. So both Naomi and Ruth were going to be

cared for, and the women went from “emptiness” to “fullness.”

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You may divide the paragraphs in these scenes in whatever way best fits the structure of your language.

Paragraph 4:9–10

This paragraph describes how Boaz formalized the agreement to acquire the land and also Ruth in front of the elders and the other witnesses.

The author probably discussed the land agreement first, because Boaz would not be able to marry Ruth unless he first acquired the land. Block (pages 221–223).

4:9a

At this, Boaz said to the elders and all the people,

- ¶ Then Boaz said to the town leaders and to all the people gathered there,
- ¶ Then Boaz said to the elders and to the other people who were there,

At this, Boaz said to the elders and all the people:

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as At this introduces what Boaz said after the other relative said he would not redeem the land.

to the elders and all the people: Boaz had selected ten elders to be official witnesses. A large crowd may have come together before the discussion was finished, and Boaz spoke to them all.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Then Boaz said to the leaders and all the others there (GNT)

Then Boaz said to the elders and to the crowd standing around (NLT)

4:9b

“You are witnesses today that I am buying from Naomi all that belonged to Elimelech, Chilion, and Mahlon.”

- “Today you are witnesses that I have decided to buy from Naomi all the possessions that belonged to Elimelech, Kilion, and Mahlon.
- “Today, you are the ones who are observing that I will certainly buy from Naomi everything that belonged to Elimelech, Kilion, and Mahlon.

You are witnesses today: This phrase and the response of the people in 4:11b were Hebrew phrases that were used when people officially completed business agreements that they had conducted in the presence of witnesses. Block (pages 221–223).

witnesses: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as witnesses refers to people who have seen or heard some event and can tell others what has happened.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

“You are all witnesses today (GNT)

“You are witnesses that today (NLT)

If your language does not have a word for witnesses, here is another way to translate it:

“You are the ones who can tell others what you saw.

all that belonged to Elimelech, Chilion, and Mahlon: The Hebrew text literally says, “all that is to Elimelech, and all that is to Kilion and Mahlon.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

that I have bought from Naomi everything that belonged to Elimelech and to his sons Chilion and Mahlon (GNT)

I am buying from Naomi everything that belonged to Elimelech and Kilion and Mahlon. (NCV)

Ruth 4:10

Section 4:1–12: Boaz assumed responsibility for Ruth

In this final chapter of the book, Ruth received the reward for her loyalty to Naomi.

Boaz is in focus in the first twelve verses. He met with the other close relative in the presence of many witnesses to discuss the entire situation. The other relative did not want to buy Elimelech’s property that Naomi was selling, if the arrangement also meant that he had to marry Ruth. So Boaz said that he would act as the redeemer himself.

In section 4:13–17, Boaz and Ruth were married, and the LORD soon gave them a son. The women in Bethlehem named the son Obed and rejoiced that Naomi now had a “son” to carry on her family line and care for her in her old age. So both Naomi and Ruth were going to be cared for, and the women went from “emptiness” to “fullness.”

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You may divide the paragraphs in these scenes in whatever way best fits the structure of your language.

Paragraph 4:9–10

This paragraph describes how Boaz formalized the agreement to acquire the land and also Ruth in front of the elders and the other witnesses.

The author probably discussed the land agreement first, because Boaz would not be able to marry Ruth unless he first acquired the land. Block (pages 221–223).

4:10a

Moreover, I have acquired Ruth the Moabitess, Mahlon's widow, as my wife,

- Also, I am obtaining Ruth as my wife. She is the woman from Moab who is Mahlon's widow.
- And also regarding Ruth from Moab, who used to be Mahlon's wife, I take her to be my own wife.

Moreover, I have acquired Ruth the Moabitess, Mahlon's widow, as my wife: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as acquired is the same word that is translated “buy” or “bought” in other parts of this chapter. It can also mean “have gotten” or “have obtained.”

Boaz was taking Ruth, Mahlon's widow, as his wife. This was an important part of the responsibility of the “redeemer.” This is not the same as giving a payment to the parents of the bride, called a “bride-price,” which is practiced in many cultures. See how you translated “acquire” in 4:5b.

4:10b

to raise up the name of the deceased through his inheritance,

- I will marry her so that Mahlon's name will be remembered with this property.
- I will marry her to keep the property in the family of Mahlon.

In 4:10b and 4:10c, Boaz stated his reasons for marrying Ruth. Here he gave a positive reason. He said that if a son would be born to him and Ruth, that son would be the heir to the property of Mahlon and would carry on Mahlon's family name.

to raise up: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as to raise up here means “establish” or “cause to continue.” If an heir would be born, the property would continue to be known as the property of the family line of Elimelech and Mahlon. Chisholm (page 677).

the name of the deceased: This probably refers primarily to Mahlon. But Boaz was also talking about Elimelech who originally owned the property (see the GNT and NCV quoted in 4:9b). He did not distinguish between the name and property of the father Elimelech and the son Mahlon. But if you must be specific, it is recommended that you refer to Mahlon, as in 4:5c. Schipper (page 170), EBC (page 1342).

through his inheritance: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as inheritance refers to the plot of land that Elimelech owned and that his sons would have inherited after he died.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

This way she can have a son to carry on the family name of her dead husband and to inherit the family property here in his hometown. (NLT)

I am doing this so her dead husband's property will stay in his name and his name will not be separated from his family and his hometown. (NCV)

4:10c

so that his name will not disappear from among his brothers or from the gate of his home.

- I will marry Ruth so that Mahlon's name will not be forgotten among his family/descendants or disappear from the history of Bethlehem.
- Then his family/descendants will continue to remember Mahlon and the town's elders will repeat his name in the stories of his people.

Having given a positive reason in 4:10b for him to marry Ruth, Boaz here gave a negative reason. He said that if a son would be born to him and Ruth, people would not forget that Elimelech's and Mahlon's family/lineage continued to exist.

so that his name will not disappear: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as disappear is literally “be cut off.” If there was no heir and a different family bought Elimelech's family land, then the name of Mahlon, and that of Elimelech and Chilion as well, would no longer be associated with this land. Their names would eventually be forgotten.

from among his brothers or from the gate of his home: Their names would be forgotten among his brothers in the family line and from the gate of his home in the town history. First, if there was no heir, there would be no descendants or relatives to talk about them. Secondly, if the property was not bought

back and was used by some other family and their descendants, the names of Mahlon and Elimelech eventually would not be mentioned in relation to the property, even from the gate of his home.

his brothers: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as his brothers means Mahlon's relatives and descendants.

or from the gate of his home: This phrase is an idiom that refers to a family's history in relation to their property, which is equivalent to town records. Here is another possible translation:

or from the town records

4:10d

You are witnesses today.”

- Today, you are witnesses.”
- Today you have seen this and will be able to testify about it.”

You are witnesses today: This phrase was used to complete legal or commercial business. See the notes on 4:9b.

witnesses: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as witnesses is emphasized by being placed first in the phrase in the Hebrew text.

General Comment on 4:10a–d

Since 4:10 is very long, it may be better to break it into several shorter sentences. See the Display for examples.

Ruth 4:11

Section 4:1–12: Boaz assumed responsibility for Ruth

In this final chapter of the book, Ruth received the reward for her loyalty to Naomi.

Boaz is in focus in the first twelve verses. He met with the other close relative in the presence of many witnesses to discuss the entire situation. The other relative did not want to buy Elimelech's property that Naomi was selling, if the arrangement also meant that he had to marry Ruth. So Boaz said that he would act as the redeemer himself.

In section 4:13–17, Boaz and Ruth were married, and the LORD soon gave them a son. The women in Bethlehem named the son Obed and rejoiced that Naomi now had a “son” to carry on her family line and care for her in her old age. So both Naomi and Ruth were going to be cared for, and the women went from “emptiness” to “fullness.”

Section 4:18–22 concludes the book with a genealogy that lists of the family line of Perez, who was a son of Judah and grandson of Jacob (who is also called Israel). The family line is listed from Perez through Obed to King David.

Here are some other examples of section headings for 4:1–12:

Boaz Redeems Ruth (ESV)

Boaz Settles the Matter (NET)

Structure:

Some commentaries divide this section into four scenes: NICOT, Sakenfield, Cornerstone, and Sakenfield. These divide the scenes in at least two different ways.

1. 4:1–2 Introduction: Boaz Convenes a Legal Assembly
2. 4:3–8 Boaz Obtains the Rights of Redemption
3. 4:9–10 Boaz Formalizes the Agreement
4. 4:11–12 Witnessing and Blessing

One commentary divides this section into three scenes. Block (pages 203–204).

1. 4:1–2 setting the stage for the legal drama
2. 4:3–8 report of the legal drama
3. 4:9–12 significance of legal drama

You may divide the paragraphs in these scenes in whatever way best fits the structure of your language.

Paragraph 4:11–12

This paragraph describes the blessing that was pronounced on Boaz, including wealth and a good reputation. It also describes the blessing that was given to Ruth that she would bear many children.

4:11a

“We are witnesses,”

- ¶ “Yes, we are witnesses!”
- ¶ “We have seen this and we will testify to it.”

“We are witnesses,”: The repetition of “We/You are witnesses in 4:9b, 4:10d, and 4:11a highlights the role of the witnesses. Block (pages 221–223).

4:11b

said the elders and all the people at the gate.

- said the town leaders and all the people who were listening/observing in the gate area.
- said the leading men of the town and the other people near the gate/meeting area.

said the elders and all the people at the gate: These people were the leading men of the town and the

other people there at the town meeting place. See how you translated these two terms in 4:9a.

4:11c

“May the LORD make the woman entering your home like Rachel and Leah,

- May Yahweh cause this woman you are bringing into your home as your wife to bear children, just as he did for Rachel and Leah,
- We pray that Yahweh will bless the woman who is becoming your wife. We pray that he will help her to have many children and descendants, as Rachel and Leah did.

May the LORD make the woman entering your home: This is a short prayer or blessing.

the woman: This refers to Ruth. You may refer to her by name if calling her the woman would be impolite or derogatory in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

May the Lord make your wife (GNT)

May the LORD cause your wife Ruth

entering your home: Here the people are speaking to Boaz. The pronoun translated “you” and your in 4:11c, 4:12a, and 4:12b are masculine singular in the Hebrew text.

Ruth was entering Boaz’s home, or into his “family” or “household,” as his wife. In some languages, it may be helpful to include this implied information. For example:

whom you are bringing into your home as your wife

like Rachel and Leah: These were the two wives of Jacob, a grandson of Abraham. If your readers do not know these names, you may want to give this information in a footnote. For example:

The people prayed that the LORD would bless Ruth by giving her children, who would themselves have many descendants. This is what the LORD had done for Rachel and Leah in Genesis chapters 29–30.

4:11d

who together built up the house of Israel.

- who together made the people of Israel strong and numerous.
- The two of them had many children and descendants, who became the nation of Israel.

who together built up the house of Israel: The many sons of Rachel and Leah were the founders of the nation of Israel. Rachel and Leah and their two servant girls gave birth to twelve sons. The twelve sons each became the head of a tribe within the descendants of Israel.

Although Zilpah and Bilhah, the women servants of Rachel and Leah, gave birth to four of the sons, all the sons were officially considered to be the children of Rachel and Leah.

built up: This means that they made Israel strong and numerous by having many descendants.

the house of Israel: Jacob was also known as Israel. There are two ways to interpret it here:

1. It refers to the nation or people of Israel who had descended from Jacob. For example:

from whom all the nation of Israel descended (NLT)

both of whom built our family of Israel (GW) (GW, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NLT)

1. It refers to the children and descendants of Jacob himself. For example:

like Rachel and Leah, who bore many children to Jacob (GNT) (CEV, GNT)

The versions that translate the Hebrew literally as “the house/family of Israel” are ambiguous.

(BSB, ESV, KJV, NABRE, NASB, NET, NIV, NRSV, REB).

Only one commentary clearly supports interpretation (2). You may follow any of the interpretations in your language.

house: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as house here refers a person’s descendants.

4:11e

May you be prosperous in Ephrathah and famous in Bethlehem.

- May you^(sing) greatly prosper in Ephrathah. May you^(sing) be well known in Bethlehem.
- We pray that Yahweh will make you^(sing) wealthy and famous in our town Ephrathah, that is, Bethlehem.

May you be prosperous in Ephrathah and famous in Bethlehem: Before the Notes discuss the interpretation of the blessings given here, it will be helpful to notice that this verse part has two parallel lines:

May you be prosperous **in Ephrathah**

and be famous **in Bethlehem**

in Ephrathah...in Bethlehem: Ephrathah is probably the name of a clan that lived in Bethlehem. This clan name was an old name for Bethlehem. Here it is a synonym for Bethlehem. In your translation, you may need to indicate that Bethlehem and Ephrathah are the same place.

There are four ways to interpret the Hebrew idiom that the BSB translates as “May you be prosperous”:

1. It refers to an increase in money and possessions. For example:

May you become rich... (GNT) (BSB, CEV, GNT, NABRE, NASB, NET, NJPS, NLT, RSV)

1. It refers to an increase in reputation and status. For example:

May you become powerful... (NCV) (NCV, NIV, NJB, NLT96)

1. It refers to good character. For example:

So show your strength of character... (GW) (ESV, GW, KJV, REB)

It refers to an increase in children. For example:

May you produce children (NRSV) (NRSV)Sakenfield (pages 76–78) says that the NRSV translation is overly influenced by the many references to bearing children, and that the phrase here has a much broader meaning. Cornerstone (page 575) supports this interpretation as “an affirmation of the stated intent of the new couple’s union,” which is fulfilled in the next verse.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The people prayed that as a result of his marriage, Boaz would prosper and grow rich. However, interpretation (2) is supported by the parallelism. UBS (pages 71–73), KD (page 359). EBC (page 1342) says that the

union of Boaz and Ruth eventually gain fame for Bethlehem through the future King David and the Messiah. Interpretation (3) is supported by the Hebrew usage elsewhere. Schipper (pages 170–171) mentions “mighty man of worth” (2:1) and “woman of worth” (3:1).

and famous in Bethlehem: The Hebrew idiom that the BSB translates as famous is literally “call a name.” The people wanted Boaz to get a well-known name, or gain a good reputation, as a result of the many children and descendants they hoped he would have.

Ruth 4:12

Section 4:1–12: Boaz assumed responsibility for Ruth

In this final chapter of the book, Ruth received the reward for her loyalty to Naomi.

Boaz is in focus in the first twelve verses. He met with the other close relative in the presence of many witnesses to discuss the entire situation. The other relative did not want to buy Elimelech’s property that Naomi was selling, if the arrangement also meant that he had to marry Ruth. So Boaz said that he would act as the redeemer himself.

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3. 4:9–12 significance of legal drama

You may divide the paragraphs in these scenes in whatever way best fits the structure of your language.

Paragraph 4:11–12

This paragraph describes the blessing that was pronounced on Boaz, including wealth and a good reputation. It also describes the blessing that was given to Ruth that she would bear many children.

4:12a

And may your house become like the house of Perez, whom Tamar bore to Judah,

- May your^(sing) clan become large like the clan of Perez, whom Tamar gave birth to as a son of Judah,
- And we pray that your^(sing) descendants will become numerous like the descendants of Perez, the son of Judah and Tamar your ancestors

In 4:11c the people said that they hoped that Ruth would have many descendants. Here they were saying the same thing about Boaz.

And may your house become like the house of Perez:

Perez was one of Judah's sons, a grandson of Jacob and one of the ancestors of Boaz (4:18–21). Although he was not the first-born, his family became more numerous and more important than those of his brothers. In the family record in Genesis 46:12, Perez is the only son of Judah whose sons are recorded by name.

house: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as house refers here to all the descendants of Boaz, not just those who live in his house.

whom Tamar bore to Judah: Tamar was a foreigner who became an important person in Israelite history because she had a baby with Judah, one of the sons of Jacob. Because Ruth was also a foreigner, this may have been the reason that the people compared Ruth with Tamar. See Genesis chapter 38 for the story of Tamar. You may want to add a footnote that gives this reference.

4:12b

because of the offspring the LORD will give you by this young woman."

- from the descendants that Yahweh causes you^(sing) to have through this young woman."
- and that Yahweh gives you and this young woman many children and grandchildren."

because of the offspring: This refers to the children Boaz and Ruth would have and to their future descendants.

the LORD will give you: The people recognized that it is the LORD who enables a woman to bear children. Ruth had not yet had a child, even though she had been married to Mahlon. So the people prayed that the LORD would give Ruth children for Boaz.

by this young woman: Ruth may have married Mahlon at quite a young age, so she still could have been considered young. This may have been true especially when compared with Boaz, who was probably somewhat older than she was. It may also imply that Ruth was still young enough to bear children.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

from the descendant whom the Lord will give you
from this young woman (GW)

May the children that the Lord will give you by
this young woman (GNT)

may the Lord give you many children through
Ruth (NCV)

Ruth 4:13

Section 4:13–17: Boaz and Ruth married and had a son

This section tells us about Boaz marrying Ruth and the birth of their son Obed. After Obed was born, the women of the town spoke encouraging words to Naomi.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ruth gave birth to Naomi's grandson

Boaz married Ruth and they had a son

4:13a

So Boaz took Ruth, and she became his wife.

- ¶ So Boaz took Ruth to/into his home, and she became his wife.
- ¶ After this, Boaz and Ruth got married.

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So continues the story after the quotation in the previous paragraph. It also indicates the result of the decision that the elders and witnesses had made at the town gate.

Boaz took Ruth, and she became his wife: The Hebrew clauses that the BSB translates as Boaz took Ruth, and she became his wife mean that Boaz married Ruth. The BSB, following the Hebrew, uses two phrases to say this. In some languages, it may be better to combine these ideas into one clause and say that he married her.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

Boaz and Ruth married one another

Boaz married Ruth (CEV)

Then Boaz took Ruth home, and she became his wife. (GW)

took: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as took means that Boaz took Ruth to his house. This was the custom of the Israelite people. In cultures where such a custom is unknown, the phrase may sound as if Boaz took Ruth without her consent. Because of this, it may be best to use a general word for “married.” See the other ways of translating this word listed above.

4:13b

And when he had relations with her, the LORD enabled her to conceive, and she gave birth to a son.

- When he had sexual relations with her, Yahweh made it possible for her to become pregnant, and she bore a son.
- Then he slept with her, and Yahweh helped her and she became pregnant.

And when he had relations with her: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as when he had relations with her means that Boaz and Ruth had sexual relations. The Hebrew is more literally “And he went in to her.” The BSB translation is a euphemism. It is a way of politely saying that Boaz and Ruth had sexual relations. In some cultures, it may be acceptable to translate this without a euphemism. The phrase you choose should be one that it is acceptable to read or say in a church meeting or at any other public occasion.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

when he slept with her (NLT)

then they lay down together

and had sexual relations with her (NET)

Some versions (CEV, GNT) leave this clause implied, because the meaning is clear from the following context. For example:

and the Lord blessed her with a son (CEV)

the LORD enabled her to conceive: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as the LORD enabled her to conceive means that the LORD made it possible for Ruth to become pregnant. You need to be careful how you translate this. If you say, “The LORD caused her to become pregnant,” it could give a wrong meaning. The author meant that the LORD worked to allow Ruth to conceive.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

The LORD blessed her and she became pregnant

The Lord let her become pregnant (NCV)

The LORD helped her and she became pregnant

and she gave birth to a son: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as she gave birth to a son means that Ruth gave birth to a male child.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and she gave birth to a male child

and she bore a son (NRSV)

Ruth 4:14

Section 4:13–17: Boaz and Ruth married and had a son

This section tells us about Boaz marrying Ruth and the birth of their son Obed. After Obed was born, the women of the town spoke encouraging words to Naomi.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ruth gave birth to Naomi’s grandson

Boaz married Ruth and they had a son

4:14a

Then the women said to Naomi,

- The women of the town said to Naomi.

- After the baby was born, the local women told Naomi,

Then: his verse happened after Ruth's baby was born.

the women said to Naomi: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the women refers to the women who lived in Bethlehem.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The village women said to Naomi (NET)

Then the women of the town said to Naomi (NLT)

Then the women said to Naomi (NRSV)

4:14b

“Blessed be the LORD,

- “Praise Yahweh.
- “May everyone give praise to Yahweh.
- “We should praise the name of Yahweh.

Blessed be the LORD: The women meant that the LORD deserved to have people praise him. They themselves praised the LORD, and they encouraged Naomi and everyone else to praise the LORD for what he had done for Naomi and her dead husband's family.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

May the Lord be praised (NET)

We should praise the LORD

Praise the Lord! (CEV)

4:14c

who has not left you this day without a kinsman-redeemer.

- Today, by giving you^(sing) this grandson, Yahweh has provided you with a close relative to care for you.
- Now Yahweh has given you this grandson.. He will take care of you when you^(sing) are old.

who has not left you this day without: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as who has not left you this day without means that the LORD has given a kinsman-redeemer to Naomi. In many languages, it may be best to translate this as a positive statement rather than use a double negative (“not left... without”).

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

has provided you with

this day: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as this day means “today” or “now.” Perhaps the women were speaking on the very day that Ruth gave birth to a son.

a kinsman-redeemer: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as kinsman-redeemer refers to a close male relative who is responsible for helping or taking care of other relatives. The women were talking about the newborn baby, not Boaz. This is made clear in 4:15c. The women expected that when the boy grew up, he would provide for his grandmother in her old age.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Today he has given you a grandson to care of you. (CEV)

He has now provided you with a grandson who will care for you when you are old.

4:14d

May his name become famous in Israel.

- May this grandson become well known in all of Israel.
- May everyone in the land of Israel hear/know about the name of this boy.

May his name become famous: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as May his name become famous means that the women wanted the baby to be well-known. In 4:11e, all the people had said that they desired that Boaz would be “famous.” In some languages, the same translation can be used in both verses.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

May the boy become well-known

We pray that the boy will grow up to be famous (CEV)

in Israel: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as in Israel means that they wanted him to be famous throughout the land of Israel and not just in Bethlehem.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

throughout Israel (NIV)

everywhere in Israel (CEV)

Ruth 4:15

Section 4:13–17: Boaz and Ruth married and had a son

This section tells us about Boaz marrying Ruth and the birth of their son Obed. After Obed was born, the women of the town spoke encouraging words to Naomi.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ruth gave birth to Naomi's grandson

Boaz married Ruth and they had a son

4:15a

He will renew your life

- He will make you^(sing) feel as if you have new life/strength.
- He will encourage/comfort you

He will renew your life: The women used this Hebrew idiom to express their hope that Naomi's grandson would give her new joy and delight in life. Now Naomi could look forward to seeing the boy grow up and have children of his own so that her husband's family line would not end.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The child will be a comfort to you (NJB)

Because of him, you^(sing) will feel as if you have new life in you.

He will encourage you (NET)

4:15a-c

(combined/reordered)

- "Your daughter-in-law loves you very much. If you had had seven sons, your love for your daughter-in-law would be more than your love for them. And now she has given birth to a baby boy. He will make sure that you have what you need and will take care of you when you become old."

4:15b

and sustain you in your old age.

- He will provide for you^(sing) in your older years.
- and take care of you as you grow old.

and sustain you in your old age: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as sustain means that Naomi's grandson would "provide for" her as she grew old. He would probably provide Naomi with food, clothing, and a place to live when she would be too old to take care of herself.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and care for you in your old age (NLT)

He'll take care of you when you are old (NIRV)

4:15c

For your daughter-in-law, who loves you and is better to you than seven sons, has given him birth."

- You^(sing) will be blessed in these ways, because your daughter-in-law, who loves you, is the one who bore him. She is more valuable to you than seven sons!"
- Your^(sing) daughter-in-law loves you, and has done more for you than seven sons. And now she has given you a grandson (GNT)

For your daughter-in-law, who loves you...has given him birth:

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces the reason why the women expected that the baby would bring Naomi such joy. The reason was that he was the child of her daughter-in-law, Ruth. Since Ruth loved Naomi very much, the women were sure that her son would love her too.

and is better to you than seven sons: The general attitude of the people of Israel was that sons were more valuable or more important than daughters were. The Israelites thought that a family that had seven sons was an ideal family. When the women said that Ruth was more valuable to Naomi than seven sons, they were saying that Ruth was a very special daughter-in-law.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

because he is the son of your daughter-in-law. And she loves you more than seven sons of your own would love you. (CEV)

She helps you^(sing) more than seven sons would help you

General Comment on 4:15a-c

Some languages require that the reason be stated before the result. In 4:15 this would mean that the

verse would begin with the clauses in 4:15c. This would then be followed by 4:15a-b. For example:

Your daughter-in-law loves you, and has done more for you than seven sons. And now she has given you a grandson, who will bring new life to you and give you security in your old age. (GNT)

See 4:15a-c (combined/reordered) in the Display for another example.

Ruth 4:16

Section 4:13–17: Boaz and Ruth married and had a son

This section tells us about Boaz marrying Ruth and the birth of their son Obed. After Obed was born, the women of the town spoke encouraging words to Naomi.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ruth gave birth to Naomi's grandson

Boaz married Ruth and they had a son

4:16a

And Naomi took the child, placed him on her lap,

- Then Naomi took the baby and held him in her arms.
- After that, Naomi took the baby boy and held him close to her.

And Naomi took the child, placed him on her lap:

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as took is a general word that here means “took in her arms.”

on her lap: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as lap indicates a place on the body where one would hold an infant. Use a phrase in your language that means that Naomi was sitting and holding the baby.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Then Naomi took the child and laid him on her lap (ESV)

Naomi took the boy, held him in her arms (NCV)

Naomi took the baby and cuddled him to her breast (NLT)

Naomi took the child, held him close (GNT)

4:16b

and became a nurse to him.

- She also looked after him.
- She also helped to care for him as he grew up.

and became a nurse to him: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as became a nurse to him means that Naomi “took care of” or “looked after” the baby. This is another way of saying that Naomi watched over the boy and helped feed and protect him. This does not mean that Naomi gave breast milk to the baby or that she took care of him only when he was ill.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and she became his foster-mother (REB)

and she cared for him as if he were her own (NLT)

Ruth 4:17

Section 4:13–17: Boaz and Ruth married and had a son

This section tells us about Boaz marrying Ruth and the birth of their son Obed. After Obed was born, the women of the town spoke encouraging words to Naomi.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Ruth gave birth to Naomi's grandson

Boaz married Ruth and they had a son

4:17a

The neighbor women said,

- The women living there in Bethlehem gave him a name, and said,
- The women living near Naomi said,

The neighbor women: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as The neighbor women is a word that literally means “female inhabitants.” It refers to the women who lived in Bethlehem.

said: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as said is literally “called him a name, saying....” The words “they called him a name” is a Hebrew idiom that means “they named him” or “they gave him a name.” The Hebrew text of 4:17c repeats the phrase “they called him a name.” For example:

And the women of the neighborhood gave him a name, saying... (RSV)

If repeating the phrase in 4:17a and 4:17c would be unnatural in your language, you may follow the BSB and omit it in 4:17a.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The neighbor women named him, saying, (NET)

and the women neighbors gave him a name, saying, (NJPS)

The women living there said, (NIRV)

4:17b

“A son has been born to Naomi,”

- “Now Naomi has a son/grandson!”
- “Naomi now has a male child who will be like a son to her.”

A son has been born to Naomi: The women meant that Naomi would help Ruth take care of the baby. Also, they thought about this child becoming a replacement for Naomi’s own sons. He would be the heir of the family property.

In Hebrew, as in many other languages, the word for “son” can also refer to a grandson. In other languages, it would be confusing, or impossible, to call Ruth’s baby Naomi’s son. In these languages, it may be necessary to use a word meaning “grandson.” Or you could use a simile and say, “The baby is like a son to Naomi.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

A grandson has been born to Naomi

Ruth has given birth to a baby boy. He will be like a son to Naomi

4:17c

and they named him Obed.

- They named the baby Obed.
- So they gave him the name Obed. (GW)

and they named him Obed: The women gave the baby a name that means “servant.”

Here is another way to translate this clause:

They gave the baby the name Obed.

4:17d

He became the father of Jesse, the father of David.

- Obed became the father of Jesse and the grandfather of David. (NLT)
- Later Obed became the father of Jesse. Jesse was the father of King David.

He became the father of Jesse, the father of David:

In the lists of names of family descendants (as in the list given at the end of this story), father of can sometimes mean “ancestor of.” In this verse, however, father does refer to the man’s immediate parent.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

Obed was the father of Jesse, and Jesse was the father of David. (NCV)

He became the father of Jesse and the grandfather of David. (NLT)

When Obed grew up he had a son named Jesse, who later became the father of King David. (CEV)

Ruth 4:18

Section 4:18–22: A list of David’s ancestors

This section contains a list of the family line from Perez through Obed to King David. Five names represent all the generations from Perez, the son of Judah, to Nahshon, who lived at the time of Moses, about four hundred years after Perez. The names of the next five generations represent all the generations from Nahshon to David, who lived about 450 years later. Clearly, many names have been left out of the list.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ancestors of David

Obed in the Genealogy of David (NET)

The list of the ancestors of King David

The names in this listing agree with the lists in 1 Chronicles chapter 2, Matthew chapter 1, and Luke chapter 3. If you have already translated any of these books, refer to the way you transliterated the names there.

4:18a

Now these are the generations of Perez:

- ¶ These are the descendants of Perez.
- ¶ Perez was the ancestor of many people.

4:18b**Perez was the father of Hezron,**

- Perez fathered Hezron. (ESV)
- Hezron was the son of Perez.

4:18

Now these are the generations of Perez: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the generations refers to a list of descendants.

These are the descendants of Perez: (NET)

Here is a list of the descendants of Perez: (T4T)

The family line here starts with Perez. Perez was the son of Judah. His mother was Tamar. See the note at 4:12b. It might be helpful for you to provide a footnote saying that Perez was a son of Judah and a great-grandson of Abraham.

Perez was the father of Hezron: The Hebrew verb used in each occurrence in this list means “father a child.” So the Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as Perez was the father of Hezron is literally “Perez fathered Hezron.” Translate this verse and the following verses into your language in whatever manner the people use to recite the list of their family’s ancestors or the names in their genealogies. For example:

Hezron was the son of Perez.

Perez’s son was Hezron, (T4T)

the father of: In some cases, the father mentioned in genealogies was not the actual father, but an ancestor. If in your language it is possible to use a word that could mean either father or grandfather (or even great-grandfather), it would be good to use that word here.

Ruth 4:19**Section 4:18–22: A list of David’s ancestors**

This section contains a list of the family line from Perez through Obed to King David. Five names represent all the generations from Perez, the son of Judah, to Nahshon, who lived at the time of Moses, about four hundred years after Perez. The names of the next five generations represent all the generations from Nahshon to David, who lived about 450 years later. Clearly, many names have been left out of the list.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ancestors of David

Obed in the Genealogy of David (NET)

The list of the ancestors of King David

The names in this listing agree with the lists in 1 Chronicles chapter 2, Matthew chapter 1, and Luke chapter 3. If you have already translated any of these books, refer to the way you transliterated the names there.

4:19a**Hezron was the father of Ram,**

- Hezron was the father of Ram.
- Hezron fathered Ram. (ESV)
- Ram was the son of Hezron.

4:19b**Ram was the father of Amminadab,**

- Ram was the father of Amminadab.
- Ram fathered Amminadab. (ESV)
- Amminadab was the son of Ram.

4:19

Hezron was the father of Ram: From 1 Chronicles 2:9, it appears that Ram was the second son of Hezron. Nothing else is known about him other than what is mentioned in this verse.

Ram was the father of Amminadab: Aaron, Moses’ brother, had married one of Amminadab’s daughters, according to Exodus 6:23.

Hezron was closely related to Perez, and Amminadab lived at about the same time as Aaron and Moses, who lived many years later. So it is likely that in this first group of five names, some generation names were left out between Hezron and Ram, and/or between Ram and Amminadab.

Ruth 4:20**Section 4:18–22: A list of David’s ancestors**

This section contains a list of the family line from Perez through Obed to King David. Five names represent all the generations from Perez, the son of Judah, to Nahshon, who lived at the time of Moses, about four hundred years after Perez. The names of the next five generations represent all the generations from Nahshon to David, who lived about 450 years later. Clearly, many names have been left out of the list.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ancestors of David

Obed in the Genealogy of David (NET)

The list of the ancestors of King David

The names in this listing agree with the lists in 1 Chronicles chapter 2, Matthew chapter 1, and Luke chapter 3. If you have already translated any of these books, refer to the way you transliterated the names there.

4:20a

Amminadab was the father of Nahshon,

- Amminadab was the father of Nahshon.
- Amminadab fathered Nahshon. (ESV)
- Nahshon was the son of Amminadab.

4:20b

Nahshon was the father of Salmon,

- Nahshon was the father of Salmon.
- Nahshon fathered Salmon. (ESV)
- Salmon was the son of Nahshon.

4:20

Amminadab was the father of Nahshon: Nahshon was an important person who lived at the time of Moses. He was the tribal chief for the tribe of Judah (Numbers 1:7, 2:3). When the leaders of Israel dedicated the tabernacle, he was the first one to offer an offering (Numbers 7:12).

Nahshon was the father of Salmon: Scholars know little about Salmon. His name is spelled differently in 1 Chronicles 2:11, but the two spellings are probably just variations of the same name.

Ruth 4:21

Section 4:18–22: A list of David's ancestors

This section contains a list of the family line from Perez through Obed to King David. Five names represent all the generations from Perez, the son of Judah, to Nahshon, who lived at the time of Moses, about four hundred years after Perez. The names of the next five generations represent all the generations from Nahshon to David, who lived about 450 years later. Clearly, many names have been left out of the list.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ancestors of David

Obed in the Genealogy of David (NET)

The list of the ancestors of King David

The names in this listing agree with the lists in 1 Chronicles chapter 2, Matthew chapter 1, and Luke chapter 3. If you have already translated any of these books, refer to the way you transliterated the names there.

4:21a

Salmon was the father of Boaz,

- Salmon was the father of Boaz.
- Salmon fathered Boaz. (ESV)
- Boaz was the son of Salmon.

4:21b

Boaz was the father of Obed,

- Boaz was the father of Obed.
- Boaz fathered Obed. (ESV)
- Obed was the son of Boaz.

4:21

Salmon was the father of Boaz: Salmon may have been an ancestor rather than the father of Boaz. Other details given in the OT about the lives of Boaz, Obed, Jesse, and David suggest that there are no extra generations between any of them. However, the length of time between Nahshon and Boaz makes it likely that several generations were not listed. Matthew 1:5 records that Salmon married Rahab, who lived in Joshua's time, when the Israelites were entering Canaan.

Boaz was the father of Obed: Obed's birth is described in 4:13–17, but nothing more is written in the Bible about his life after that.

Ruth 4:22

Section 4:18–22: A list of David's ancestors

This section contains a list of the family line from Perez through Obed to King David. Five names represent all the generations from Perez, the son of Judah, to Nahshon, who lived at the time of Moses, about four hundred years after Perez. The names of the next five generations represent all the generations from Nahshon to David, who lived about 450 years later. Clearly, many names have been left out of the list.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The ancestors of David

Obed in the Genealogy of David (NET)

The list of the ancestors of King David

The names in this listing agree with the lists in 1 Chronicles chapter 2, Matthew chapter 1, and Luke chapter 3. If you have already translated any of these books, refer to the way you transliterated the names there.

4:22a

Obed was the father of Jesse,

- Obed was the father of Jesse,
- Obed fathered Jesse, (ESV)
- Jesse was the son of Obed,

4:22b

and Jesse was the father of David.

- and Jesse was the father of David.
- and Jesse fathered David. (ESV)
- and King David was the son of Jesse.

4:22

Obed was the father of Jesse: Jesse is mentioned quite a few times in the Scriptures, primarily in connection with his famous son, David.

and Jesse was the father of David: The book of Ruth ends with the name of David. He was Israel's most famous king and an ancestor of the Lord Jesus Christ. If your readers do not know that David was a king of Israel, it may be helpful to supply that information, either in the text or a footnote. Then your readers will understand why this genealogy is important and how Ruth was part of it.

Jesse's son was the father of King David. (T4T)

King David was Jesse's son.